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● **THE 3RD INDIA-NORDIC Summit** will be held in Oslo. It is set to impart a more strategic dimension to India's ties with Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Sweden and Norway.

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INDIA AND SWEDEN: DELIVERING GROWTH, RESILIENCE AND SUSTAINABILITY

By PM NARENDRA MODI AND SWEDEN PM ULF KRISTERSSON

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TWISHA CASE HINGES ON CONTRASTING ACCOUNTS, WHATSAPP MESSAGES [PAGE 3](#)

ELON MUSK LOSES LAWSUIT AGAINST OPENAI AND ITS CEO SAM ALTMAN [PAGE 14](#)

MANESAR PROTESTS

'Demanding higher wages not an offence': Court grants bail to union leader

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, May 18

AGURGAON court on Monday granted bail to a union leader who was arrested in connection with the April 9 labour unrest in Manesar, saying he had been kept in "illegal custody" as there was "nothing incriminating" against him.

The workers in Manesar in Gurgaon district were protesting for higher wages. Days later, similar demands by factory workers in Noida descended into violence and vandalism, leading to a string of arrests by the UP Police.

Gurgaon Additional Sessions Judge Dr Gagan Geet Kaur passed the order in the bail plea filed by Ajit Singh, the general secretary of the employees' union at Belsonica, an auto parts company in Manesar.

"The applicant-accused, who is stated to be a member of the workers' union, has raised the issue of less salary in a democratic way and nothing incriminating has been shown against him," the judge said.

"Making a demand to raise their wages/ salary by workers/ employees to the government is not an offence," said the court.

The prosecution had based its case on the gravity of the alleged offences committed during the protest at Richa Global Exports Pvt Ltd at the Industrial Model Township (IMT)

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● **WAS EMPLOYED AT CONSTRUCTION COMPANY IN MOSCOW SINCE DECEMBER 2024**

Latest casualty of Ukraine-Russia war, Odisha man was helping rebuild home

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, May 18

THIRTY-YEAR-OLD Anjarana Ramaya from Odisha's Ganjam district had been working with a construction company in Moscow for over a year, sending money back home to help his family renovate and expand their modest house. He had been back home recently, reaching in time for Maha Shivratri celebrations and staying until March 22. The youngest of four siblings, he

GRANTS BAIL TO J&K RESIDENT IN UAPA CASE

'Bail the rule': SC questions its own order in Umar Khalid case

Cites 3-judge order in 2021: UAPA bail provisions will 'melt down' in case of prolonged incarceration, delayed trial

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, May 18

CITING AN earlier judgment that the stringent bail provisions under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) would "melt down" in cases where prolonged incarceration and delayed trial "produce reservations" about the decision of another two-judge bench to deny bail to Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam in the 2020 Delhi



Umar Khalid, Sharjeel Imam were denied bail in Delhi riots case

riots case.

The bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan made these observations while granting bail to a resident of

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Different SC benches, different rulings on bail under stringent UAPA

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, May 18

IN GRANTING bail to a Kashmiri man in an alleged narco-terror case, the Supreme Court on Monday underlined a plurality of judicial approaches in the top court, with different benches taking distinct perspectives on the fraught question of whether bail restrictions under the stringent Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA)

can prevail over constitutional safeguards.

"If the smaller benches are unable to agree with the ratio laid down by the larger bench, then the proper and the only course of action open is to make a reference to the Hon'ble Chief Justice of India for placing the matter for consideration by a still larger bench. Being in a combination of two Judges, we are bound by the ratio laid down by the three-Judge bench in

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



India eyes trade pact with Oman amid turmoil, FTA starts June 1

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, May 18

AMID THE Strait of Hormuz blockade and uncertainty over peace talks between Iran and the US, the Commerce and Industry Ministry Monday said the India-Oman free trade agreement (FTA) signed in December could enter into force as early as June 1.

The likely implementation, within months of signing, comes as Delhi pushes for faster operationalisation of the deal since Omani ports, mainly Salalah and Duqm, fall outside the Strait and could help India reroute exports for West Asia and Africa.

Commerce Ministry officials said several meetings have been held with exporters to explore opportunities for pushing food and other low-margin, labour-intensive products, given Oman's geographic advantage during the current crisis.

While Oman's annual demand is limited, the pact offers a transit window. Officials said that only two UAE ports, Khor

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Taking charge in Kerala

Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi congratulates Congress leader V D Satheesan after he was sworn in as Kerala Chief Minister, in Thiruvananthapuram, Monday. Twenty Cabinet ministers of the UDF government also took oath. [PTI](#) [PAGE 6](#)

Bengal govt ends religion-based welfare schemes, scraps OBC list

Announces Rs 3,000 per month, free bus rides for women

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, May 18

THE WEST Bengal BJP government on Monday held its second Cabinet meeting under the leadership of Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, where it took several key decisions including on a monthly assistance of Rs 3,000 to women under the Annapurna Bhandar scheme and free travel for women in all



Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari in Kolkata, Monday. EXPRESS

state-run buses.

The Cabinet also decided to discontinue all welfare schemes based on religious classification. After the meeting, minister Agnimitra Paul said assistance schemes run by the Information and Culture Department and the Minority Affairs and Madrasa Education Department would be stopped from next month. A detailed notification

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

ADANIS TO PAY \$18 MN TO U.S. SEC

US clean chit for Adani after Iran deal, offer to invest \$10 bn

Goes for \$275-mn settlement on Iran sanctions

George Mathew
Mumbai, May 18

THE DONALD Trump-led US administration moved to dismiss criminal fraud charges against Gautam Adani on Monday, while also settling alleged Iran sanctions violations involving his flagship Adani Enterprises, according to court records.

The US Department of Justice permanently dropped all criminal charges against Gautam Adani and his nephew Sagar Adani, bringing high-profile securities and wire fraud case in New York to a complete close after prosecutors concluded they could not sustain the allegations.

With this, multiple US regulatory and legal investigations involving the group have all closed in the last couple of days. The New York Times had last week reported that Adani's attorney Robert Giuffra Jr, who is also a personal attorney of US



Gautam Adani

President Donald Trump, had in a presentation said Adani wanted to invest \$10 billion in the United States but could not do so because of the cases.

Adani had been accused of agreeing to pay \$265 million in bribes to Indian government officials so Adani Group could win approval to develop the country's largest solar power plant. The Adani Group has consistently denied wrongdoing. Adani is the company's founder and chairman.

Earlier on Monday, Adani Enterprises Ltd entered into an agreement with the US Department of Treasury's Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) by paying an amount of \$275 million to settle its potential civil liability for apparent violations of OFAC sanctions on Iran.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Latur coaching centre founder held, got NEET papers 10 days before exam: CBI to court



Shivraj Motegaonkar at the Rouse Avenue Court in New Delhi on Monday. ANI

Vallabh Ozarkar, Mahender Singh Manral & Nirbhay Thakur
Mumbai, New Delhi, May 18

MARKING ITS tenth arrest in the NEET-UG paper leak case, the CBI has taken into custody Shivraj Motegaonkar, founder of Latur-based RCC Classes, alleging that he received the leaked question papers and answers as early as April 23 — 10 days before the May 3 exam, placing one of Maharashtra's best-known coaching figures at the centre of the case.

Motegaonkar was arrested on Sunday, the same day a CBI team searched the premises of

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NTA CHIEF TO APPEAR BEFORE HOUSE PANEL

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MUTUAL FUND INVESTMENTS ARE SUBJECT TO MARKET RISKS, READ ALL SCHEME RELATED DOCUMENTS CAREFULLY.



Dairy protest

Dairy farmers spill milk outside the Deputy Commissioner's office in Amritsar on Monday to protest against the sale of adulterated milk and cheese. PTI

Bhopal 'love jihad' assault: Police say accused not linked to right-wing groups

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, May 18

POLICE HAVE said they have not found links with the Bajrang Dal, or that to any right-wing organisation, so far of the seven held in connection with the beating up of a 29-year-old inside a hotel in Bhopal recently, on charges of "love jihad".

Of the seven held, one is a juvenile, Govindpura SHO Awadhesh Singh Tomar said, identifying the others as Brijendra Prajapati, Prateek Chouksey, Lalaram Meena, Ramesh, Ajay and Aman. "Representatives of right-wing organisations have informed that they are a disciplined organisation and these individuals are not their members," the SHO said.

The Muslim youth has been arrested since, over old allegations pending for some years. SHO Tomar said: "He was recently released from jail and we found was involved in two cases of mobile phone thefts. After this came to light, we arrested him."

A video had surfaced of the youth being assaulted, stripped, having his face smeared with cow dung, and being paraded on the streets, after he met with a Hindu friend at a hotel. Both had testified that they were at the hotel voluntarily, and had refused to file a complaint. The FIR on the basis of which seven persons have been held was filed by a local social worker, Mohammad Uwais Rahmani, who said he was disturbed by the video, and who spoke to the Muslim youth at the police station. Incidentally, what the 29-year-old youth reportedly told Rahmani was initially registered as a complaint in the former's name. DCP (Bhopal) Vikas Kumar Sehwal said

they had "rectified" the same. Rahmani said the youth told him that he had come to the hotel to meet his woman friend, and was beaten up only because he is Muslim, was "falsely accused of love jihad" and subjected to "indecent behaviour". Rahmani said, "I do not know the youth... My complaint was on the sentiments of the Muslim community being hurt."

The youth said that "some persons, who identified themselves as associated with Bajrang Dal, stopped me because I am Muslim". "They behaved in an extremely inhuman manner with me by forcibly stripping me, smearing black paint on my face, applying cow dung and publicly humiliating me." It alleges the accused gathered a crowd and recorded videos while "raising objectionable slogans against my religion, seriously hurting the religious sentiments of both myself and the Muslim community". "When I opposed them, the accused paraded me in a public place, assaulted me and threatened to kill me," Rahmani's complaint states, quoting the youth.

The victim suffered "physical injuries and extreme mental trauma" and the incident had created "an atmosphere of fear and insecurity" for him and his family, the complaint says. Videos of the incident were circulated on social media and carried by news platforms. "The acts of the accused are not only a serious attack on my fundamental rights and dignity, but also against the spirit of the Constitution," the complaint says. It adds that the incident has caused "deep anger within the Muslim community" and could affect the city's social atmosphere.

'Sexual exploitation' of woman inmate in Ranchi jail raises political storm, BJP alleges cover-up

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, May 18

THE ALLEGED sexual exploitation of a woman inmate at Ranchi's Birsu Munda Central Jail has kicked up a political storm in Jharkhand, with Leader of Opposition Babulal Marandi accusing state officials of a cover-up and demanding an independent probe into the allegations.

In a letter to Chief Minister Hemant Soren, Marandi alleged that a woman inmate inside the Ranchi jail had been subjected to "continuous mental and physical exploitation" by the jail superintendent and had subsequently become pregnant. Calling the allegations a "grave institutional crime", Marandi alleged that senior prison officials, including the Inspector General (Prisons), were trying to shield the accused and suppress evidence related, as well as accused the state administration of trying to suppress the matter.

Marandi also alleged that the pregnant inmate was being repeatedly taken outside the jail premises to hospitals and undisclosed locations under the guise of medical treatment in a "bid to destroy biological and forensic evidence". He claimed that key witnesses and prison staff aware of the alleged incident had been transferred or removed overnight to prevent information from leaking. Calls and texts to the jail superintendent and the Inspector General (Prisons) went unanswered. However, sources said, the alleged inci-

dent came to the prison administration's notice in April. Supporting Marandi's letter, BJP women spokesperson Rafiya Naz termed the alleged incident "shameful" and that the administration was trying to hide it. "We support Babulal Marandi and want strict action against all officials involved in the incident, from the SP level to the IG."

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, BJP Mahila Morcha state chief Arti Singh said, "It is a serious matter that a woman inmate had to face such an incident inside a jail. This raises questions over security arrangements and the seriousness of the government towards women in the state." Singh alleged that the absence of a functional State Women's Commission reflected the "carelessness" of the government. "There is no Mahila Aayog in the state and many files related to women's issues are pending. We do not know why it has not been constituted yet."

Responding to the claims, Jharkhand Mukti Morcha spokesperson and general secretary Supriyo Bhattacharya said that a probe would provide a clearer picture and that "action would be taken accordingly".

For his part, Ranchi Deputy Commissioner Manjunath Bhanjra said that the district administration became aware of the matter only after reports surfaced in the media and the Opposition raised the issue. "Whatever allegations have been made, the facts need to be properly verified and ascertained."

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Adani

This settlement — the second such agreement in the US — is without admitting the allegations made by OFAC, AEL said in an exchange filing. "Pursuant to the settlement agreement, the company has undertaken to pay the settlement amount of \$ 275 million to OFAC mitigated from the maximum statutory penalty of \$384 million," it said.

Last week, the US Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) had gone for final consent judgments against Gautam Adani and Sagar Adani, whom it had earlier accused of making false and misleading statements linked to a 2021 bond offering by Adani Green Energy Ltd. If approved by the court, Gautam Adani and Sagar Adani would have to pay civil monetary penalties of \$6 million and \$12 million, respectively.

According to OFAC, from November 2023 to June 2025, AEL purchased shipments of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) from a Dubai-based trader purporting to supply Omani and Iraqi gas. Red flags should have put AEL on notice that the LPG actually originated from Iran, OFAC said in a statement.

During this time period, AEL caused US financial institutions to process 32 US dollar-denominated payments totalling approximately \$192,104,044 for the shipments, OFAC said. "The settlement amount reflects OFAC's determination that AEL's apparent violations were egregious and not voluntarily self-disclosed and further reflects the AEL's remedial measures following discovery of the conduct and the cooperation AEL provided for OFAC's investigation," OFAC said.

In June 2023, AEL entered the liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) market by importing LPG

and selling to customers in India. However, neither AEL nor any of its affiliates had, prior to this time, traded LPG on their own account through Mundra Port. "None of the parties involved in AEL's LPG imports were sanctioned at the time of the LPG shipments, and none of the documentation provided to AEL contained any information explicitly pointing to Iranian origin of the LPG. However, AEL and APSEZ sanctions compliance programme did not include other measures to account for risks arising from its dealings," it said.

OFAC said from the earliest days of the relationship, a number of red flags called into question the true source of the Dubai supplier's cargo. On at least four separate occasions between March 2023 and February 2024, AEL learned of third-party concerns that cargos supplied by the Dubai Supplier may have originated in Iran, OFAC said.

Manesar

Manesar, including attempt to murder, rioting, and obstruction. The management had alleged that 200-250 protesting workers pelted company managers and police with stones, and set company and government vehicles on fire.

The public prosecutor conceded that Singh was not present at the spot on the day of the violence. However, police alleged that he had hatched a conspiracy and incited workers before the incident through messages posted in a WhatsApp group and a public speech.

However, the electronic evidence presented by police failed

to convince the court. When the investigating officer played a video of Singh's speech, the judge found it had "nothing incriminating except an address in the form of appeal to problems facing by workers due to less wages compared to rising prices of daily needs".

After the prosecution conceded that a subsequent transcription of a speech from April 4 also contained nothing incriminating, the judge ruled that keeping Singh in jail since April 13 without any prima facie evidence amounted to illegal custody.

"No evidence has been shown to arrest him and he has been in custody since 13.04.2026. This amounts to illegal custody...", the court said.

NEET leak

RCC Classes in Latur, after being questioned by the agency for the second time in a week. On Monday, he was remanded in CBI custody for nine days.

In its remand application filed in a Delhi court, the CBI said the leaked questions were allegedly found on Motegaonkar's phone. "He distributed copies of the leaked papers and answer sheets to multiple persons. There is a video where he is seen in his coaching centre saying that the questions which he gave to the students were there in the final question paper. His links with co-accused Prahlad Kulkarni are under investigation," the agency told the court.

Opposing the application, counsel for the accused said the allegation that he was in possession of an actual question paper was false, and that he merely had questions used by his students for mock tests. "The accused has been in the field of teaching for about 27 years and

had sufficient data of questions," the counsel said.

The CBI, however, alleged that Motegaonkar was an "active member" of an organised network involved in leaking and circulating NEET-UG 2026 question papers before the examination. He allegedly conspired with public servants associated with the National Testing Agency (NTA) and other accused to obtain the leaked papers and answers, supplied handwritten copies to several persons, and later destroyed evidence, the agency said.

The CBI is learnt to be examining a set of 42 chemistry questions the institute circulated before the examination as "guess questions", after alleged similarities were found between those and portions of the leaked NEET paper.

According to the CBI, Motegaonkar was allegedly a close friend of Kulkarni, the retired teacher who was "associated with NTA" and arrested from Pune last week. "Searches conducted at his (Motegaonkar's) institute and residence resulted

Bengal

will be issued soon, she added.

Sources in the Minority Affairs Department said allowances for imams, muezzins and purohits introduced during the Mamata Banerjee government's tenure would be discontinued with immediate effect.

Paul said women currently receiving benefits under Lakshmi Bhandar will be shifted to the Annapurna Bhandar scheme through direct bank transfers. She added that those who have not yet enrolled would be able to apply once the portal opens on June 1. Applicants under the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) process and

"AEL acted recklessly and had reason to know of the Apparent Violations due to the presence of red flags pointing to potential links to Iran. These included warnings received from third parties that LPG cargos being imported by AEL may have been of Iranian origin, and the economic, commercial, and logistical implausibility of the cargos' origin and pricing," it said.

On the mitigating factors, OFAC said AEL provided substantial cooperation to OFAC, including by conducting a thorough, independent internal investigation on an expedited basis and at substantial cost, responding promptly to OFAC's requests for information, and providing large volumes of data regarding the Apparent Violations. "AEL has implemented significant remedial measures to respond to the Apparent Violations, including ceasing imports of LPG into India...", it said.

those who have approached tribunals will also be eligible for the scheme, she said.

Another major decision taken at the meeting was the cancellation of the existing OBC reservation list with immediate effect. The Cabinet decided to revise reservation percentages for OBCs in jobs and government posts, review the state OBC list and abolish sub-categories. "There will be a fresh enquiry. The state government will take a decision on the groups proposed to be merged as per the High Court order," Paul said.

The minister also announced that the government had decided to constitute the Seventh Pay Commission, fulfilling a key BJP poll promise.

Chemistry and began teaching the subject to students preparing for board and entrance exams. In his early years, local residents said, he travelled by bicycle giving home tuitions. Around 1999, he started his own coaching class from rented premises with 10 students, teaching in small batches with handwritten notes.

"I was in his 2001 batch. At that time, there were only around 40 students in Latur. Now there are over 15,000 students in Latur itself," said one of his oldest students.

Over two decades, RCC (Renukai Career Centre) grew into one of Maharashtra's biggest coaching brands for NEET, JEE and CET preparation. It now operates centres in Latur, Pune, Nashik, Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar, Nanded, Solapur, Kolhapur and Akola, with around 40,000 students enrolling annually. Fees range between Rs 50,000 and Rs 65,000 per student. Widely known as "Msir" in coaching circles, Motegaonkar has been described by former students as "a guru".

Abbas Araghchi also said Iran was coordinating with Oman on the future management of the Strait.

Under the FTA, Oman has offered zero-duty access for Indian goods on 98% of its tariff lines. Oman largely exports crude oil, liquefied natural gas, fertilisers, and chemical inputs such as methyl alcohol and anhydrous ammonia, along with petroleum coke. Indian exports to Oman, largely consisting of machinery and parts, have doubled in the last five years from \$3 billion to \$6 billion. New Delhi's top exports, apart from naphtha and petrol, include machinery, aircraft, rice, iron and steel articles, beauty and personal care products, and ceramics.

Currently, only 15.33% of India's export value and 11.34% of tariff lines (2022–24 average) enter the Omani market at zero duty under the Most Favoured Nation (MFN) regime. Under the CEPA, Indian exports to Oman that earlier faced duties of up to

5%, valued at around \$3.64 billion, are expected to gain significantly from improved price competitiveness, the ministry had said at the time of signing in December.

The ministry had also pointed to Oman's electronics imports, worth \$3 billion in 2024, against India's exports of just \$123 million, indicating clear scope for expansion. Key import segments include smartphones, photovoltaic cells, telecom instruments and parts, boards and cabinets for electric control or distribution, and static converters.

"India already exports smartphones, static converters, and boards and cabinets, with a relatively stronger presence in the latter two. Import duties are already zero for most electronics, and under the trade deal, remaining items — boards and cabinets, static converters, and television reception apparatus — also move to zero duty, improving tariff certainty," the ministry had said.

brother, Ganesh.

Ramaya left for Moscow and joined the company in December 2024. The family was aware of the continuing conflict between Russia and Ukraine, but after reaching Moscow, Ramaya assured them that everything was normal there. "He used to say there was nothing to worry about as the place where he was working was not that volatile," said Ganesh.

Ramaya's plan was to work for a few years in Russia and save enough money to return to Odisha and start a business, the brother said. In the meantime, he was sending money back home for the construction of another floor on top of the fam-

ily's existing house. The construction, however, was still at a nascent stage when the tragedy of Ramaya's death struck the family.

The family is now urging the government to take steps to bring his mortal remains back to India, and to arrange some form of compensation for his parents.

Ganjam District Collector V Keerthi Vasani said the administration was in touch with the Resident Commissioner's office in New Delhi and the Indian Embassy in Moscow on this. He said the Resident Commissioner's office has initiated action through diplomatic channels, and that efforts are being made to bring Ramaya's remains back.

Bail the rule: SC

Jammu and Kashmir, Syed Ifthikar Andrabi, in custody since 2020. Andrabi faces charges under the UAPA in a narco-terror case investigated by the National Investigation Agency (NIA).

Saying that bail is the rule and jail an exception even in UAPA cases, the bench said it is a constitutional principle flowing from Articles 21 and 22, and the presumption of innocence is the cornerstone of any civilised society governed by the rule of law.

The bench pointed out that in the *Union of India vs K A Najeer* case in 2021, a three-judge bench of the court had held that violation of a fundamental right like right to speedy trial can be a ground for grant of bail even under a stringent law like the UAPA. The bench had then upheld the bail granted to an accused jailed since April 2015 for alleged involvement in chopping the hand of a Kerala professor in 2010.

"Therefore, the caution of Najeer (case) is that continued incarceration cannot go unabated by a mere discharge by the State of the prima facie standard under Section 43-D(5) (which lays down stringent conditions for grant of bail under UAPA). The judgment explicitly held that Section 43-D(5) will 'melt down' where prolonged incarceration and delayed trial produce a violation of Article 21. The constitutional inquiry in Najeer therefore operated independent of, and notwithstanding, the statutory embargo of Section 43-D(5) in the realm of constitutional principles," the bench said.

However, in two subsequent judgments by separate two-judge benches — *Gurwinder Singh vs State of Punjab* (February 2024) and *Gulfisha Fatima vs State (NCT of Delhi)* (January 5, 2026) — the court took a somewhat divergent view "from the clear, distinctive trajectory it had earlier followed," the bench said.

In the *Gulfisha Fatima vs State* case, an SC bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and N V Anjaria had granted bail to five other accused in the Delhi riots conspiracy case, but denied relief to Khalid and Imam, saying they stood on a "higher footing in the hierarchy of participation". The court had observed that prolonged incarceration cannot be an "absolute entitlement" to seek bail in terror cases.

"This court is satisfied that the prosecution material taken on face value as required at this stage discloses a prima facie attribution of a central and formative role by appellants... Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam are in the alleged conspiracy. The material suggests involvement at the level of planning, mobilisation, and strategic direction extending beyond episodic or localised acts. The statutory threshold under Section 43(D)(5) of the UAPA, therefore, stands attracted qua these appellants," the bench had said.

On April 16 this year, the SC had dismissed review petitions against this decision.

"We have serious reservations on various aspects of the judgment in the *Gulfisha*

Fatima case, including foreclosing the right of the two appellants to seek bail for a period of one year... The judgment in the *Gulfisha Fatima* case would have us believe that Najeer is only a narrow and exceptional departure from Section 43-D(5) justified in extreme factual situations. It is this hollowing out of the import of the observations in the Najeer case that we are concerned with," the bench said on Monday.

In the case of Gurwinder Singh, accused in a UAPA case of Sikh separatism, the SC, while rejecting the bail plea, had said that relief could be denied if accusations appear to be prima facie true and in such situations, bail would be an exception and jail the norm.

On Monday, Justice Bhuyan, writing for the bench, said: "We make it clear that K A Najeer is the binding law and entitled to the protection of stare decisis. It cannot be diluted, circumvented, or disregarded by the trial court, the High Court, or even by benches of lower strength of this court."

The doctrine of stare decisis requires courts to follow established legal precedents so as to ensure consistency, fairness and predictability.

"A judgment rendered by a bench of lesser strength is bound by the law declared by the bench of greater strength. Judicial discipline mandates that such a binding precedent must either be followed or, in case of doubt, be referred to a larger bench. A smaller bench cannot dilute, circumvent or disregard the ratio of a larger bench," the court said.

In the current case, the bench directed that Andrabi be released on bail, subject to conditions as the NIA court may deem fit. He had earlier been denied bail by the NIA court and the Jammu and Kashmir High Court.

Andrabi was accused of having links with Pakistan-based handlers of the Lashkar-e-Toiba and Hizbul Mujahideen, and involvement in a cross-border narcotics smuggling racket to fund terrorist activities in India. Andrabi's counsel had contended that though the chargesheet was filed on December 5, 2020, the trial was moving slowly, and over 350 prosecution witnesses were yet to be examined.

Justifying its decision to grant bail to Andrabi, the SC cited statistics on low conviction rates in UAPA cases. "It is evident that the country-wide percentage of conviction under the UAPA for... 2019-23 hovers between 2% to 6%. In other words, there is 94% to 98% possibility of acquittal in such cases... When it comes to the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir, the percentage of conviction is abysmal, to say the least. For the aforesaid period, the annual rate of conviction is always less than 1%. It means that at the end of the trial, there is 99% possibility of acquittal in such cases," it said.

"With these kinds of statistics staring at our face, the question is, should we continue the detention of the appellant or defer the consideration to a later stage, simply because the charges are serious," it said.

Different rulings

K A Najeer. We say this and no more," the bench comprising Justices B V Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan said in the 102-page ruling.

The court's concern stems from the line of precedents it examined on whether the rigours of Section 43(D)(5) of the UAPA — which restricts the grant of bail — would "melt down" where prolonged incarceration and delayed trial lead to a violation of Article 21 of the Constitution.

The 2021 ruling by a three-judge bench headed by then Chief Justice of India N V Ramana establishes the "good law" to be followed on this issue. The court had said that an accused under trial suffering long incarceration with no end in sight to the criminal trial must be enlarged on bail. The court had then examined the most consequential ruling on bail in UAPA cases — the 2019 ruling in *NIA v Zahoor Ahmed Shah Watali*. A two-judge bench in the Watali case had held that courts must accept the state's case without examining its merits while considering bail pleas under the UAPA.

"The caution of Najeer is that

continued incarceration cannot go unabated by a mere discharge by the State of the prima facie standard under Section 43-D(5)," the SC said on Monday, underlining that the Najeer ruling would prevail over the Watali ruling. Apart from the structural reasoning, procedurally too, Najeer is a later judgment by a larger bench.

Judicial discipline and certainty demand that benches of smaller strength are mindful of the decisions rendered by larger benches and are bound to follow the same. However, in a polyvocal court, where multiple benches of two and three judges comprise the Supreme Court, these norms are often diluted.

In a 2024 ruling in *Gurwinder Singh v. State of Punjab*, a two-judge bench cautioned against "mechanical" invocation of delay to seek bail, suggesting bail should only be considered if it also satisfies the test under Section 43(D)(5) of UAPA.

In January 2026, another two-judge bench also side-stepped the Najeer precedent, holding that the accused in the Northeast Delhi riots case had not "crossed the constitutional threshold" of delay to seek bail.

ED arrests AAP leader; raids in Delhi, Goa

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, May 18

THE ENFORCEMENT Directorate (ED) Monday arrested AAP leader Deepak Singla from Delhi in connection with an alleged money laundering case linked to a Rs 150-crore bank fraud.

AAP has rejected the allegations against Singla and accused the BJP-led Centre of using investigative agencies to target leaders of Opposition parties ahead of the Assembly election set to be held in Goa early next year.

Singla was taken into custody after the ED conducted searches at premises linked to him and other alleged hawala operators in Delhi and Goa on



Deepak Singla

Monday. ED sources said that among the locations searched was a flat in Dona Paula near Panaji, where some from AAP's organisation team reside.

The sources said the money laundering case pertains to a bank loan fraud in which Singla, along with some members of his family, are accused of defrauding the Oriental Bank of Com-

merce of more than Rs 150 crore. ED officials alleged that Singla is suspected of "handling the hawala operations" for the movement of funds for the party between Delhi and Goa.

Officials claimed the money was allegedly sent to "controlled firms in Singapore".

"It is also suspected that such proceeds of crime are routed back to India through the hawala route, to be infused back in illegal activities. In relation to this PMLA fraud, Singla was arrested," an ED source said.

Singla, AAP's Goa co-in-charge, contested the Delhi Assembly elections from Vishwas Nagar constituency in 2020 and 2025. In 2024, the ED had conducted searches at his residence

in connection with the case.

AAP stated that the action against Singla was similar to the ED and CBI crackdowns in Bengal and Punjab. AAP alleged that the BJP was "selectively" targeting leaders who refused to join the party.

In a post on X, AAP convener Arvind Kejriwal said, "Deepak Singla has not been arrested because he did anything wrong. He has been arrested because he was working against the BJP and refused to join the BJP. Deepak Singla is brave and is fighting for the country."

AAP Goa in-charge and Delhi Assembly LoP Atishi said Singla was arrested "because he was building an organisation in Goa to fight against the BJP".

APP WON'T WORK, NO SUPPORT' 10 Gurgaon teachers booked for 'failing' to perform Census duty

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, May 18

TEN GOVERNMENT enumerators have been booked in two FIRs by the Gurgaon Police for alleged negligence during the ongoing National Census 2027 operations by "failing" to perform their assigned duties and "obstructing" official government work. Several of them, however, flagged lack of support and issues with the app.



Census enumerators during a survey. FILE

The first FIR was registered at the Gurgaon City police station late Sunday on a complaint filed by Rajesh Yadav, Charge Officer Census-cum Zonal Taxation Officer-III of the Municipal Corporation Gurugram (MCG). It names five enumerators — Sandeep, Hansraj, Kuldeep, Rajesh Kumar, and Amit Kumar — all government school teachers.

The second FIR was lodged on Monday at same police station based on a complaint filed by Zonal Taxation Officer Dinesh Kumar against government school teachers Ravita Yadav, Jagmati, Sunil Kumar, Sunil, and Daisy Sharma.

Speaking with *The Indian Express*, Amit Kumar, who teaches at a school in DLF Phase 1, said there has been no support from the top (his supervisor) regarding help in Census work.

"I attended the training programmes. They only send messages on the WhatsApp group and never come with us on the field. I have to cover 85 homes in my area, but the app does not work...", he said.

Amit also said he has not received any notice from the police. "I could not make data entries because of software issues and was told I will be pulled up for it. Several teachers are facing such issues, they have sent show-cause notices to over 150," he added. The others were not available for comment.

The case has been registered

Two die, one critical in separate road accidents within 30 hrs in Capital

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 18

TWO PERSONS were killed and another sustained critical injuries in two separate road accidents, which took place within 30 hours of each other in South-west and East Delhi, Delhi Police said on Monday.

The first accident came to light around 2 am on Sunday after a PCR call regarding a crash near 31 Block, Nala Road, in Southwest Delhi was received at Mayur Vihar police station, officers said. Soon, a police team reached the spot and found that a collision had occurred between a motorcycle and an autorickshaw, they added.

The deceased was identified as Kapil (40), a resident of Trilokpuri, police said. According to the police, Kapil was travelling in the autorickshaw.

The man riding the motorcycle was identified as Satyam (25), also a resident of Trilokpuri. Kapil was declared dead by doctors at LBS Hospital, while Satyam sustained critical injuries and was referred to GTB Hospital for further treatment, police officers added.

Police said that footage from CCTV cameras installed in

nearby areas is being analysed as part of the investigation.

Since Satyam was declared unfit to give a statement, legal action was initiated on the basis of medical evidence and available facts, officers added.

According to the police, a case under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita sections 281 (rash or negligent driving), 125A (endangering life or personal safety), 106 (causing death by negligence) has been registered at Mayur Vihar police station.

Driver of offending vehicle at large

The second accident happened around 6 am on Monday near Aruna Asaf Ali Road in Southwest Delhi, after an unidentified vehicle hit a pedestrian and fled the scene, police said.

The deceased has been identified as Rohit (20) a resident of Mehrauli and a BSc student. He was declared dead by doctors at Fortis Hospital in Vasant Kunj, police said.

A case under various sections of the BNS has been registered at Kishangarh police station. Investigation is underway to identify the offending vehicle and trace eyewitnesses, officers said.

BHOPAL COURT DENIES ANTICIPATORY BAIL TO HUSBAND Twisha case hinges on contrasting accounts, WhatsApp messages

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, May 18

OBSERVING THAT Noida resident Twisha Sharma's death occurred within six months of marriage under "unnatural circumstances", a sessions court in Bhopal said that it "does not appear appropriate to grant anticipatory bail" to her husband, Samarth Singh.



Friends and family of Twisha Sharma staged a protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Monday. AMIT MEHRA

Singh is allegedly absconding. His mother, retired judge Giribala Singh, is also an accused in the alleged dowry demand and death case, and was granted anticipatory bail earlier.

Additional Sessions Judge Pallavi Dwivedi, while rejecting Samarth's plea, noted that the FIR, witness statements and WhatsApp chats placed on record indicated that the "main allegations" were against him.

As per the bail order, Twisha and Samarth got married on December 9, 2025, in Delhi after meeting through a matrimonial website. Before marriage, Twisha had worked as an actor and model. At the time of her marriage, she was employed with a private firm in Delhi.

The order records sharply divergent versions of the marriage from the two sides.

Samarth, in his anticipatory bail plea, said Twisha had repeatedly travelled between Bhopal and Delhi-Noida after marriage and that tensions emerged after she got pregnant in April. The defence said Twisha was distressed after learning of the pregnancy and did not want to continue "the role of a housewife". It also raised questions on her mental health and accused her of drug abuse.

The complainant's side, however, alleged that Twisha was harassed for dowry and pressured into terminating her pregnancy. The objections filed before the court alleged that Samarth and his mother repeatedly taunted Twisha, questioned the paternity of her

unborn child, and forced her to undergo an abortion. The family also alleged that she was physically assaulted by her husband on several occasions.

According to the prosecution's objections cited in the order, Twisha's family had paid Rs 2 lakh after alleged dowry demands from the accused. The objections stated that on May 12, Twisha made several phone calls to her family members shortly before her death.

The court order reconstructs Twisha's final hours largely through the version presented by the defence. According to the application, on May 12, Twisha visited a beauty parlour near her house and went for a walk before returning home around 7.30 pm. After watching TV for about an hour, she spoke to her parents over the phone. Around 10.15 pm, her mother allegedly called the family asking them to check on her. Samarth's family claimed they found Twisha hanging from an iron rod on the terrace using an exercise resistance band. The defences said attempts were made to loosen the noose and administer CPR before she was taken to a hospital.

Twisha's family, however, has disputed that narrative and alleged that she had been under severe mental distress because of sustained harassment in her matrimonial home. In objections before the court, the family said Twisha had called them in

fear on the night of her death and that they lost contact with her around 10.35 pm. The family alleged that Samarth later told them over the phone that "she is no longer in this world".

Her family presented WhatsApp messages in court, where, on May 9, she purportedly wrote, "*Maa aap mujhe ya sha selenee jao kal please* (Please come and take me from here tomorrow)." She allegedly told her mother that it appeared her husband no longer needed her and had merely been "tolerating" her for a year. On April 30, she allegedly described her life as "*narak* (hell)". "*Kyun bheja mujhe yaha? Ye yaha baat hi nahi kar raha hai* (Why did you send me here? He is not even talking to me)," she purportedly wrote.

The defence rejected the allegations in court. Advocate Enosh George Carlo, appearing for Samarth, argued that the alleged dowry demand itself was inconsistent. The defence also challenged the authenticity of WhatsApp chats.

Twisha's father, Navnidhi Sharma, meanwhile, accused the police of delaying action and shielding an influential family. "Why should the body have been handed over when the case is suspicious? The post-mortem report and evidence do not match," he alleged while demanding a second autopsy and a Supreme Court-monitored investigation.

Relatives seek transfer of case to Delhi



Twisha Sharma

Upasika Singhal
New Delhi, May 18

A HANDFUL of Twisha Sharma's friends, family and well-wishers, makeshift protest boards in their hands, gathered on a Monday afternoon at Delhi's Jantar Mantar.

Priyanka Sharma, her cousin, told *The Indian Express*, "We have seen these things happen before and Twisha would always tell me that there is always a solution, that suicide is not an answer... she was such a cheerful and carefree soul."

Twisha was found dead at her matrimonial home in Bhopal on May 12. The protesters said they want the case transferred to Delhi and another post-mortem in AIIMS Delhi.

Samira, a friend of Twisha, claimed, "Two months before the wedding, she told me that her in-laws had asked her to remove all her pictures from social media. She removed everything, but since she's a model, some of her pictures were published by other outlets."

After the wedding, Samira said, "We kept texting and calling her, but she wouldn't respond. Her last text to me was 'I'll call you later, busy right now.'"

Meanwhile, Twisha's mother-in-law, Giribala Singh, a retired district judge who is an accused in a case, addressed mediapersons in Bhopal on Monday. She claimed Twisha had mental health issues, which she linked to being "pushed into the glamorous world at a young age".

Singh also alleged that her position had instead worked against her family: "Being a district judge is a curse; a common man can get bail. Because I am a retired district judge, there is no question."

PUBLIC NOTICE
FUNDAMENTUM INVESTMENT ADVISORS LLP
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Notice is hereby given that Fundamentum Investment Advisors LLP ("FIA LLP") is in the process of surrendering its Certificate of Registration as a "Co-Investment Portfolio Manager" bearing Registration No. **INP000008172**, granted by the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"), on **June 28, 2023**, under the SEBI (Portfolio Managers) Regulations, 2020.
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For Fundamentum Investment Advisors LLP
Sd/- Sanjay Chaturvedi (Authorised Signatory)
Place: Gurugram Date: [a] May, 2026

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
JAWAHARLAL NEHRU KRISHI VISHWA VIDYALAYA, JABALPUR
E-TENDER NOTICE
No. E.E./Tender /2026/227 Dated - 18/05/2026
Online E-Tender are invited from puter Manufacturers/ Dealers/ Registered Contractors of CPWD/State Govt. PWD/ PSUs in India for the work titled as "**Establishment of Speed Breeding Facility at JNKVV, Jabalpur, (MP) on EPC turnkey basis.**". The detailed of items and tender document can be seen and purchase on mptenders.gov.in website by payment of Rs. 15,000/-. The Purchase Start 19/05/2026 at 10:30 AM to 08/06/2026 at 06:00 PM, Bid submission end date 08/06/2026 at 06:00 PM, last date of submission of tender document (Hard copy) 12/06/2026 05:00 PM, Date of opening of the tender 15/06/2026. If any amendment or change is made in the tender after publication of e-tender, it will be available only on the above mentioned e-tender portal.
Sd/- Executive Engineer
IPRO/EE/2026/68

FLAME UNIVERSITY
Name of the trust / institution
FOUNDATION FOR LIBERAL AND MANAGEMENT EDUCATION SOCIETY
Name of the institution and address: FLAME University
Gat No. 1270, Taluka Mulshi, Village Lavale, Vadzai, Dist. Pune - 412115
For the Academic Year 2026-27 applications are invited for filling Jain religious/linguistic minority seats from the eligible students for the B.A./B.Sc./BBA/BBM/Communications Management /B.Des/MBA/ MBA/Communications Management /PGPE/IM.Sc.(Economics), PhD and Hons. courses of FLAME University.
Time table for admission procedure of Jain Minority Educational Institution:

1. Last Date of Application	June 21, 2026
2. Date of Publication of Merit List	July 13, 2026
3. Date of Admission	August 10, 2026

Application for admission will be available online after payment of Rs. 2,000/- by Cash / DD / Credit Card / Debit Card.
Website: www.flame.edu.in, Email: admission@flame.edu.in
Tel No.: 1-800-209-4567
Registrar, FLAME University
FLAME University has been established as a state private university vide the FLAME University Act 2014 (Maharashtra Act No. 11 of 2015), now Maharashtra Private Universities (Establishment and Regulation) Act, 2023 (Mah. Act No. VIII of 2024) of the Government of Maharashtra, India. FLAME University is recognized by the University Grants Commission (UGC) of India under Section 2(f), and degrees awarded by the FLAME University are recognized under Section 22 of the UGC Act, 1956.

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Last date of submission of application by the applicant is by 15:00 hours on
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Last date of forwarding of applications by the Nodal officers to PESB is by 17:00 hours on
15/06/2026
For details login to website
<https://www.pesb.gov.in>

ऑयल एण्ड नेचुरल गैस कॉर्पोरेशन लिमिटेड
Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd.
Regd. Office: Plot No. 5A-5B, Nelson Mandela Marg, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi- 110070
CIN: L74899DL1993GOI054155
Website: [www.ONGCINDIA.COM](http://www ONGCINDIA.COM) | Email: secretariat@ONGC.CO.IN
PUBLIC NOTICE FOR ISSUANCE OF ENTITLEMENT LETTER
NOTICE is hereby given that the undermentioned Equity Share Certificate(s), representing shares of face value of ₹5/- each, have been reported lost/misplaced by the following shareholder to the Company. The said shares have already been transferred to the Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF) Authority:

Name of Share holder	Folio No.	No. of Shares	Share Certificate Number	Distinctive Nos.
SHRI SURESH KUMAR SINGH	40762	1536 1536 3072	6298 969110	3802489-3804024 8558180088-8558181623

A request has been lodged by Shri Suresh Kumar Singh for claiming these shares from IEPF Authority. Any person(s) who has/have any claim in respect of the said certificate(s) can lodge his claim along with supporting documents to the Company within 10 days of the publication of this notice, after which no claim will be entertained by the Company and an Entitlement Letter will be issued in lieu of above mentioned shares.
Further, public is hereby warned against purchasing or dealing in any way with the above mentioned share certificate(s). Any person dealing with the above share certificate(s) shall be doing so, solely at his/her risk as to costs and consequences, the Company shall in no way be held responsible for such dealing(s). This notice is issued in compliance with the requirements of the IEPF (Accounting, Audit, Transfer and Refund) Rules, 2016, for Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd.
Sd/-
(Shashi Bhushan Singh)
Company Secretary
New Delhi 18.05.2026
For further details, please visit ONGC <https://www.ONGCINDIA.COM>

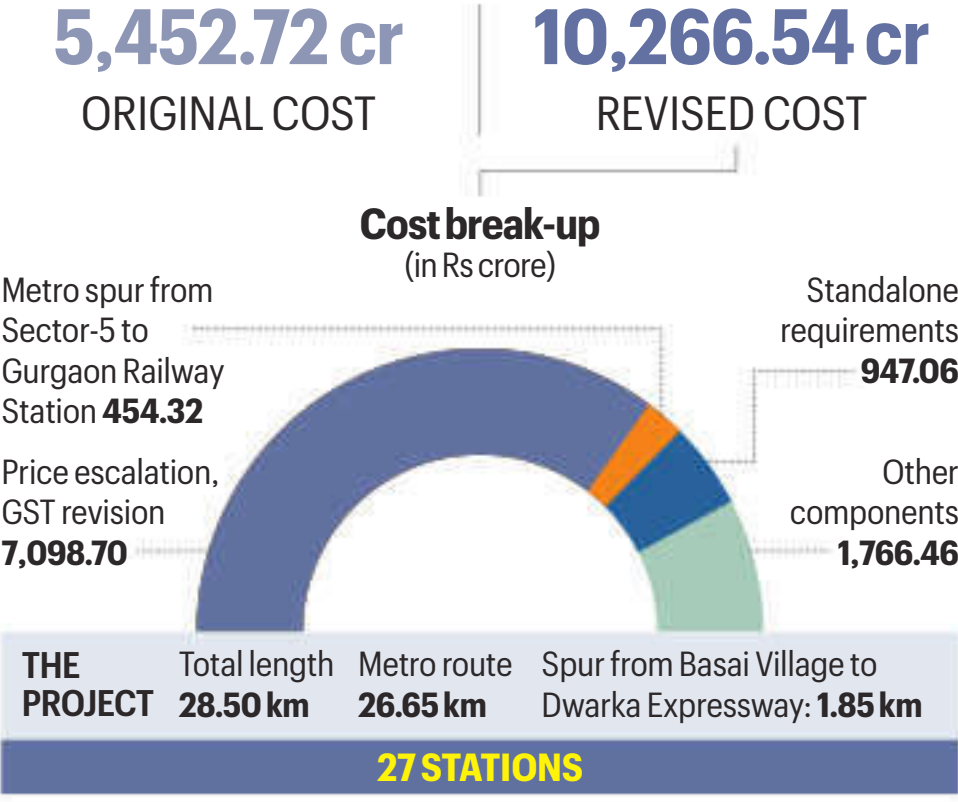
No. A-35018/01/2023-Admn.III
Union Public Service Commission
Dholpur House, Shahjahan Road
New Delhi-110069
Date: 30.04.2026
VACANCY CIRCULAR
Subject: Engagement of a Consultant (Chief Estates Manager & Meeting Officer) in the office of UPSC.
It is proposed to engage a Consultant (Chief Estates Manager & Meeting Officer) in the office of UPSC from the retired Central Government Servants.
2. The details like General conditions, Eligibility Criteria, Age limit, proforma of application form etc. are available on the website of UPSC i.e. <http://www.upsc.gov.in/vacancy-circulars>.
Sd/-
(Aparna Srivastava)
Under Secretary (Admn.II)
Union Public Service Commission
Tel. No.: 011-23388476
CBC-55103/11/0005/2627

RERA Registration Number : DLRERA2022P0011
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HARYANA CABINET DECISIONS

Gurgaon Metro project cost nearly doubles to Rs 10,266 cr

● MILLENNIUM CITY CENTRE TO CYBER CITY



Express News Service
Chandigarh, May 18

THE HARYANA Cabinet on Monday approved Rs 10,266.54 crore as revised project cost for the Millennium City Centre to Cyber City corridor of the Gurgaon Metro, nearly double from the original sanctioned cost of Rs 5,452.72 crore in 2020.

The corridor will serve major residential and commercial corridors, including Sector 45, Cyber Park, Subhash Chowk, Hero Honda Chowk, Sector 10, Basai, Palam Vihar, and Udyog Vihar. Residents of Dwarka Expressway, will also see a station at Sector 101, benefiting commuters of the many high-rises located there.

"The approval marks a significant milestone towards strengthening urban mobility infrastructure in Gurgaon and accelerating implementation of the much-awaited Metro connectivity project from Millennium City Centre to Cyber City," an official spokesperson said.

The detailed project report (DPR) for the corridor, covering a length of 28.50 km with 27 stations, was originally approved by the Haryana Cabinet on August 13, 2020 and subsequently by the Union government.

The spokesperson attributed the project cost to "price in-

crease between 2019 and 2023, revised GST rates, additional infrastructure requirements, changes in alignment planning, and expanded project scope including depot facilities, rolling stock, and a new Metro spur to Gurgaon railway station".

The revised structure includes Rs 7,098.70 crore towards price escalation and GST revision, Rs 947.06 crore for additional standalone corridor requirements, and Rs 454.32 crore for construction of the Metro spur from Sector 5 to Gurgaon railway station.

Further, the Cabinet approved supplementary reports related to Gurgaon Metro's integration with Rapid Metro and Gurgaon railway station spur, and the proposal for funding of the soft loan portion of the project through the World Bank.

It cleared supplementary report on the Metro's integration with Rapid Metro, which includes provisions for development of a depot and facilities spread over 22.86 hectares of government land in Sector 33.

It also approved the supplementary report regarding the proposed 1.8-km spur from Sector 5 station to Gurgaon station. Moreover, it approved the proposal for funding the entire soft loan component of the project through the World Bank.

No petrol, diesel vehicles for cab aggregators, delivery partners

Express News Service
Chandigarh, May 18

THE HARYANA Cabinet on Monday cleared the rules for grant of aggregator licences making it mandatory for aggregators, delivery service providers and e-commerce firms in the NCR districts, including Gurgaon and Faridabad, to induct only green vehicles.

They include CNG, EVs, battery-operated vehicles (BOV) or those that run on any other cleaner fuel. Also, only CNG or electric 3-wheelers will be

allowed to be additionally inducted into existing fleets in the NCR.

"Under the amended rules, all vehicles inducted in the fleet of aggregators, delivery service providers and e-commerce entities in NCR areas from January 1, 2026 onwards will mandatorily be CNG, EVs, BOVs or based on any other cleaner fuel," an official spokesperson said.

The decision has been taken to promote clean mobility, curb vehicular pollution and improve air quality, he said.



The demolition of Nirman Bhawan, among the buildings constructed in the 1950s and 1960s, was completed last week. EXPRESS

Central Vista: Nirman Bhawan demolished, Udyog Bhawan next

Damini Nath
New Delhi, May 18

THE DEMOLITION of Nirman Bhawan — which was among the Central government office buildings constructed in the 1950s and 1960s — was completed last week, making it the first of the ministerial complexes to be knocked down for the Central Vista redevelopment project, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Until July-August last year, Nirman Bhawan used to house the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Ministry of Housing & Urban Affairs (MoHUA), and

the CPWD. These have since been relocated — the health ministry to Kartavya Bhavan, MoHUA to Sankalp Bhawan, and CPWD to multiple buildings in the Capital.

As of Monday, government sources said, the site was cleared of all office buildings, but an electricity sub-station of the NDMC is yet to be relocated from the plot.

While the proposed demolition of the neighbouring Udyog Bhawan is yet to start, the machinery is in place and the work is expected to begin soon.

As part of the government's Central Vista revamp, a 10-

building Common Central Secretariat (CCS) is being constructed to house all Union ministries. Three of the 10 buildings have been completed so far.

The site of Nirman Bhawan and the adjoining Udyog Bhawan will be used to construct CCS 8 and CCS 9. The CPWD had allotted the work to Ahluwalia Contracts (India) Ltd. in January this year, accepting a bid of Rs 3,069.70 crore. The project was to be completed in 21 months. The new buildings will be seven floors each, as per the CPWD's tender document.

Started in 2019, the MoHUA's Central Vista redevelop-

ment project has so far seen the completion of three CCS buildings, which were named Kartavya Bhavan last year, the new Parliament building, the Vice-President's Enclave and the Prime Minister's Office complex, named Seva Teerth.

Construction or planning of the remaining seven CCS buildings is underway. As per the CPWD's plan, the government office buildings that were constructed post-Independence — including Nirman Bhawan, Udyog Bhawan, Krishi Bhawan and Shastri Bhawan — are to be demolished to make way for the new CCS buildings.

KIN ALLEGE DOWRY HARASSMENT

Woman dies by suicide in Greater Noida; husband, father-in-law held

Drishti Jain
Greater Noida, May 18

A 24-YEAR-OLD woman allegedly jumped to death from the terrace of her in-laws' residence in Greater Noida on Sunday, police said. A day later, scores of people thronged the house where her parents live.

As per her family, the deceased, Deepika, was being harassed by her in-laws for dowry, police said, adding that her husband and father-in-law have been arrested.

On Monday, while trying to console Deepika's mother and elder sister, a woman said: "They (in-laws) could have just dropped her at her parents' house last night." Another murmured: "Why kill her?"

Deepika, who hailed from Jalpura in Greater Noida, got married to Ritik a year-and-a-half ago.

DCP (Central Noida) Shailendra Kumar Singh said officers at Ecotech 3 police station were informed about the incident on Sunday night. "Based on a complaint filed by the woman's family, an FIR was registered. The woman's husband and father-in-law have been arrested," Singh said.

The FIR was lodged under sections 85 (husband or relative of husband of a woman subjecting her to cruelty) and 80(2) (dowry death) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and the Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961.

Deepika's elder sister, Sarika



Deepika died on Sunday.

(28), said the deceased never told her anything about any major fight at her in-laws' house. "There were small fights, which are common in any household."

However, Sarika said, she has been under a lot of pressure recently. "Her feet were hurting. She grew weak after two abortions... But her mother-in-law would make her do all the household chores."

Sarika also said that she spoke with Deepika twice on Sunday. "She told me in the morning that her mother-in-law had scolded her... How could a 24-year-old manage the entire house? But she was still doing it all alone... Later around 11 pm, I got on a call with her again. She told me she was tired and wanted to rest."

Sarika said their father had gone to Deepika's in-laws' house on Sunday to meet one of their relatives who was unwell. The father returned home around midnight. Deepika's in-laws, Sarika said, called them around 1 am informing them about the incident.

"I don't know what hap-

pened... but she was not someone who would take such a decision," Sarika said.

Deepika and Ritik got married in December 2024. According to neighbours, the wedding was grand — one they still remember.

The sister said the family spent over Rs 1 crore on the wedding. Deepika was an Integrated BA B.Ed graduate and the youngest of three siblings. "We gave a Mahindra Scorpio N SUV, cash, over 20 tolas of gold, 14 earrings to Ritik's relatives, and furniture. Her in-laws did not like the bed and my father sent another. I have the entire list," she said, adding that despite all that, her mother-in-law kept taunting and boasting how much they spent on their daughter's wedding.

"Before Karva Chauth in October last year, the family started asking for more 'gifts'," Sarika said. "We thought that the family was good, but had it been so, my sister would have been alive."

The mother is still in shock. "Meri laado ko koi wapas le aao. Kuchh bhilelo, par wapas le aao (Please bring my beloved daughter back. Take anything you want, but bring her back)."

Police said that the body of was sent for a post-mortem examination.

"The viscera has been preserved for chemical analysis," said an officer. "Further investigation and proceedings are underway," DCP Singh said.

HC transfers Rohini district judge after viral video of heated debate

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, May 18

THE DELHI High Court Sunday transferred Rohini court district judge Rakesh Kumar V after a video of him in a heated exchange with the Bar association president went viral. He has been attached with the Director of the Delhi Judicial Academy "in diverted capacity".

The transfer comes even as the Judicial Service Association of Delhi on Sunday said that it "unequivocally stands in complete solidarity" with the district judge and "all judicial officers are discharging their duties with integrity, independence and courage".

The HC order follows a demand for transfer, withdrawal of judicial work and an inquiry, by the All District Court Bar Associations, Delhi. The bar associations announced that their members shall abstain from work on Monday.

The Delhi HC order was issued through the Delhi HC registrar general Arun Bhardwaj.

Judicial officer Dheeraj Mittal, Additional Director at Delhi Judicial Academy, will take charge of Judge Kumar's court in Rohini, as a district judge in "diverted capacity".

Meanwhile, the Judicial Service Association, Delhi, has expressed its "strongest condemnation and profound anguish over the shocking incident involving the illegal recording and deliberate circulation of video clips relating to court proceedings conducted by Shri Rakesh Kumar V". It has requested the Delhi HC to pass "necessary directions for deletion of said video clips from social media platforms".

It also objected to the "clandestine recording of judicial proceedings and making the same viral on social media platforms" as not only "an act of gross impropriety, but a direct assault on the dignity, independence and majesty of the judicial institution". It termed it to be aimed at subjecting judicial officers to "unwarranted intimidation, vilification and public pressure".

However, the Coordination Committee of All District Court Bar Associations, Delhi, termed district judge Kumar's conduct as "highly objectionable and unbecoming" towards the advocate, who is also the President of the Rohini Court Bar Association.

CONTEMPT CASE AGAINST KEJRIWAL TO COME UP BEFORE DIVISION BENCH

CBI plea in liquor 'scam' case to be heard by Justice Manoj Jain today

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, May 18

MATTERS RELATING to the Delhi excise policy case that were being heard in the High Court by Justice Swarna Kanta Sharma have now been listed before Justice Manoj Jain. They are expected to be taken up on Tuesday.

Justice Sharma said last week that she would no longer hear the alleged 'liquor scam' matter, and initiated suo motu criminal contempt proceedings against seven AAP leaders for publishing "contemptuous material" against her and the judiciary on social media.

In her 68-page order passed on May 14, Justice Sharma named AAP national convener and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal, former Delhi Deputy CM Manish Sisodia, former AAP MLAs Durgesh Pathak and Vinay Mishra, AAP Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh, president of the AAP's Delhi unit Saurabh Bharadwaj, and Devesh Vishwakarma, who is said to be involved in the AAP's social media operations.

The allegedly contemptuous posts were made after Justice Sharma refused to recuse from hearing the pleas filed by the CBI and ED in the excise policy case.

While transferring the cases out of her court, Justice Sharma had clarified that the transfer "should not be understood as this court transferring the matter merely because demands for recusal were made which were rejected by a detailed order...".

CBI's revision plea challenging the discharge of the 23 accused in the case by a trial court in February, is pending before the HC. The ED has sought the expungement of alleged adverse remarks made against the agency by the trial court.

While the pleas by the CBI and ED will be heard by Justice

Manoj Jain, the suo motu contempt proceedings will be heard by a Division Bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dudeja, also on Tuesday.

According to the current roster, Justice Jain deals with criminal matters, including pleas for bail, criminal appeals of the year 2026, and cases relating to sexual harassment.

As per instructions on the administrative side of the Delhi HC, all criminal revision petitions of the year 2021 pending before the Bench of Justice Sharma, except criminal cases relating to sitting/ former Members of Parliament and Members of Legislative Assembly, are heard by Justice Manoj Jain.

Justice Jain joined the Delhi Judicial Service in 1992, and was promoted to the Delhi Higher Judicial Service in 2003. He was Director (Academics) at the Delhi Judicial Academy and Registrar General of the HC before he was sworn in as an additional judge in May 2023. He was made a permanent judge in July 2024.

Justice Jain has presided over civil, criminal, and family law cases, and is no stranger to cases involving political leaders. He is currently hearing a challenge by Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief Lalu Prasad against a trial court's order framing corruption and criminal conspiracy charges against him and members of his family in the alleged land-for-jobs scam.

Justice Jain was part of a Division Bench led by Justice Suresh Kait in the Delhi HC that heard the bail pleas of the accused in the larger conspiracy case in the 2020 Northeast Delhi riots.

As a single judge, he was hearing a plea by businessman Robert Vadra challenging the charges framed against him and issuing summons to him in a case of alleged money laundering in a 2008 Gurgaon land deal.

Metro Monday

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta shows Delhi Metro card, as she travels along with Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh to promote 'Metro Monday' initiative in New Delhi. AMIT MEHRA



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta shows Delhi Metro card, as she travels along with Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh to promote 'Metro Monday' initiative in New Delhi. AMIT MEHRA

As temperatures soar, power demand peaks

New Delhi: The peak power demand in the national capital soared to 7,542 megawatts (MW), the highest so far this summer, as the day temperature rose to 43.4 degrees Celsius on Monday.

The IMD has predicted a four-day heatwave conditions in the Capital beginning Tuesday, when the maximum temperature is likely rise to 44 degrees Celsius.

Real-time data from the State Load Dispatch Centre in Delhi showed the peak demand at 7,542 MW at 4.05 pm on Monday. The peak demand on Sunday was 7,094 MW. This year, the peak power demand in Delhi is estimated to cross 9,000 MW.

The highest peak demand in 2025 was recorded at 8,442 MW on June 12. The all-time high in peak power demand in the Capital was 8,656 MW, recorded on June 19, 2024. Discoms say the rise in power demand in summer is pushed up primarily by enhanced use of coolers, air conditioners and refrigeration appliances. PTI

● 'BRINGING DISREPUTE TO DEPARTMENT,' SAYS CIRCULAR

Delhi Police pulls the plug on cops' 'reel' culture

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, May 18

THE SOCIAL media era has seen even Delhi Police personnel actively joining platforms like Instagram and Facebook, sharing lip-sync clips to stylised reels — often in uniform. However, the trend has raised concern within the force, with the Delhi Police Headquarters flagging "serious breaches" of social media rules.

An internal communication, issued by the PRO, Additional CP Rajiv Ranjan to deputy commissioners of police across Delhi earlier this month, refers to an SOP issued in August 2023 that lays down norms for online conduct of police personnel. Despite this, police said, instances have emerged where

officers both on and off duty have been uploading videos deemed inappropriate while wearing the uniform.

According to the communication, such actions are not merely a technical violation of rules but risk "bringing disrepute to the department." Sources indicated that a list of identified personnel has been shared internally, with instructions to take necessary action.

While the department has not publicly commented on the scale of violations, officers acknowledged that the rise of reels and video on social media platforms has changed how individuals, including those in uniform, engage with the public.

A senior officer said the concern is less about presence on social media and more about



The circular emphasises stricter enforcement of existing guidelines.

context. "The uniform is not just attire; it represents authority and public trust. Its use in casual or inappropriate content can dilute that perception."

The circular stops short of announcing sweeping punitive measures. Instead, it emphasises stricter enforcement of existing guidelines. District heads have been asked to ensure compliance, initiate disciplinary action in cases of violation, and conduct repeated sensitisation sessions for their staff. "The challenge is to allow individual expression without compromising institutional dignity," a senior officer said.

The internal communication comes in the wake of several reels and short videos created by police personnel garnering thousands of followers.

One such account belongs to an officer who regularly posts content related to fitness, diet and lifestyle while dressed in the Delhi Police uniform. Besides, there are multiple instances where officers have shared videos from within police station premises. These include clips of personnel escorting accused individuals in court complexes or inside police stations.

At the same time, officers noted that not all such content is inappropriate.

"Some reels created by police personnel are educational in nature, offering guidance on how to prepare for and crack competitive examinations to join the forces. Others simply follow ongoing social media trends without any official intent," said an officer.



For United Front

AT THE swearing-in ceremony of the Congress-led UDF government in Thiruvananthapuram, Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi was seen reaching out to each and every section of the state party unit. He hugged V D Satheesan immediately after the latter took oath as CM. When Satheesan was about to take his seat, Gandhi whispered something in his ears and the CM hurriedly walked up to Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge and greeted him. Gandhi also hugged Ramesh Chennithala, senior leader who was one of the frontrunners for the CM post but took oath as the Home Minister. Party insiders said Gandhi was ensuring that Chennithala, who had worked with Rajiv Gandhi and Indira Gandhi, was not upset about not getting the top post.

Fresh Start

THE JAL Shakti Ministry has emerged as the first central department to move swiftly in engaging with the newly elected BJP government in West Bengal. On Monday, Union Jal Shakti Minister C R Patil and CM Suwendu Adhikari signed an MoU for implementation of Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0 via videoconferencing. The development is being viewed as significant as several other Union ministries are also preparing to revive and fast-track projects and welfare programmes that had remained stalled in West Bengal for a considerable period.

Language No Bar

UNION MINISTER Jyotiraditya Scindia made full use of his proficiency in conversational Nepali while picking tea leaves with plantation workers at Sikkim's Namchi during his recent three-day visit to the state. Scindia, married to Priyadarshini Raj Scindia who traces her lineage to Nepalese royalty, conversed with workers and appreciated their skill in swiftly identifying and plucking the two leaves and one bud variety, while trying his hand at plucking the leaves himself.

Suwendu aide murder: Key accused arrested

New Delhi: The CBI on Monday arrested Raj Kumar Singh, believed to be a key accused in the murder of West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari's aide Chandrakant Rath, officials said Monday. Singh, alias Raj Singh, was arrested from Muzaffargarh in UP, they said. **PTI**

Satheesan takes charge, free bus ride for women gets Cabinet nod

Department for elderly, hike in allowance of ASHA workers also announced

Shajuh Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, May 18

HAVING STEERED the Congress-led UDF back to power in Kerala after a decade by unseating the Left Front, V D Satheesan took oath as Chief Minister on Monday at a packed ceremony held at the Central Stadium.

His 20-member Cabinet, featuring a mix of experienced leaders and new entrants, was also sworn in by Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar. Senior Congress leader Ramesh Chennithala, who was seen as one of the contenders for the top job, was among those inducted.

Apart from Chennithala, the other experienced face in the Cabinet is IUML minister P K Kunhalikutty, who has been part of all the UDF Cabinets since 1991.

RSP leader Shibu Baby John and Communist Marxist Party (CMP) nominee C P John, both representing the Left politics in the UDF, took their oath of of-



Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar administers the oath of office to Kerala CM V D Satheesan in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday. **PTI**

fice by solemn affirmation. Unlike in 2011, IUML ministers did not wear the white cap while taking the oath of office. Kerala Congress leader Mons Joseph, Kerala Congress (Jacob) leader Anoop Jacob, and John were also sworn in as ministers to loud cheers from the crowd.

The ceremony was attended, among others, by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi, Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah and Deputy CM D K Shivakumar, Telangana CM Revanth Reddy, Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvir Singh Sukhu, Congress's Wayanad MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, and Congress general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal, who was also one of the contenders for the CM post.

Others on the dais were former CM Pinarayi Vijayan and leaders of the UDF and LDF allies.

Soon after the swearing-in ceremony, Satheesan chaired his first Cabinet meeting.

Following the meeting, the government announced free bus travel for women in the state-run Kerala state transport corporation, starting June 15; the formation of a department for the aged citizens; an increase in the allowance of ASHA workers; a white paper on the state finances; and the decision to re-investigate the alleged attack on Youth Congress workers in Alappuzha in 2023 by the security staff of then CM Vijayan during the latter's Nava Kerala Yatra.

On the department for the

• New Cabinet: Veterans, dynasts, debutants

CONGRESS

RAMESH CHENNITHALA (will turn 70 later this month)
K MURALEEDHARAN, 69
SUNNY JOSEPH, 73
P C VISHNUNADH, 48
BINDU KRISHNA, 58
T SIDDIQUE, 51
A P ANIL KUMAR, 61
O J JANEESH, 37
K A THULASI, 51
ROJIM JOHN, 43
M LIJU, 46

IUML

P K KUNHALIKUTTY, 74
N SAMSUDHEEN, 56
K M SHAJI, 54
P K BASHEER, 66
V E ABDUL GAFOOR, 49
OTHERS
C P JOHN, 69 (Communist Marxist Party)
MONS JOSEPH, 61, Kerala Congress (Joseph)
SHIBU BABY JOHN, 63 (RSP)
ANOOP JACOB, 48, Kerala Congress (Jacob)

elderly, the CM said, "This was another guarantee of the UDF. Kerala will be the first state in the country to form a department for the aged. Japan was the first country to implement a special department for the aged. That model will be studied within two months. A society's approach toward its elderly people is one of the key yardsticks by which its level of civilisation is measured. A day will come when Kerala will tell the world how it is taking care of the aged people."

The CM said ASHA workers would now receive Rs 12,000 allowance per month, up from Rs 9,000. "This was our promise to the ASHA workers when they had staged an agitation in front of the state secretariat. I had promised them that when the UDF comes to power, the

first Cabinet will decide in favour of them," Satheesan said.

Satheesan also said the government would increase the monthly remuneration of Anganwadi workers and helpers by Rs 1,000. An additional Rs 1,000 per month would be given to the cooking staff in schools and the honorarium of pre-primary teachers and ayahs (nannies) would also be hiked by Rs 1,000, he added.

The CM said an expert team would look into state's finances and bring out a white paper and that a special investigation team would be set up to look into the alleged attack in Alappuzha. He also announced key decisions related to convening of the new Assembly session on May 21 and 22 for swearing-in and election of Speaker, respectively.

Bengal debt nearly double the threshold; new BJP govt schemes will double expenditure

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, May 18

AS THE Suwendu Adhikari-led BJP government in West Bengal prepares its first Budget, it could be facing a near doubling of the state's expenditure on social welfare schemes if it goes through with the party's pre-poll promises and announcements. These include increasing the monthly assistance to women under the Lakshmi Bhandar scheme, now the Annapurna scheme, and the unemployment allowance, and clearing the Dearness Allowance dues.

If all three are implemented, the expenditure will go up to about Rs 1.29 lakh crore per year. As of now, the state government spends Rs 54,000 crore on Lakshmi Bhandar and unemployment allowance, with the DA dues not paid.

The estimated revenue deficit (expenditure compared to earnings) that West Bengal is looking at in 2026-27 is Rs 21,759 crore, while its debt burden for this financial year is expected to be Rs 8.15 lakh crore.

BJP sources argue since the state government will now work in step with the Centre, with the same party in power in both for the first time, the "double engine" push will help Bengal over the financial bumps.

Under Mamata Banerjee's Lakshmi Bhandar scheme, launched in 2021, women got Rs 1,500 a month, with those from

• EFFECT ON GOVT COFFERS

Lakshmi Bhandar, now called Annapurna Bhandar

2.20 cr
Women beneficiaries

PREVIOUSLY: ₹1,500 monthly; ₹1,700 for SC/ST women

TOTAL EXPENDITURE: ₹39,000 crore annually

CURRENTLY GIVEN BY BJP GOVT: ₹3,000 for all monthly

TOTAL ESTIMATED EXPENDITURE: ₹79,000 crore annually

DEARNESS ALLOWANCE PARITY, ARREARS	
TOTAL BENEFICIARIES	
State govt employees CURRENTLY: Govt is not paying DA arrears, or ensuring parity with Central govt staff BJP PROMISE: Clearance of DA	Pensioners arrears, within 45 days TOTAL ESTIMATED EXPENDITURE: ₹62,000 crore this year.

SC/ST groups entitled to Rs 1,700 each. Around 2.20 crore women are currently enrolled for Lakshmi Bhandar, including 29.45 lakh in SC and 4.78 lakh in ST groups. The BJP government hiked the benefits to Rs 3,000 per month, meaning an expenditure of around Rs 79,000 crore per year (from Rs 39,000 crore now).

The BJP manifesto also promised to increase monthly assistance for unemployed to Rs

Unemployment allowance

84 lakh as of now
Total beneficiaries

CURRENTLY: ₹1,500 monthly

TOTAL EXPENDITURE: ₹15,000 crore annually

BJP PROMISE: ₹3,000 monthly

TOTAL ESTIMATED EXPENDITURE: ₹30,000 crore annually

3,000, apart from providing 1 crore new jobs and self-employment opportunities in the next five years. The TMC government had started its scheme for unemployed youths called Yuba Sathi, entailing Rs 1,500 per beneficiary, just before the Assembly polls, with 84 lakh-odd signing up for it within days.

With the doubling of the amount, the total expenditure on unemployment allowance would go up to around Rs

30,000 crore (from Rs 15,000 crore now).

Another of the BJP's promises was implementation of the Seventh Pay Commission recommendations, and clearance of pending DA arrears, within 45 days of forming the government.

Currently, Central government employees get 60% DA, while for West Bengal staff, the figure is 18%. To ensure DA parity, as the employees have been demanding, West Bengal will have to spend Rs 20,000 crore extra in a year.

In an order on February 5, the Supreme Court directed West Bengal to clear the DA dues in accordance with the Fifth Pay Commission report. That entails payment of around Rs 42,000 crore as one-time compensation to government employees. Together, DA payments alone may add up to Rs 62,000 crore this year.

Other than this, the TMC government had the Kanyasree Prakalpa scheme for girl students (started in 2013), Rupasree Prakalpa for financial help for marriage of a girl (2018), Kri-shak Bandhu for farmers (2019), and several schemes for fishermen in the state, together costing the state Rs 4,000 crore. Some of these will now be subsumed into Central schemes, such as schemes for farmers and fishermen, freeing up a portion of the state's money.

The revenue deficit estimated in the vote-on-account submitted by the TMC govern-

ment ahead of Assembly elections, Rs 21,759 crore, was less than the revised estimation in the 2025-26 budget of Rs 41,164 crore. However, Finance Department officials said an increase in expenditure due to expansion of schemes or payment of DA dues will take this up to Rs 31,000 crore.

Similarly, the vote-on-account debt estimation for 2026-27, at Rs 8 lakh crore-plus, was more than the Rs 7.62 lakh crore in the revised budget for 2025-26. It will go up further now.

States are expected to keep their outstanding debt to around 20% to 25% of the GSDP. In the case of West Bengal, this is around 38%.

A senior Finance Department official said BJP government has taken its state finances into account. "CM Suwendu Adhikari has said all DBT schemes will continue. Naturally, it will increase the revenue deficit and burden on the state exchequer. On the other hand, now those Central government schemes which were stalled during the TMC government will be reintroduced, and money for that will come from the Centre. So Ayushman Bharat will replace Swasthya Sathi, and take that load off the state."

Asked about the expenditure the state is looking at, Chief Secretary Manoj Agarwal said: "We will increase revenue and also decrease unnecessary expenditure. We will sit with finance officers and find a way out."

CASH-AT-HOME ROW

Allegations against Justice Varma: Judges inquiry panel submits report to Speaker Birla



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla receives the Judges Inquiry Committee report in New Delhi on Monday. **PTI**

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 18

THE JUDGES Inquiry Committee investigating allegations against Justice Yashwant Varma submitted its report to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday.

The report, which was presented in accordance with the statutory requirements under the Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968, will be laid before both Houses of Parliament in due course, the Lok Sabha Secretariat stated.

Sources said it would likely be taken up during the Monsoon Session between July and August.

Justice Varma of the Allahabad High Court, who tendered his resignation last month, was facing impeachment proceedings over the alleged discovery of piles of burnt currency notes from his official residence in Delhi following a fire incident in March 2025.

An in-house committee constituted by then CJJI Sanjiv Khanna had concluded that Justice Varma had "active or tacit control" over the specific storeroom where the cash was hidden. In July 2025, over 200 MPs signed a motion to impeach the judge.

In his resignation letter to President Droupadi Murmu and Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justice Varma had ex-

pressed "deep anguish" over his decision.

"While I do not propose to burden your august office with the reasons which have constrained me to submit this missive, it is with deep anguish that I hereby tender my resignation..." he wrote.

Justice Varma had also written to the three-member inquiry committee about formally withdrawing from participation in its proceedings.

"While I do not even for a moment seek to question the expectation that the conduct of judges be examined against standards higher than those that may apply to others, even that would not justify the adoption of standards which result in a deprivation of a reasonable and fair opportunity to defend or a fair trial itself," he had written.

Justice Varma had said given the circumstances, he would be doing the "greatest disservice" to himself and the institution by continuing to participate in the present proceedings.

The three-member Inquiry Committee, comprising Justice Aravind Kumar from Supreme Court, Bombay HC Chief Justice Shree Chandrashekhar and Senior Advocate, Karnataka HC, B V Acharya, was constituted by the Lok Sabha Speaker on August 12, 2025.

Stone-pelting ended in J&K, will stop it in Bengal too: Suwendu after Kolkata violence

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, May 18

A DAY after protests in Kolkata's Park Circus turned violent, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari issued a stern warning to protesters Monday, asserting that just as "stone-pelting was successfully ended in Jammu and Kashmir, it will soon be completely eliminated in West Bengal".

Adhikari's remarks came after he visited the police personnel who were injured during violent protests and alleged stone-pelting at the busy Park Circus Seven-Point crossing on Sunday.

"Anyone can protest. This is a democratic country. Police officers have been told any individual, political group, or religious group can make a demand. They will give a representation and an officer-in-charge and an inspector-in-charge at the police station will meet them. They will be heard, and their queries answered," Adhikari told reporters after meeting with injured policemen near the office of the DCP (Southeast) in Park Circus.

"But a situation where people suddenly resort to stone-pelting while raising religious slogans will simply not be tolerated. Stone-pelting stopped in Jammu and Kashmir after the abrogation of Article 370. I believe it is now time that stone-pelting is brought to an absolute halt in Kolkata and across West Bengal," Adhikari said.

"I came here to support our injured personnel as both the police minister and the CM. The days when policemen were left to get injured while the police minister sat back in an air-conditioned room are over," he said, taking a jibe at the previous TMC government.



West Bengal Minister Agnimitra Paul briefs the press on Monday.

Panels to probe into corruption, atrocities against women during TMC rule, says CM

Kolkata: The West Bengal government on Monday announced two Commissions, led by retired HC judges, to probe into allegations of "institutional corruption" and crimes against women in the state during Mamata Banerjee-led TMC regime. "The Cabinet gave its approval to form two Commissions promised during poll campaign. These will start work from June 1," CM Suwendu Adhikari said. The Commission to investigate "institutional corruption" will be led by retired Calcutta HC judge Justice Biswajit Basu, with ADG-rank IPS officer Jayraman as its member secretary. Regarding the probe into crimes against women and girl child, Adhikari said the Commission will be chaired by retired judge Justice Sampati Chatterjee, with IPS officer Damayanti Sen as member secretary. **ENS**

He said over 40 arrests have been made, so far. Adhikari reiterated zero tolerance for vandalism, saying, "If you think, like in previous government, that the hands of policemen are tied up, you are wrong."

Cong begins UP poll prep, maps winnable seats, outreach

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, May 18

THOUGH THE Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections are scheduled for early next year, the Congress has begun identifying seats it plans to contest and has directed AICC secretaries to submit lists of probable candidates for constituencies the party is likely to seek during seat-sharing talks with ally SP.

The Congress leadership is particularly wary of complications in negotiations after what it views as a "costly experience" in the 2025 Bihar Assembly elections, where delayed seat-sharing talks and "friendly fights" among INDIA bloc allies cost it the elections.

Sources in the party told *The Indian Express* that the AICC general secretary in

charge of UP, Avinash Pande, has asked the six party secretaries in the state to prepare two lists. "The first list will include probable candidates for all 403 Assembly seats, while the second will identify around 100-120 seats with stronger prospects," a source said.

The party has internally classified Uttar Pradesh's 403 Assembly constituencies into three categories: high potential, marginal and weak. "So far, we have identified more than 100 seats in the first category, around 200 in the second, and about 120 in the third," a senior Congress leader said.

An AICC secretary involved in the exercise said feedback was being gathered from local units and aspirants. "We are assessing constituencies and speaking to leaders interested



Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday. **ANI**

in contesting. Most of us are expected to submit our reports to the in-charge in the next few days," the functionary said.

Party insiders said Congress aims to contest around 80 seats as part of an alliance with the SP. We will identify around 100-

Rahul on 2-day visit to Raebareli from today

Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi will visit his parliamentary constituency Raebareli on May 19 and 20, where he is set to address public meetings, interact with women and party workers, and hold Janata Darbars. Thereafter, he will head to Amethi. **ENS**

120 seats where we believe we are competitive and eventually settle for about 80. We also do not want seats where the social combination does not favour us. The focus is on winnable constituencies," a party insider said.

The leadership is also cautious about allowing state-level

functionaries too much influence in the process. "There has to be a balance. No one in the UP unit wants an alliance because it reduces both number of seats and the influence of local leaders. This sentiment was visible in the 2022 Assembly elections when the leadership was persuaded to go solo. We all saw the result," said a senior Congress leader from UP based in Delhi.

In 2022 Assembly polls, Congress contested all 403 seats but won only two, with its vote share dropping to a historic low of 2.33%.

Pande told *The Indian Express* on Sunday that preparations for the 2027 polls began six months ago. "We have identified 2,200 potential candidates for 403 seats," he said.

On the alliance with the SP,

Pande said discussions would begin at an appropriate time.

"Our alliance with SP worked very well in 2024 LS elections in UP. BJP was brought down to 240 seats nationally and below the majority mark because of that alliance. Why should we disturb that arrangement now?" said a senior Congress leader considered close to Gandhi.

Leaders familiar with the party's strategy said the Congress intends to focus on Muslims, Dalits and Brahmins in the run-up to polls.

The role of Wayanad MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, who led the party's 2022 campaign, in campaigning also remains uncertain. Several senior state unit leaders are considered close to Vadra and are awaiting a decision from the leadership.

India and Sweden: Delivering growth, resilience and sustainability... together



NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA

ULF KRISTERSSON
PRIME MINISTER OF SWEDEN

AT A time of growing geopolitical uncertainty, energy insecurity and economic fragmentation, the world faces a defining choice — retreat into narrow national approaches or strengthen partnerships that deliver growth, resilience and sustainability together.

As the United Nations marks its 80th anniversary, the value of international cooperation and multilateralism has become even more evident. At the same time, the need to reform global governance institutions to reflect contemporary realities has become impossible to ignore.

A rules-based international order anchored in international law and sovereign equality has helped create decades of relative stability and development. Yet today's challenges of climate change, industrial transformation, supply-chain disruptions and energy transition require a renewed spirit of practical and inclusive cooperation.

Few challenges are as universal or consequential as climate change. It affects societies and economies across all regions, whether in India, Sweden or elsewhere. But climate action cannot be divorced from development aspirations. Billions of people continue to seek better living standards, jobs, modern infrastructure and energy access. Delivering growth and opportunity while advancing sustainability is therefore not a contradiction, it is the defining economic and political task of our times.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Swedish counterpart Ulf Kristersson in Gothenburg on May 17. PTI

India has emerged as one of the world's fastest-growing major economies while pursuing one of the world's largest renewable energy transitions. The approach is guided by a clear objective: To bridge climate ambition with development realities.

As a major growth engine, and a responsible voice of the Global South, India's two defining milestones for the near future are to achieve 'developed country' status by 2047 and Net Zero emissions by 2070. These domestic goals are deeply intertwined.

Thanks to global cooperation, including the Leadership Group for Industry Transition (LeadIT) and other global platforms that India has formed with the United Nations and international partners — including the International Solar Alliance, the Global Biofuels Alliance and Mission LIFE, India is a responsible voice of the Global South.

Simultaneously, Sweden leads the way in European climate action. Thanks to bold decisions taken decades ago, the electric grid is 98 per cent fossil-free. The contribution of the private sector in innovation and ex-

“Our partnership reflects a shared conviction that industrial transformation can be driven through collaboration between governments, industry, innovators and financial institutions.”

ports of climate-friendly solutions cannot be overstated. All in all, emissions have decreased by more than a third since 1990 — and during this time, the size of Sweden's economy has almost doubled.

The approaches of India and Sweden reflect a broader belief that climate action can create jobs, expand opportunity, strengthen energy security and improve lives. The aim is not only to decarbonise domestic development pathways, but to help build partnerships that make clean industrialisation at scale possible.

It is in this spirit that India

and Sweden met in Gothenburg on May 17. Our partnership reflects a shared conviction that industrial transformation can be driven through collaboration between governments, industry, innovators and financial institutions.

The green transition is not only an environmental imperative, it is also central to competitiveness, economic resilience and long-term growth.

India and Sweden have demonstrated the value of such cooperation through the LeadIT, launched jointly by both countries in 2019 with the support of the United Nations. LeadIT has helped place industrial decarbonisation and hard-to-abate sectors at the centre of the global climate discussion. More importantly, it has shown that developed and developing economies can co-create solutions through trust, innovation and shared responsibility.

Today, however, the scale and urgency of the challenge demand that we move further and faster.

The next phase of LeadIT should move from words to action, meaning implementation at scale. It has proved to be a useful platform for action by accel-

erating technology partnerships, enabling industrial pilot projects, mobilizing sustainable finance, strengthening resilient clean-energy supply chains and building globally competitive low-carbon industries.

The next phase should aim to support workforce transitions, skills development and financial architecture that reduce risk and lower the cost of capital for industrial transformation.

Not every country needs to invent every solution, but every country should have the opportunity to adapt, deploy and scale technologies suited to its developmental circumstances and priorities. Emissions do not recognise borders, and neither can the solutions.

We, therefore, call for a broadening and deepening of this coalition through 2030. We invite more countries, including Nordic partners with strong innovation ecosystems and clean technology leadership, to join and actively contribute to this effort. The industrial transition can succeed only if it can deliver tangible economic value and social progress.

Solar, wind, hydropower, nuclear energy, storage technologies and low-carbon industrial solutions will all have important roles to play depending on national circumstances and priorities.

No country can secure every critical technology, mineral or industrial input alone. Nor can any nation address climate change in isolation. Emissions do not recognise borders — which is why solutions must be international.

The opportunity before us extends far beyond climate policy. It is about shaping a new era of industrial cooperation.

India and Sweden remain committed. At a moment of global uncertainty, our message is clear: Cooperation, rather than fragmentation, will define the pathway to shared prosperity and a sustainable future.

INK PACTS ON SPACE, HEALTH, DIGITAL DEVELOPMENT

India, Norway elevate bilateral ties to Green Strategic Partnership

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, May 18

INDIA AND Norway decided to elevate bilateral ties to “Green Strategic Partnership” and signed pacts on space, health and digital development following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's meeting with Norwegian PM Jonas Gahr Støre in Oslo on Monday.

After the bilateral talks, PM Modi said: “Today, we are giving shape to India-Norway relations as a ‘Green Strategic Partnership.’ Through this strategic partnership — spanning sectors ranging from clean energy to climate resilience, and from the Blue Economy to Green Shipping — our companies will develop global solutions by combining India's scale, speed, and talent with Norway's technology and capital.” Modi met Støre hours after he landed in Oslo from Sweden as part of his four-nation European tour.

The Norwegian PM said, “We are now elevating our relationship to a Green Strategic Partnership, which gives us the foundation to work on knowledge, resources, and ambitions for the green transition, where we depend on succeeding, both of us.” On health cooperation, Støre said, “We are strengthening our cooperation in health; a lot to learn from India. We are signing a memorandum of understanding on developing high-tech quality health services, closer cooperation on digital health, artificial intelligence, research, and health technology. We also deepen our cooperation on digital development, including work on digital public infrastructure and digital public goods.”

On Arctic and space cooperation, Modi said, “Norway is a key nation in the Arctic region. We share a long-standing history of cooperation in Arctic and polar research. We are grateful



PM Narendra Modi with King Harald V as he is conferred the Grand Cross of the Royal Norwegian Order of Merit, in Oslo on Monday. ANI

E. EXPLAINED

Shared belief in rules-based order

AMID ONGOING conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia, both India and Norway extended support to every effort toward an early end to hostilities and the restoration of peace. Both countries firmly believe in a rules-based order, dialogue, and diplomacy, said PM Modi. The two nations also pledged commitment to eliminating terrorism in all its forms.

to Norway for its support in the operations of India's Arctic research station, “Himadri.” The MoU being signed today between ISRO and the Norwegian Space Agency will add new dimensions to our cooperation in the space sector.” “Through deeper cooperation in all these areas, our scientists will contribute to understanding climate change, protecting fragile ecosystems, and securing the future of humanity,” he said.

“As two major maritime nations, we will work together to strengthen cooperation in the marine economy, maritime security, and capacity building. Today, we have concluded a Triangular Development Cooperation Agreement. We will now collaborate to contribute to human development in countries of the Global South through India's Digital Public Infrastructure projects,” PM Modi said.

The two leaders also discussed the geopolitical situation and the conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia. Modi said, “Both India and Norway firmly believe in a rules-based order, dialogue, and diplomacy...” The Norwegian PM said, “Norway and India do not always see eye to eye on all issues. Nobody does. And we are both respectful democracies who handle those issues in ways that live up to democratic standards...”

This is the first visit by an Indian PM to Norway in over 40 years; the last PM to visit Norway was PM Indira Gandhi in 1983. Modi also met King Harald V and Queen Sonja of Norway and received the Grand Cross of the Royal Norwegian Order of Merit.

House panel to review implementation of report on NTA reforms

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 18

THE PARLIAMENTARY Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, headed by Congress leader Digvijay Singh, has decided to review the implementation of a high-level committee report on reforms in the National Testing Agency (NTA) and the investigation into the alleged NEET-UG paper leak this year.

Vineet Joshi, Secretary in the Education Ministry's Department of Higher Education, and NTA chairperson Pradeep Kumar Joshi are scheduled to appear before the committee on May 21. The committee will review the implementation of a 2024 report submitted by a seven-member panel headed by former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan. The committee, constituted after a NEET-UG paper leak, had recommended measures to strengthen the NTA and ensure smooth conduct of exams.

In a report presented in Parliament last year, on a review of autonomous institutions like NTA and NAAC, the standing committee had noted that the NTA “has not inspired much confidence”.

Privilege notice

PTI adds: Congress chief whip in the Rajya Sabha Jairam Ramesh on Monday moved a privilege notice against Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan for allegedly lowering the dignity of Parliament with remarks made at a press meet after the NEET paper leak.

Pradhan, addressing a press conference last week, had said: “I will not go by the opinion of the parliamentary committee. I will go by the recommendation of the Radhakrishnan committee...I will proceed based on facts; we won't talk about assumptions...The parliamentary standing committee has Opposition members. They write in a certain way, you also know that.”

NEET-UG PAPER LEAK

At Pune shopping complex, a shut dental clinic and a ‘beauty parlour’ that isn’t

Anuradha Mascarenhas
Pune, May 18

SHUTTERS ARE down at Dr Sanjay Waghmare's clinic ‘Dental Designs’, at Kapil Upvan complex in Pune's Bibwewadi. It was from this clinic that Dr Waghmare's wife Manisha, allegedly key to the leak of the NEET-UG examination paper that has led to its cancellation, is said to have run her “beauty parlour”.

However, before Manisha's name surfaced as a central figure in the leak, leading to her arrest on May 14, hardly anyone in the shopping complex knew about the 46-year-old, and certainly not as a beautician. A former employee at her husband's clinic — a multi-specialty clinic, offering a range of dental services, including orthodontic — said what was being described as a “parlour” was little more than a small section within the establishment. Chaitrali Katekhaye, who owns an adjoining salon at



Dr Sanjay Waghmare's clinic, ‘Dental Designs’, at a shopping complex in Pune has been shut for the past three days. PAVAN KHENGRE

the shopping complex, ‘Style and Smile’, said: “I remember Manisha getting her children to my parlour for a haircut. Beyond that, we barely interacted.”

Naveena (23), who is employed with a pharmaceutical distributor's firm in the complex, said that in the two years she had been working there, she never heard of a beauty parlour at the clinic. Pune Police

Commissioner Amitesh Kumar told *The Indian Express* that they did not know much about Manisha, and had only detained her, before handing her over to the CBI. It was during interrogation by CBI officials, Pune Police sources said, that details about her became clear.

CBI sources said that Manisha did small-time “beauty salon” work. The agency believes

Manisha connected students looking for tuitions with teachers of reputed schools, and then allegedly used the same contacts to distribute the leaked paper. Waghmare's clinic has been shut for the past three days, said owners of other establishments at the shopping complex. The Gagan Osian Park Society where the Waghmares live with their children incidentally is the same complex where Manisha Mandhare, another accused in the case, stays. Mandhare was one of the exam setters with the National Testing Agency (NTA) that conducts NEET.

“Our society has 252 flats. The news about these arrests has come as a tremendous shock to all of us,” said Rajkumar Birjadar, secretary of the cooperative housing society. The Waghmare flat is latched from the outside. A neighbour said: “The family mostly kept to themselves. We really do not know them well.”



The accident site in Palghar's Dahanu taluka on Monday. EXPRESS

13 killed, 30 injured as truck rams wedding party tempo in Palghar

Express News Service
Mumbai, May 18

THIRTEEN PEOPLE, including four women, were killed and over 30 others were injured after a container trailer rammed a tempo truck carrying a wedding party on the Mumbai-Ahmedabad Highway near Dhaniwari in Palghar district's Dahanu taluka on Monday evening. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis announced compensation of Rs 5 lakh each to the kin of the deceased.

The Palghar district administration said that the Eicher tempo on its way to Khadkipada, carrying about 40 passengers, was headed for an engagement ceremony in Dhaniwari when it collided with the trailer truck coming from Mumbai side near Dhaniwari village around 4 pm. The accident happened at a short distance from the bride's home. “Upon reaching Dhaniwari village, a trailer (NL 01 AC 9118) coming from the opposite direction lost control, and its container box collided heavily with the left side of the tempo. A motorcycle (MH 04 EM 8425) was also caught in the pile-up.”

In the impact, the front section of the container broke apart and fell onto the truck, trapping several passengers underneath. Both riders of the motorcycle

were also killed. The tempo was allegedly travelling on the wrong side of the Mumbai-Gujarat carriageway, it said, while officials claimed the trailer allegedly lost control before the accident.

The statement identified the 13 deceased as Suresh Ratna Lakhat, Pandu Ganpat Lakhat, Kalu Govind Lakhat, Sunil Arjun Dandekar, Chima Govind Kurhada, Namita Vitthal Dandekar, Sarika Santosh Lakhat, Ayush Sitaram Lakhat, Sagar Namdev Shende, Vandana Shivram Valvi, Saloni Shivram Valvi, Ajay Ahadi and Riyanshi Santosh Lakhat. Residents and rescue teams scrambled to pull survivors out from beneath the mangled truck and fallen container. Critically injured 14 people were shifted to Vedantaa Hospital in Dahanu, while the other injured were admitted to Kasa Sub-District Hospital, where a huge crowd gathered.

District officials and police personnel were present at the site to coordinate rescue operations and manage traffic on the Mumbai-Ahmedabad Highway. The administration said that the exact cause of the accident is yet to be ascertained. Police have initiated a probe into the accident, even as rescue and relief efforts continued through the evening.

WITH PTI INPUTS

● ‘PETROL NOT EASILY AVAILABLE, LONG LINES AT STATIONS... FAMILY HAD THIS HORSE FOR YEARS’

Govt teacher rides horse to go on Census duty in Jharkhand

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, May 18

AMID FUEL shortages at several petrol pumps in Jharkhand, a teacher at a government school in Garhwa district has gone viral for choosing an old family horse over a motorcycle to carry out Census-related fieldwork in remote villages.

Munna Prasad Gupta, 43, an assistant teacher at the up-graded government high school (Utkramit Uchha Vidyalay) in Tatidiri village of Dhurki block in Garhwa, said he began travelling on horseback for house-listing and map-preparation work linked to the Census exercise after struggling to access fuel in

recent days. “Petrol wasn't easily available, and there were long queues. So, I thought that instead of wasting time in queues, I should come up with an alternative. We have had this horse in our family for years, so I thought I should go on horseback,” Gupta told *The Indian Express*.

Videos of Gupta, in a white uniform and government-issued census cap, riding a brown horse through village paths with survey material on his back, have been widely shared on social media. He said that the horse also proved useful in reaching settlements connected only through narrow dirt paths that cannot easily be crossed on motorcycles. “In such places, we can



Videos of Munna Prasad Gupta riding the horse have gone viral on social media. EXPRESS

still go house to house on horseback and understand the conditions of every household while preparing the maps,” he said.

Gupta said his family has traditionally used horses and that he had learnt riding from his father in his childhood. The sight of him riding the horse into villages would usually draw the attention of children, many of whom had only seen horses in pictures. “Children born after 2018 or 2019 mostly know horses from images. They came close, saw the animal directly and became very excited,” he said.

Gupta, teaching since November 25, 2003, said this was his first Census duty assignment. The teacher said he started the fieldwork on Saturday, despite it being a school holiday, because he considered the Census assignment an im-

portant government responsibility. “I thought if the Government of India has given me this responsibility, then I should begin immediately and complete it with sincerity,” he said.

The work includes house listing and preparation of “nazri naksha”, or sketch maps of households and localities. Gupta said the process is expected to continue for around a month and may involve visiting between five and 20 houses daily. “Sometimes, mobile networks do not work. Sometimes, people are not at home, and we have to revisit the houses later. So, the number of houses covered each day can vary.” He said nobody has objected to his going for the

duty on horseback. “People are appreciating it. I only thought about saving fuel and using what was available at home.”

Jharkhand began the first phase of Census 2027, “House Listing and Housing Census”, on May 16. This will continue until June 14. The state government has deployed thousands of enumerators and supervisors for door-to-door surveys, with data being collected digitally through mobile applications for the first time. Gupta said he plans to continue using the horse during the initial phase of the Census work. “The survey work may continue for around a month... My horse will help me to deal with this fuel crisis in India,” he said.

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

● POLITY

In federalism challenges, consensus is the solution



EXPERTS EXPLAIN

DEVESH KAPUR & ARVIND SUBRAMANIAN

CONTENTIOUSNESS HAS marked discussions around the recently defeated Constitutional Amendment Bill. But that has been true of the evolution of federalism since Independence, not least because federalism has been a critical instrument of nation-building. From the centralisation turn in the constitutional design in the aftermath of the horrors of Partition, to the never-ending debates on vertical and horizontal devolution in fiscal federalism, to the centralising effects of the Planning Commission, to the misuse of Article 356 and dismissal of state governments by the Centre and imposition of President's Rule, to the partisan role of Governors, the language imbroglio, delimitation and the distribution of seats in Parliament, federalism has been a work in progress and never set in stone.

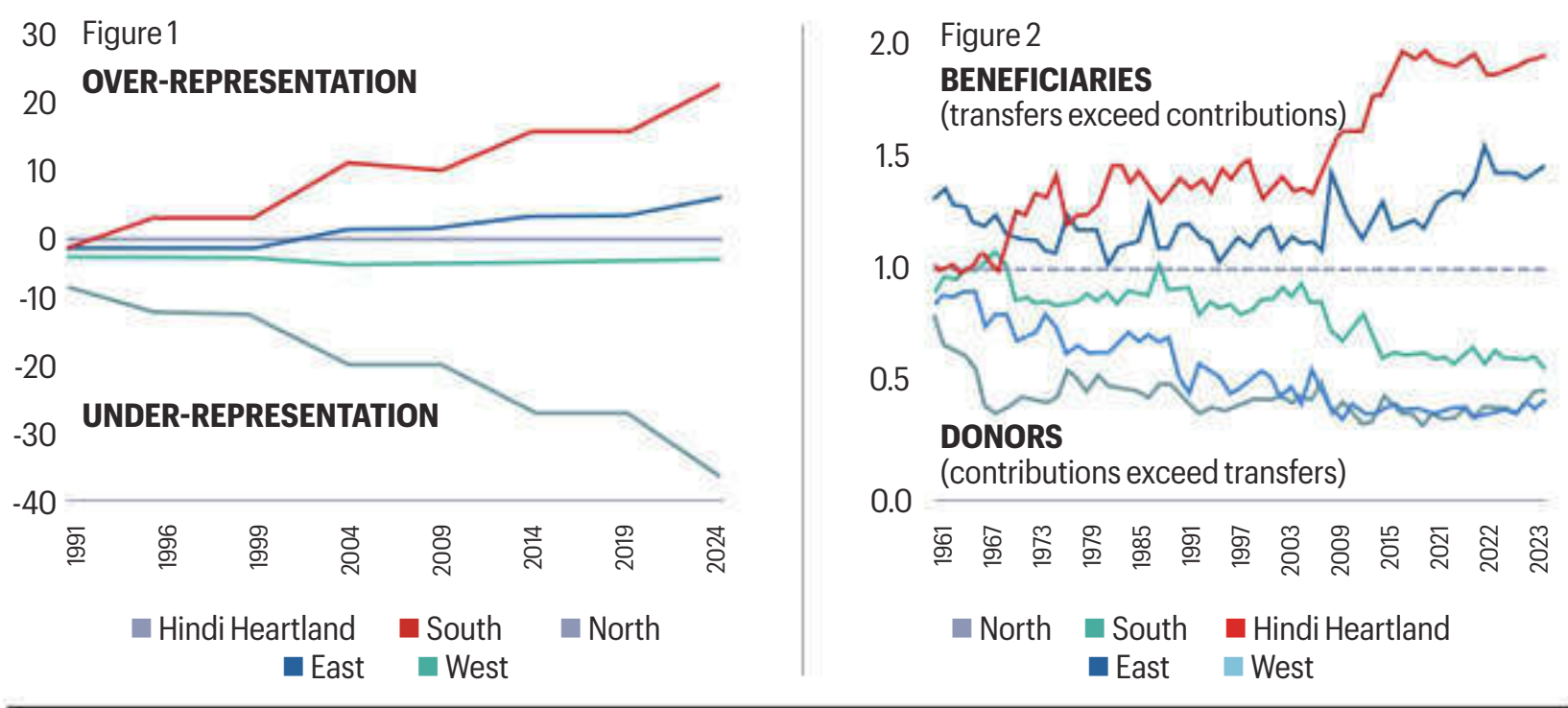
Our recent book, *A Sixth of Humanity*, which looks back on 75 years of India's development journey, sheds light on some of these issues. It quantifies two proximate challenges, identifies the two deeper causes and ends with one anecdote that is both revealing and instructive for India's politicians.

Proximate challenge 1: Rising democratic 'deficit'

In democracies, equal citizenship requires that each citizen's vote should have the same weight. As populations shift, periodic adjustments in the distribution of seats, both across states (between states with slower and more rapid growing populations) as well as within states (between slower growing rural areas and faster growing urban areas) are needed to ensure this equality. But principles in the abstract need to be adjusted with the pragmatism of political wisdom.

Constitutional amendments in 1976, and again in 2002, froze political representation on the basis of the 1971 Census until the first Census after 2026. As a result, as *Figure 1* indicates, the "democratic deficit" — the gap between a state's population share and its seat share — had grown from a relatively small amount in 1991 to such an extent that even in the 2024 elections, the four Southern states (Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Telangana) would have had 23 fewer seats and the four Northern states (Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh) 31 additional seats had these been determined by the latest population estimates.

● Changing populations, changing representation



But because of growth divergence and highly redistributive policies, by 2023, the Hindi heartland received 90 per cent more Finance Commission resources relative to its economic base/contribution, while the South and West received about 44 and 58 per cent less, respectively than their contribution. The wedge between contributors and beneficiaries has grown sharply over six decades, especially in the new millennium.

Proximate challenge 2: Rising fiscal transfers

In a federal polity, fiscal resources would be generated and allocated across states in line with economic size and performance. In reality, this will and should never happen, and some redistribution will be essential. Transfers from richer to poorer states to ensure broadly comparable access to public goods and services to all citizens are a key instrument of nation-building. But redistribution that is open-ended and rising continually is an invitation to resentment and discontent.

Figure 2 plots the difference between a state's contribution to the tax base and what it receives by way of Finance Commission transfers. An index greater than 1 implies a state is a beneficiary, while an index smaller than 1 implies it is a donor. In the early 1960s, the spread between the index was small. The Hindi heartland, for example, got 20 per cent more resources than the size of its economy. The South and West got 20 per cent less.

But because of growth divergence and highly redistributive policies, by 2023, the Hindi heartland received 90 per cent more Finance Commission resources relative to its economic base/contribution, while the South and West received about 44 and 58 per cent less, respectively than their contribution. The wedge between contributors and beneficiaries has grown sharply over six decades, especially in the new millennium.

The more powerful Centre needs to engage with states through wide consultation, accommodation, compromise and self-restraint

erally with minimal consultation and little respect for the democratic processes of wide consultation, accommodation, compromise and self-restraint.

Instead of treating politics as electoral competition, it is increasingly viewed as an existential battle to vanquish enemies. Co-operative federalism — the bedrock of nation-building — is curdling into contentious, even combative, federalism. This has led to mounting grievances — in Kashmir, Ladakh, Manipur, the South, and amongst religious minorities.

The single biggest casualty is the erosion of the most potent and indispensable, if elusive, force of nation-building — trust — whether among citizens, between the state and citizens, between the Centre and states, and between states.

What is democratic sensibility? In 2018, the Finance Minister of Kerala, TM Thomas Isaac, politely asked to walk out of the GST (Goods and Services Tax) Council meeting because he was in a minority of one relative to the consensus on gambling taxation. The Council could easily have moved forward because it was the Centre plus 28 states against one state, and that too a state in opposition to the ruling party at the Centre.

Instead, the then Union Finance Minister, Arun Jaitley, went out of his way to cajole him back and accommodate his position even while juggling to maintain the delicate compromise amongst the other 28 finance ministers. Kerala came on board. Unanimity was preserved. India triumphed.

Solutions galore — new compacts, grand bargains, complex voting principles, revised fiscal transfer arrangements — have been offered in the last few weeks to address the serious challenges of Indian federalism. But if performance diverges within India, no solution will succeed without the embrace of a basic democratic sensibility, especially on the part of the Central government which has the preponderance of power. With it, workable solutions will be possible for even the most exigent challenges. Without it, even simple problems risk spiralling into crises. Democratic sensibility prevents a dominant government from becoming domineering.

This is the first of two pieces on the federalism debate. It draws upon the authors' recent book A Sixth of Humanity: Independent India's Development Odyssey, especially Chapters XIV and XV.

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Arvind Subramanian is an Indian economist and the former Chief Economic Advisor to the Government of India (2014-18). He is currently a Senior Fellow at the Peterson Institute for International Economics, Washington DC.

● POLITICS

OBC quota in Uttar Pradesh panchayat polls: process, rules

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, May 18

THE UTTAR Pradesh Cabinet on Monday approved the formation of the UP State Dedicated Backward Classes Commission to determine reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in three-tier Panchayati Raj institutions.

The move is in line with directions issued by the Supreme Court and the Allahabad High Court on implementing OBC reservation in local body elections.

Hearing a petition in March, the Allahabad HC had taken a stern view of the delay in forming the commission and asked if the process would be completed before the current five-year tenure of panchayats ends on May 26.

Why does this matter?

Courts have made it clear that before giving reservations to OBCs in local elections, states must pass a strict "triple test", which includes:

- Setting up a dedicated commission
- Conducting empirical inquiry into backwardness
- Determining reservation proportion within constitutional limits.

With this commission, UP is checking the first box.

What is the larger political significance?

Panchayat elections in UP are a mammoth affair, covering over 8 lakh posts at different levels of panchayat. In the 2021 polls, elections were held for 7.32 lakh wards across 58,189 Gram Panchayats, 75,855 wards of 826 Kshetra Panchayats, and 3,051 members of 75 Zila Panchayats.

● SIGNIFICANCE

- Panchayat elections in UP are a mammoth affair, covering over 8 lakh posts.
- In the run-up to the 2027 UP Assembly elections, all major players are eyeing these polls to show their strength.

What will the commission do?

CONDUCT EMPIRICAL STUDY: A study will help assess the nature, extent and impact of backwardness among OBCs across UP. Based on the findings, the panel will recommend the proportion and manner of reservation.

EXAMINE RESERVATION FRAMEWORK: The commission will examine provisions related to reservation under the Uttar Pradesh Panchayat Raj Act, 1947, and the Uttar Pradesh Kshetra Panchayat and Zila Panchayat Adhiniyam, 1961. It will also review the operational framework under Uttar Pradesh Panchayat Raj (Reservation and Allotment of Seats and Offices) Rules, 1994, and other rules.

THE BREAKDOWN: According to the Cabinet note, under Article 243D of the Constitution and relevant state laws, reservation in panchayat bodies is provided for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and backward classes.

The Cabinet note states that while SC/ST reservation will continue in proportion to their population, OBC reservation in panchayats will remain capped at 27% of the total seats. Further, if updated population data for backward classes is unavailable, their population can be ascertained through a prescribed survey process.

MEMBERS: It will comprise five members having expertise of backward class issues, appointed by the state government. One of the members will be a retired High Court judge, who will serve as chairperson.

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● SPORTS

String theory: Why tension in a badminton racquet impacts player performance

Prithraj Raj
New Delhi, May 18

WHEN AYUSH Shetty was playing at the World Junior Badminton Championships a few years ago, he had a tension for his racquet string in mind. But when the shuttle landed at the gut-string counter, Tim Willis, head of stringing at sports equipment manufacturer Yonex, reckoned he might need higher tension to produce a more attacking game.

"Stringing is a crucial part of any racquet sport. I think Indians are more calculative about their game and less about these details, but it does play a role in the career of any shuttle," Willis told *The Indian Express* on the sidelines of the Yonex stringing workshop. "Strings guide the gameplay in badminton. They give you precision and

the ability to control the game," he added.

Why tension matters

Surface tension is the tightness of the string on the racquet. While higher tension makes the string bed firm and offers more control, lower tension makes it softer and gives it more power. "Knowing tension for strings is like knowing your diet plan. It's like what your racquet needs," said Willis. According to him, elite shuttlers are "very particular" about it but "not as fussy as the tennis ones".

On how crucial tension is, Willis said that depends on the individual. "Some players rely a lot on their racquets to deliver their game, while some are more instinctive and improvise even without everything being perfect for them."

According to Willis, there is "no set for-

mula" of having higher or lower tension for better performance. "For example, Akane Yamaguchi [Japan] is one of the most elite players to have lower tensions. She operates around 24 to 26 lbs (measured in pounds). Carolina [Marin] also used to have lower tension, around 28 lbs. Viktor Axelsen [of Denmark] or Kunlavut Vitidsarn [of Thailand] have around 33 to 35 lb," he said.

Willis also said that Yamaguchi's lower tension preference makes her an exception, as elite players usually prefer between 30 and 35 lbs.

"One of the reasons that elite players don't need lower tension is due to precision. Lower tension gives you a larger sweet spot to connect with the shuttle but given the precision of elite players, they want a tighter sweet spot," he said. "Someone like



Tim Willis during the stringing workshop in New Delhi. YONEX

Viktor or Satwik (Satwiksairaj Rankireddy) prefers higher tension because of their ability to hit the sweet spot every single time."

meant to study the magnetosphere. Past missions like the Swarm and Cluster by the European Space Agency (ESA) have also vastly improved our understanding of this region in space and the processes that happen here.

What sets SMILE apart is that it will, in real-time, be able to capture X-ray images of how the Earth's magnetosphere instinctively reacts and protects the Earth from numerous incoming solar emissions and charged particles. Unlike previous missions, it will also get a full view of the interactions happening in the magnetosphere.

The mission

SMILE weighs about 2,600 kg and has a mission life of about three years. It will be positioned around 1.21 lakh km above Earth's north pole and be able to observe the edge of the magnetosphere fully.

The mission will help solar physicists better understand space weather and forecast solar storms or other perturbations. This is vital for the safety of astronauts, our

space-based assets like satellites, GPS, and airline operations, as well as uninterrupted operations of space stations.

The forecasts happen at present too, thanks to satellites installed in space for this purpose, but SMILE is expected to significantly improve the accuracy and effectiveness.

The mission is carrying four scientific instruments, weighing 70 kg in total. All these payloads will use remote sensing and make in situ (on site) observations along the near-Earth regions. The four onboard instruments will operate both on X-ray and ultraviolet wavelengths of the electromagnetic spectrum.

ESA has developed the Soft X-ray Imager (SXI), whereas the Chinese team has developed the other three payloads — Magnetometer, Light Ion Analyser (LIA) and Ultraviolet aurora Imager (UVI).

While the Chinese and European space agencies have worked together in the past, this is the first time that they are sending a joint mission to space.

What Indians prefer

Indians mostly prefer above 30 lbs, said Willis. "(PV) Sindhu was the one who had a bit extra at the start of her career, but as she progressed, I think she moved towards 31 or 32 lbs," said Willis.

Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty have different string tensions due to their game play and role in a doubles setup. "Satwik has got 32 lbs tension and he uses the BG80 string while Chirag uses 31 lbs," he said. "Satwik is one of the hardest smashers in the world. He has got higher tension given his precision to strike that smaller sweet spot."

Both Lakshya Sen and Ayush Shetty are "a little fussy, but in a good way", Willis said. "Ayush wants to get his racquet re-strung every game while Lakshya recently got his freshly strung racquets re-done as he felt

the strings have become soft." According to him, many Indian players need to learn more about tension and its importance.

One reason behind this lack of knowledge, Willis said, is the scarcity of more qualified stringers in India, pointing to instances of non-elite Indian players with poorly strung racquets.

Evolution of stringing

Like all other techniques in sports, stringing has evolved over the years from manual to usage of machines that can string five to six racquets in an hour.

Pointing to how the game had evolved from wooden racquets in the past to carbon fibre now, Willis said: "Similarly in stringing, when I started, it was manual. Now, we have got machines that can really work on five racquets in an hour."

No quick-fixes, weak rupee problem runs deep

THE INDIAN currency continues to be under pressure. On Monday, the rupee was hovering around 96.3 against the dollar — since the beginning of this year, it has fallen by around 6.5 per cent. According to a report in this paper, some policymakers view this fall as the market pricing in the depreciation that may have occurred before 2025, a time when the central bank's interventions increased sharply, leading to an “artificial stabilisation” of the rupee. While market interventions designed to keep the currency at a particular level may delay the adjustments required to fix underlying imbalances in the economy, the problems with the rupee run deeper.

The currency's weakness comes at a time when the Indian economy has been growing at a relatively healthy pace, with both inflation and the current account deficit being low. The rupee has also fallen against the dollar when the greenback has itself weakened — in 2025, the rupee fell by 4.7 per cent against the dollar when the dollar index fell from 109 to 98. The problems have been due to pressure on both the capital and current accounts. Capital has been flowing out of the country, with both foreign and domestic investors exploring alternatives. Investors seem more exuberant about the prospects of East Asian economies, which are benefitting from the China+1 play and the AI boom. And on the current account side, the steep rise in global crude oil prices is exerting pressure, financing which will be challenging.

In response, there have been appeals to curb foreign travel and gold purchases in order to conserve forex, with the RBI also intervening in the markets to stem the rupee's slide. Its net short forward position had widened considerably, and it had earlier also restricted activity in the non-deliverable forwards market. The relief to the currency from the central bank's steps was, however, short-lived. But the temptation to intervene in the currency markets through various instruments, when the rupee is facing both depreciation and appreciation pressures, is not new. The central bank has in the past repeatedly intervened in the markets. The approach should, however, be to allow the currency to move freely. The rupee should work as a shock absorber. At the current juncture, the focus should be on addressing the pain points in the economy. Steps need to be taken to attract foreign capital, raise domestic competitiveness and boost merchandise exports. The structural impediments to growth need to be tackled urgently.

On Saranda forests, Jharkhand must heed SC

IN NOVEMBER last year, the Supreme Court asked the Jharkhand government to notify 314 sq km of the Saranda forests in the state's West Singhbhum district as a wildlife sanctuary. The order came after the apex court had pulled up the state government on at least two occasions for failing to comply with its directives on checking illegal mining in the biodiverse forests. However, after assuring the Court of compliance, the Hemant Soren government has dilly-dallied over protecting one of Asia's largest sal forest ecosystems. It has missed the February deadline for declaring the Saranda forests a wildlife sanctuary and instead filed two review petitions before the SC — the last on April 30. The state government's argument — according to protected area status to the forests would curtail the rights of indigenous people — flies in the face of the SC's clarifications. The Court has repeatedly said that individual and community rights under the Forest Rights Act will remain protected and traditional livelihoods will not be displaced by conservation efforts.

The Saranda forests are among the country's most important elephant corridors. Mining operations have, over the past two decades, altered the ecosystem's integrity. They have disrupted the migratory routes of elephants and forced them to move through human settlements and fields, leading to increased human-animal conflict across Jharkhand and neighbouring Odisha and West Bengal. A study published last year in *Ecology and Evolution* reported that rampaging elephants had killed more than 1,300 people in Jharkhand between 2000 and 2023. Deforestation also weakens watershed systems, accelerates soil erosion, hampers local climate resilience, and affects agriculture and people's livelihoods. The Jharkhand government is, therefore, ill-advised in framing conservation as a choice between forests and indigenous communities. It should see the protection of the sal forests as a matter of long-term ecological security.

Jharkhand's prevarication reflects a deeper and troubling pattern — a widening chasm between judicial directives and executive action on environmental matters. Whether in the inadequate response to Delhi's deteriorating air quality, the bypassing of Court orders aimed at protecting the fragile Himalayan ecology, or dilution of safeguards within coastal zones, the executive has too often failed to match the judiciary's interventions with meaningful enforcement. Public faith in environmental governance is undermined when governments offer assurances before courts and then delay or dilute implementation. The Jharkhand government should course correct and listen to the SC.

Iliad, and the art of dying

IF SOCRATES was right when he remarked in the *Phaedo* that “Philosophy is training for death”, it is perhaps not too much of a leap to imagine that literature can be a guide in the afterlife. A group of researchers, including academics from the University of Barcelona and the Free University of Berlin, have found a fragment from the *Iliad* buried with a mummy from Roman-era Egypt. The elaborate tombs of Egyptian royalty and nobility often have texts, but these are usually more practical guides on navigating life after death — the *Book of the Dead*, for example. Homer's epic, though, is a little more poetic: “Now the wind scatters the old leaves across the earth, now the living timber bursts with the new buds and spring comes round again. And so with men: As one generation comes to life, another dies away.”

There is a sociological explanation for the fragment of the epic interred in the tomb. With the beginning of the Ptolemaic age after Alexander's invasion of Egypt, religious customs — especially funeral rites and mummification — evolved, and many of Greek origin may have wanted to preserve their Hellenistic roots. The *Iliad*, in such a context, becomes a religious text.

But there is, perhaps, another less concrete message about life and death — and stories and poems — from the fragment and the mummy. The big question about life is how to deal with the mystery at its end. The Socratic way of contemplation and detachment is one path prescribed through the centuries. For those who are fond of living while they are alive, though, there's always a story and a poem. Who's to say that isn't heaven?

The Editorial Page

NEET paper leak raises larger questions, calls for honest reckoning

FOR THE third time in recent years, the NEET examination has been marred by a paper leak — a phrase that has become, with grim predictability, a seasonal feature of India's medical admissions calendar. The hopes of 22 lakh students are once again temporarily dashed. They go home, not relieved of a burden but still high-strung, facing a repeat examination and all the uncertainty that lies beyond it. Young men and women who have spent years in relentless preparation — after-school coaching, sleepless nights, the full weight of family expectation — have met their first roadblock before their journey even began. The frustration on their faces, visible in images circulating on social media, is not the frustration of a single bad morning. It is the accumulated anguish of years.

The paper leak raises questions that ought to disturb us deeply. In an era of digital encryption, blockchain-secured communication, and multi-layered cybersecurity protocols, how does a national examination of this magnitude remain so porous? The answer points, regrettably, toward structural corruption. Well-organised networks — often traceable to the commercial interests of large coaching institutions anxious to demonstrate the success rates of their students — appear to have cultivated contacts within the examination ecosystem itself: Those involved in question setting, collation, or distribution. It must also be said that NEET has provided an unintended but powerful impetus to the mushrooming of coaching centres across the country, several of them operating in conditions of overcrowding, unrelenting stress, and performance pressure that exceed reasonable human limits, driving a distressing number of aspirants toward de-

pression, and some to suicide.

It is worth returning to first principles. NEET was introduced in 2013 to ensure uniformity in assessing eligibility for medical education, to uproot the menace of capitation fees, to end corruption in seat allocation, and to establish merit as the sole criterion for selection. These were not small ambitions. A decade later, each of these objectives deserves honest appraisal, not institutional self-congratulation.

Capitation fees have not been uprooted. Several private medical colleges continue to collect substantial sums above prescribed limits from candidates who possess the grades but not the means. More troublingly, the structure of NEET cut-offs has produced a perverse outcome: Low qualifying percentages now favour the less meritorious but financially resourceful candidate over the more meritorious but economically constrained one. The student, compelled to borrow in order to capitalise on a hard-earned rank, enters medicine carrying a debt that reshapes every professional decision thereafter. The ethic of service that might have taken root at the threshold of a career is not lost through moral failure — it is foreclosed by financial obligation. Such graduates are driven, almost by design, into early private practice and commercially induced clinical behaviour. Ahead of them lie not one but two further examinations — NEET Postgraduate and NEET Superspecialty — with the same rignarole. This repetitive cycle leaves doctors burnt out and diminished in their zeal to serve.

The consequences extend further. The middle-class graduate is pushed toward revenue-generating practice. Many of the most talented, merit-driven graduates — drawn by better professional environments and more



SUNIL CHANDY

Incompetence, lack of integrity, and unacceptable examination conduct have brought the standing of this national examination to its lowest imaginable point

enabling systems abroad — leave at the first opportunity. Both outcomes represent a loss the country can ill afford. India's doctor-to-population ratio in several states remains dangerously below acceptable benchmarks. Community health centres across Tier 2 and Tier 3 districts report chronic vacancies. This is not a future concern — it is a present emergency. An admissions system that consistently diverts talent away from public service is not a neutral administrative arrangement; it is a structural problem with direct health consequences.

None of this is to say that NEET has produced nothing of value. The creation of a common national platform, the reduction in the multiplicity of competing entrance examinations, and some improvement in transparency within government college admissions are real, if partial, achievements that deserve acknowledgement. But partial success does not excuse systematic failure, and the failures are now too numerous and too consequential to be addressed by incremental adjustment.

The time has come for a rigorous, multi-pronged retrospective appraisal. Have the objectives set at conception in 2013 been met? Has NEET produced better medical graduates for the nation? Has it meaningfully curbed capitation, quantitatively and qualitatively? Has it increased the supply of doctors available to serve in health-im-

poverished geographies? Has it brought greater equity in the allocation of medical seats for economically disadvantaged and tribal communities? Has it, in any measurable sense, produced a generation of doctors who place the patient above self-interest? These are not rhetorical questions. They are the terms on which this examination

● WORDLY WISE

Conservation is a state of harmony between men and land.
— Aldo Leopold

was originally justified, and the country is owed honest answers.

The government's immediate obligations are clear: Conduct the rescheduled examination with security measures commensurate with the stakes involved; provide verifiable redress to affected students through fee refunds and adequate notice; and institute an independent forensic investigation into this and previous leaks — one that names, charges, and prosecutes those responsible. The leadership of the National Testing Agency must account publicly for a pattern of failure that has become indefensible.

Beyond the immediate, a larger act of institutional honesty is required. The reform needed is not cosmetic. It must address examination security, fee regulation in private medical colleges, incentive structures that make rural and public service genuinely viable, welfare standards for aspirants caught in the coaching ecosystem, and accountability mechanisms for the institutions that have profited most from the current disorder.

Incompetence, lack of integrity, and unacceptable examination conduct have brought the standing of this national examination to its lowest imaginable point. That is not a political statement. It is a description of what is.

India has produced, across generations, physicians of extraordinary skill and dedication who have served this country and the world well. The question before those who govern this system today is not a complicated one: Does the process we have built honour the students we are putting through it, and does it serve the people those students are meant to heal?

The writer is former director, CMC Vellore

For WTO to matter, it needs to recognise politics behind trade



AMRITA NARLIKAR

IT IS impossible not to smile darkly when the results of a G2 summit are discrepant readouts: It seems that presidents Donald Trump and Xi Jinping cannot agree on what was agreed on during their recent talks. The good news: They seem not to be colluding to divide up the world into new spheres of influence. But global instability is not about to diminish. For the rest of the world, multilateral institutions matter more than ever. So it is fair to ask: What does the latest ministerial conference of the World Trade Organisation (WTO) — MC 14 — held in Yaoundé, Cameroon, mean for development?

For some time, development talks in the WTO have focused on streamlining Special and Differential Treatment. But four other aspects demand urgent attention.

First, the “needs and interests” of developing countries should be placed “at the heart of the WTO.” Unfortunately, the Doha Development Agenda (DDA) of 2001, the unprecedented trade round according centrality to development concerns, died a slow death.

The second challenge derives ironically from a WTO success: China became a full member in 2001, swiftly learning how to use/play the rules. Add to this its political system, state-led investment and industrial policy, and overcapacity in Chinese manufacturing and cheap exports followed. Despite some advantages that accrue to developing countries, their manufacturing base in key areas gets undercut by China, while depressed prices globally deliver a double whammy. If the US and China strike a bilateral deal on this, developing countries will be even worse hit.

Third, economic interdependence can now be weaponised. How does a developing country manage access to food and energy, when strategic chokepoints are affected by war? Or, protect its citizens and national defence systems against cybersecurity threats, surveillance and data misuse? These dangers hit developing countries more because of the difficult choices they face. To address them, national security needs to be factored into trade equations more systematically.

Fourth, “development” can no longer be restricted to humans. Recognition is slowly growing that anthropocentric per-

spectives on development have caused immense damage to the environment. Pandemics caused by keeping innocent animals in brutal conditions in wet markets, or transporting them as “live exports” on journeys that maim and kill, are deadly examples. We need models of growth and trade that honour the deeply intertwined existence of all beings.

On all four levels, MC 14 has not delivered. The old DDA-related concerns remain unaddressed. Chinese overcapacity cannot be solved by trade measures alone. National security barely features in WTO discussions. Planetary rights are scarcely present in trade debates. Ideally, one organisation should be mandated to handle these interlinked trade problems. But such a mandate far exceeds that of the WTO's. What can it do to address these existential concerns?

First, the sooner the WTO and its members recognise that “politics” is here to stay, the greater the chance that they will be able to acknowledge differences and develop innovative solutions. These could include taking a tiered approach to MFN and plurilaterals.

Second, just how disengaged the global public is from trade debates is clear from the perfunctory media coverage MC 14 received. A big mistake at MC 14 was to kick the can back to Geneva — a sure-shot recipe to take trade matters even further away from the public eye. Without political support from the organisation and member countries, and buy-in from a global citizenry, technically sound solutions to development problems will not fly.

Third, for the WTO to catch up with altered empirical realities, it must become intellectually inclusive. A disciplinary dominance of Economics and Law in its secretariat no longer suffices. Prioritisation of efficiency and compliance, at the expense of fundamental questions of power and ethics, is one of the reasons for the mess it is in today. Interdisciplinary research, which also includes historians, political scientists, philosophers, and natural scientists, will enable the needed paradigm shift.

The writer is distinguished fellow, ORF, and honorary fellow of Darwin College, University of Cambridge

Asia is ageing. Can primary care keep up?



PRIYANKA TOMAR AND ALOK KUMAR SINGH

When primary care is not seen as capable of providing sustained care, hospitals become the default point of access — not because they are best suited to meet long-term needs, but because the alternatives are fragmented or absent

When primary care is not seen as capable of providing sustained care, hospitals become the default point of access — not because they are best suited to meet long-term needs, but because the alternatives are fragmented or absent

ducting several new faces into the national executive. The new general secretaries are Indubhai Patel, Anantram Jaiswal, former UP Janata Party chief, Yashwant Sinha, Bhai Vaidya and Jaipal Reddy, MP.

Reshuffle in Kerala soon

THE CHIEF Minister, K Karunakaran, disclosed that there would soon be another reshuffle of ministerial portfolios, including those held by Indian Union Muslim League ministers. Talking to newsmen, Karunakaran denied reports that the portfolios of League ministers had been left undisturbed

for political and personal reasons.

Churn in Karnataka

THE MOVE by 92 Janata MLAs to prevail upon the Chief Minister, Ramakrishna Hegde, to reconstitute his cabinet and put off panchayat elections till the party is able to give a better account of itself has created a piquant situation in the light of certain recent developments. The memorandum containing this suggestion was given to the Chief Minister a couple of months ago, but there was no subsequent development because of Hegde's sudden illness.

The writers are health systems researchers at CSEP, New Delhi. Views are personal

40 YEARS AGO

May 19, 1986



Anti-apartheid push

THE PRIME Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, concluded his five-day tour of the four frontline states of southern Africa with an assurance that the CHOGM meeting in Nassau had resolved to take steps for “dismantling apartheid” in South Africa.

Changes in Janata executive

THE JANATA Party president, Chandra Shekhar, effected major changes in the party's executive by nominating five new general secretaries and three secretaries and in-

State push for Indian knowledge systems is a farce. But dismissing them is a mistake



DESHKAAL
BY YOGENDRA YADAV

INDIAN KNOWLEDGE systems are either worshipped or dismissed. Two recent books suggest a way past these knee-jerk responses. They remind us why we must take Indian knowledge systems seriously. They also instruct us on how to — and how not to — do so.

Indian Knowledge Systems, or IKS, is the buzz word in Indian higher education these days. Every university is busy organising some IKS-related event and posting its photographs on the website. Academics are desperate to discover or invent a connection between their work and IKS. This newly discovered fondness is not organic but spawned by state patronage. The Ministry of Education has created an IKS Division to “rejuvenate and mainstream Indian Knowledge Systems for the contemporary world”. The government is pushing for it, pumping money and incentivising career mobility. Standing for IKS is also, for some academics, a not-so-subtle way of registering an ideological affinity with the present regime. The result is predictable. Thus, we have a flood of publications, mediocre if not worse, that do not serve either knowledge or India, let alone Indian knowledge systems.

This state-sponsored farce cannot but invite a reaction. Among advocates of “scientific temper”, it reinforces the notion that traditional knowledge is nothing but unscientific mumbo-jumbo. Critics of the caste order see this as an attempt to impose a Brahminic worldview. Critics of the government view this as an attempt to cloak an authoritarian regime with false national pride. The greater the advocacy of IKS, the greater the ridicule for the very idea of Indian knowledge in liberal and progressive circles. Such a rejection of IKS is a serious intellectual and political mistake.

It is historically absurd to believe in the self-serving autobiography of the modern

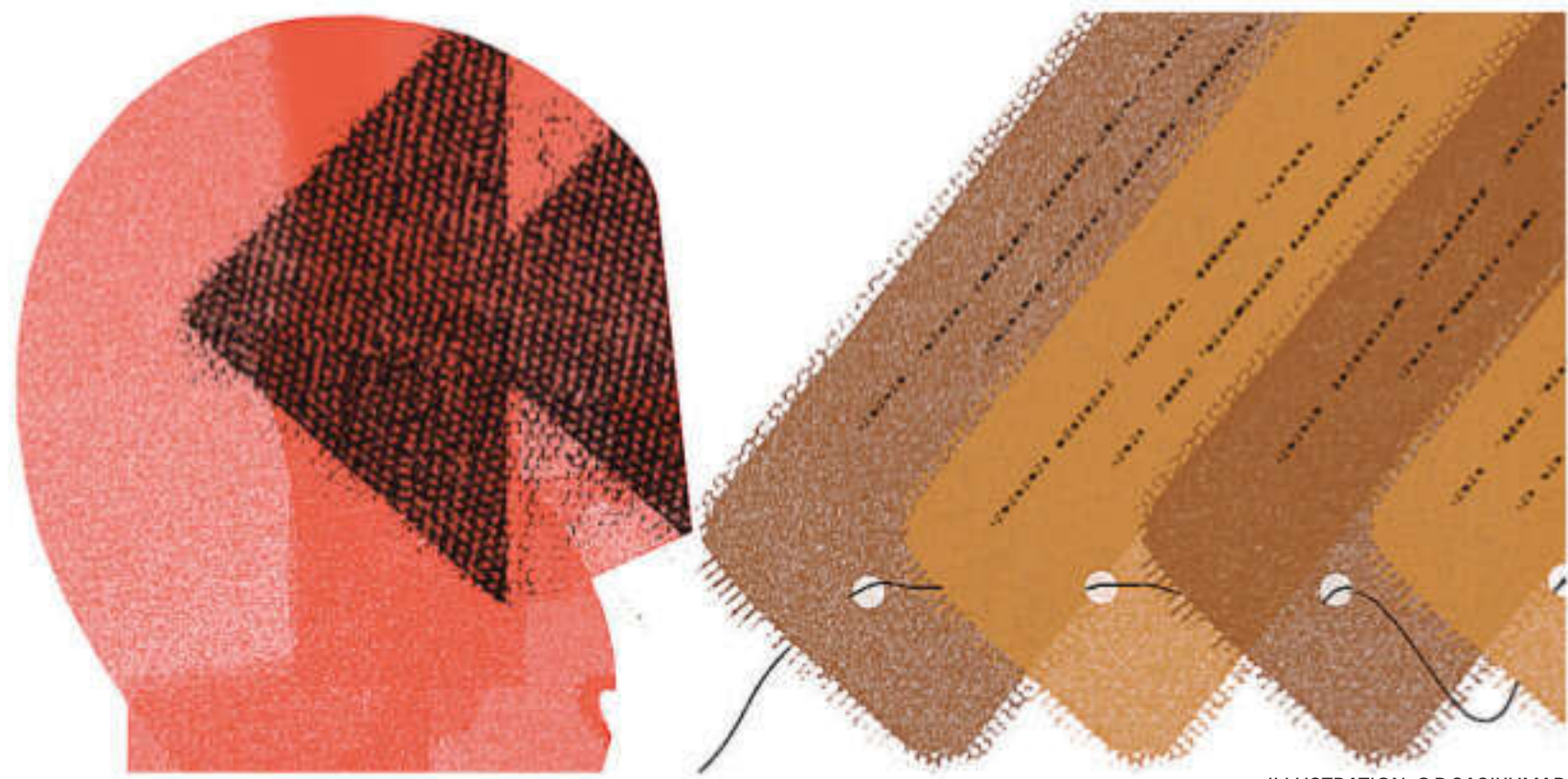


ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASKIKUMAR

West, to assume that it is the sole repository of human knowledge. It is a cultural disaster to raise generations of Indians who have no idea of the knowledge resources of the land where they were born. It is a political blunder to give up on the cultural and civilisational heritage of the country you seek to reclaim. Any serious engagement with IKS has to begin with a humble admission that India since Independence has been guilty of overlooking its intellectual traditions. Recovery and reconstruction of our knowledges must be an integral part of the future agenda of Swaraj in ideas.

The problem with IKS is not its basic idea but its skewed framing. The current focus on IKS involves multiple reductions. First, Indian knowledges are assumed to belong to the past, thus overlooking the living and vibrant knowledge systems. Second, the boundaries of India's relevant past have been pushed to ancient times, bypassing the period of British and Muslim rule in India. Third, knowledge systems are reduced to those knowledges that are codified in texts, turning our back on the knowledges encoded in the practices of individuals and communities in agriculture, weaving, handicraft, medicine and so on. Fourth, the texts are limited to those of the high Brahminic traditions, to the neglect of a vast vernacular and *desi* textual

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tradition. And finally, the reference point for the validation of these knowledges continues to be the empire of knowledge created by the modern West. The push for IKS hinges on a pathetic political project of redeeming India's honour in the eyes of the White man.

Bharat ki Saraswat Sadhna (Vani Prakashan, 2025) shows us a way to relate to India's intellectual traditions without falling prey to the current IKS framing. The author is Acharya Radhavallabh Tripathi, a renowned Sanskrit scholar of our times, justly celebrated for his creative writing as well as more than 100 commentaries on literary and philosophical works in Sanskrit. This 556-page volume in Hindi is meant to be an introduction to 19 major literary and philosophical figures who wrote in Sanskrit from 1000 BCE to the 20th century. Given its scope and readership, the author does not get into scholarly and interpretative disputes. Yet, what stands out is his clear-eyed view of our intellectual legacy: Faithful to the texts, mindful of the context, but no attempt to brush inconvenient truths under the carpet. While respecting Western Sanskrit scholars, he quietly interrogates some of the dominant theories about Sanskrit in Western academia and brings the focus back on the tradition of Sanskrit and Oriental scholarship in India. While he does not hide his deep admiration for this tradition,

he steadfastly refuses to participate in the supremacist political project.

Allama Prabhu and the Shaiva Imagination (Permanent Black, 2025) belongs to the other end of the spectrum of writings on Indian intellectual history that focuses on non-Brahminic and non-Sanskrit sources. Authored by D R Nagaraj, among the most profound cultural critics in post-Independence India, the Kannada book was originally published posthumously in 1999. Now we have its long awaited English rendering by NS Gundur, an act of linguistic hospitality that succeeds in bringing Nagaraj's complex ideas to the English reader. The book focusses on Allama Prabhu, one of the great 12th century *vachanakaras* in the Virashaiva movement. In the course of establishing Allama Prabhu as a poet and philosopher, Nagaraj questions the received ways of narrating the history of Indian philosophy and literature that have neglected the vernacular and *desi* imagination that expresses itself through images and metaphors.

Instead of using Western literary theory, Nagaraj interprets Allama's *vachanas* through the conceptual resources of the Shaiva Mimamsa tradition and sets up a conversation with Kashmiri philosopher Abhinavagupta. Above all, Nagaraj engages with Allama in a creative and critical manner, refusing to simply follow like a “flock of parrots”. This book is shot through with a critical lens: Allama critiques the received Virashaiva tradition; Nagaraj critiques Allama and the translator offers a critique of Nagaraj.

This is the kind of engagement we need with Indian knowledge systems — a clear-eyed, future-oriented critical engagement with multiple systems from the past and present, not limited to any one phase of history, not restricted to textual forms of knowledge and not focused on high Brahminic texts. Once we adopt this vantage point, we may not search for Indian knowledge systems in some lost ancient text and struggle to connect it to modern science. We might begin to see and respect millions of Indians, from farming and artisanal communities that we call uneducated and backward, as carriers of Indian knowledge systems.

The writer is member, Swaraj India, and national convener, Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan. Views are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Course correct

USING NSDF funds to build recreational facilities for bureaucrats while athletes train in substandard conditions is a betrayal of the fund's founding purpose (‘Don't deprive sports ecosystem of its due’, *IE*, May 18). Such misallocation makes restoring corporate and public confidence considerably harder. Regular CAG audits, mandatory public disclosure of expenditure, and ring-fencing of NSDF resources exclusively for athlete welfare would restore credibility.
SM Jeeva, Chennai

A fire that burns all

HIMANTA BISWA Sarma must understand that while his politics of Assamese sub-nationalism, Hindu majoritarianism and vilification of Muslims may bring him electoral dividends, a brand of politics that divides the state's inhabitants between “we” and “they” builds a toxic society (‘Assam needs a politics of trust, not suspicion’, *IE*, May 18). In the long run, it creates distrust even among the people he claims to lead. Votaries of the politics of polarisation must understand that it ultimately does immense harm to everybody. It is a fire that burns all and sundry, sparing no one.
SH Quadri, Bikaner

Not just for women

THE ASSUMPTION that domestic work is naturally women's responsibility has never been rooted in biology but in habit, convenience, and selectively interpreted history (‘Turns out, women also hunted and went to war’, *IE*, May 18). Archaeological evidence now challenges even that selective reading. The Supreme Court's observation during the divorce hearing was equally significant. A marriage is a partnership, not a service arrangement. Until that understanding moves from courtrooms into everyday households, the 289-minute versus 88-minute gap in unpaid domestic work will persist — and with it, the quiet erosion of women's time, health, and opportunity.
Swathi Senthilkumar, Coimbatore



SAKTI PRASAD SRICHANDAN

WHAT MADE PM Modi's visit to the Netherlands particularly consequential was not merely the symbolism of diplomatic engagement, but the growing convergence between India's technological ambitions and the Dutch dominance in the semiconductor ecosystem. The visit came at a time when semiconductors have become the new geopolitical currency of power, shaping economic competitiveness, military capability, AI, and digital sovereignty.

At the centre of this emerging partnership lies ASML, the Dutch technology giant that occupies a near-monopoly position in the global chip ecosystem. ASML is the world's only producer of extreme ultraviolet (EUV) lithography machines, the highly sophisticated systems required to manufacture advanced semiconductors. Without its machines, the production of cutting-edge chips becomes virtually impossible. This has transformed the Netherlands from a relatively modest European power into a critical node in the global technology rivalry between the United States and China.

India has identified semiconductors as central to its broader push for technological self-reliance under initiatives such as Make in India, Digital India, and the India Semiconductor Mission. New Delhi has committed billions of dollars in subsidies and incentives to build an ecosystem, including fabrication plants, packaging facilities, chip design centres, and semiconductor research infrastructure. The proposed Tata semiconductor fabrication facility in

Behind Netherlands visit, a semiconductor push

Dholera, Gujarat, with a planned total investment of \$11 billion, for instance, represents India's most ambitious attempt yet to enter the advanced manufacturing segment of the global chip-supply chain.

The global semiconductor industry is undergoing a profound restructuring because of the US-China competition, export controls, and supply-chain vulnerabilities exposed during the Covid pandemic. Dutch companies, including ASML, now face increasing restrictions on exports to China under pressure from Washington. Consequently, India appears increasingly attractive as a democratic, politically stable, and strategically aligned alternative manufacturing destination within the broader “China-plus-one” framework. Reports say that Dutch semiconductor firms are actively exploring diversification opportunities outside China, while Indian officials are encouraging the Netherlands to view India as a long-term production and innovation base.

Earlier this year, Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw visited ASML headquarters in Veldhoven, where discussions focussed on lithography technologies and India's semiconductor ambitions. During PM Modi's trip, Tata Electronics signed an MoU with ASML to support the establishment and ramp-up of its upcoming 300 mm (12-inch) semiconductor fabrication plant in Dholera. Yet the significance of this partnership extends beyond hardware and manufacturing. The Netherlands offers India access to an

ASML is the world's only producer of extreme ultraviolet (EUV) lithography machines, required to manufacture advanced semiconductors

entire ecosystem of semiconductor innovation involving research universities, photonics clusters, precision engineering firms, and advanced design capabilities. Such collaboration could help India avoid the mistake of becoming merely a low-cost assembly base and move up the value chain toward chip design, semiconductor R&D, advanced materials, and AI-integrated manufacturing systems. Modi's visit therefore reflected a broader evolution in Indian foreign policy, from traditional diplomacy centred on trade and politics towards what may be called “technology diplomacy”.

There are reasons for caution. Semiconductor manufacturing is among the most capital-intensive and technologically complex industries in the world. Even with subsidies and political support, India faces structural challenges, including infrastructure gaps, power reliability issues, shortages of highly specialised manufacturing talent, and dependence on imported semiconductor-grade materials. Export-control politics could complicate deeper technology transfers. The Netherlands itself remains closely tied to American strategic preferences in semiconductor controls.

Nevertheless, PM Modi's trip could accelerate India's transition from being a consumer of advanced technologies to becoming an active participant in shaping the global semiconductor ecosystem.

The writer is assistant professor, Centre for European Studies, School of International Studies, JNU

For economic growth, focus like Arjun, or Deng



ARVIND P DATAR

IN 1978, high-level Chinese officials made study tours of several Western and Eastern European countries and Japan. Within weeks, they prepared detailed reports on what China needed to do to economically progress as quickly as possible. Launching his policy for economic reform, Deng Xiaoping made three critical observations: “Recently, our comrades have had a look abroad. The more we see, the more we realise how backward we are. The basic point is we must acknowledge that we are backward, that many of our ways of doing things are inappropriate and that we need to change.” In his outstanding biography of the Chinese leader, Ezra F Vogel records that Deng instructed his officials: “Look at how (the West) manage their economic activities. We ought to study the successful experiences of capitalist countries and bring them back to China.” This was a stunning policy shift for a Communist nation.

After Covid, 2026 is likely to be an extremely difficult year. Indeed, this year is to India what 1978 was to China. India needs to make a similar pivotal shift with a monomaniacal focus on economic growth. Most Indians know the story of Arjun focussing on the wooden fish circling overhead at Draupadi's *swayamvar*. Looking into its reflection in the water, Arjun could see nothing but its eye. It was this single-minded focus, or *ekagrata*, that made him successful.

The first step to progress is to acknowledge and confront the brutal facts. India has slipped to sixth place in the GDP rankings. The rupee is at an embarrassing low of Rs 96 to the dollar and, at the current trend, is likely to reach the three-digit mark by the next quarter. A weak rupee shakes investor confidence, and overseas investors have withdrawn over \$20 billion from the Indian stock markets in the first quarter of 2026, another historic low.

FT Weekend (May 9, page 17) reports: “The rupee was already Asia's worst-performing currency this year before the war began, thanks to India's growing trade deficit and a slump in foreign direct investment in productive assets.” It further notes that the dollar returns of India's Nifty 50 were at a four-year low, and that Indian stocks had underperformed their Asia-Pacific counterparts by 25 per cent. Adding to these alarming statistics is the fact that India's trade deficit swelled to almost \$120 billion by March 31, compared with \$95 billion a year earlier. This abnormal increase is undoubtedly due to the oil crisis in the Gulf.

The second step is to seriously re-examine how inappropriate our ways of doing things are. Most changes are on the periphery; eliminating archaic laws or deleting provisions for harsh punishments do little to attract domestic or foreign investments. There must be a major reduction in state-level regulatory hurdles, licences and no-objection certificates that ensure that it is not easy doing business in India. Every hurdle is a point of corruption, which again discourages investment.

The third, and most important, step is to determine what needs to change. Multinational companies, large domestic companies, and representatives of the MSME sector are best placed to make suggestions on what changes are imperative. The Centre and state governments should prepare a detailed questionnaire that will generate extensive feedback. It is clear that regulated incentive schemes like the PLI can only give limited benefits. There is an equally important need to study the incentives offered by Vietnam, Thailand and Malaysia, and offer even better terms for setting up factories in India. What are the tax liabilities of industries in those countries? What needs to change in the way our taxes are administered? The Swadeshi dream will come true only if we make manufacturing in India attractive and rewarding for large global brands.

The need for Arjun's hyperfocus on reviving the economy is more critical than ever. Sadly, India's progress is hobbled by scattered focus on multiple political issues that deserve to be put on the back burner. Almost 50 years ago, Deng made a radical, and almost heretical, policy shift that altered the destiny of China. He did not hesitate to adopt capitalist policies in a Communist nation, because that was what was needed the most. The current financial crisis is a golden opportunity for India to radically alter its policies as did China. We cannot be unmindful of the needs and exigencies of our country and the limitations of a republican democracy. But we need to go far beyond austerity measures and policy tinkering at the fringes. As was beautifully said: Nothing changes, if nothing changes.

The writer practises at the Supreme Court



Exam fiascos rob me of a chance at a better life

has done his Master's in science, was also a teacher in the same centre. Since both my parents would be busy tending to the farm and my sisters were married, I would have to come back home and cook dinner too, snatching a few hours of sleep in between. It didn't seem that big a deal, probably because I was naive and thought that I was steps away from fulfilling my dream. I was wrong. That year, videos of mass cheating went viral on social media, and CBI investigations were ordered. My dreams were shattered. My parents asked me to move on. I concentrated on completing my Master's and started appearing for competitive examinations. This time, I couldn't afford coaching classes, so I would collaborate with other students for studies.

In families like ours, girls are lucky to get one shot at their dreams. I had already had that privilege. Forms cost money, and we don't have the luxury to spend on them. But I did not want to give up. By 2024, I felt I was meant to be a police constable. I prepared for it for months, and my examination went really well. But the government cancelled the Constable Recruitment Examination

Today, when the whole country is up in arms about NEET, I have one question for the authorities. Do they even consider the struggles of candidates like us?

due to an organised question paper leak. It affected over 48 lakh aspirants like me. I felt so angry. I was in my mid-20s, most of my peers were married off by then. My parents were convinced that I was wasting my time.

A friend who was in a similar situation suggested we should move out and start supporting ourselves so that we could pursue our dreams without feeling guilty about being a burden on our families. She was moving to Bikaner to work in a nanny centre. The job was suitable because it is respectable and the hours are fixed, which meant we would get time to prepare for examinations.

But the idea of moving out didn't sit well with my parents initially. Both my sisters were married off after college. Here I was, an

unmarried girl, moving to a different city. But my mind was made up, and they reluctantly agreed. I moved to Bikaner in 2025, and after a year, I moved to Noida. The money was better. There are also better coaching centres. I recently wrote the UP Home Guard examinations and am awaiting the results. Today, when the whole country is up in arms about NEET, I have one question for the authorities. Do they even consider the struggle of candidates like us? A leak and a cancellation are not just a news report; it's like losing a chance at a better, more liveable life.

The writer has appeared for various government competitive examinations and is working as a nanny to support herself

CURRENT LOSS PEGGED AT RS 750 CR A DAY; FIGURES EXCLUDE UNDER-RECOVERY ON JET FUEL SALES

Petrol, diesel price hike slashes OMCs' daily losses by Rs 250 cr

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, May 18

THE RS 3-per-litre hike in petrol and diesel prices has provided some relief to public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs), reducing their combined daily losses on sales of the two automobile fuels and liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) by a fourth, or about Rs 250 crore, a senior Petroleum Ministry official said on Monday.

The three OMCs — Indian Oil, Bharat Petroleum, and Hindustan Petroleum — are currently incurring losses of about Rs 750 crore a day by selling petrol, diesel, and LPG below market rates, according to Petroleum Ministry Joint Secretary Sujata Sharma.

She did not comment on whether more fuel price hikes are in the pipeline. Sharma said the loss figures don't include the OMCs' under-recovery on jet fuel sales for domestic flights.

The OMCs hiked petrol and diesel prices by Rs 3 per litre on Friday, the first increase in over four years, as they continue to grapple with financial strain amid the West Asia crisis.

Petrol is now priced at Rs 97.77 per litre, and diesel at Rs 90.67 in New Delhi. Fuel prices vary across states due to differences in state-level taxes. There was no hike in LPG prices since the last increase early March.

As per industry sources and analysts, the quantum of this hike will only partially ease the pressure, as the gap between retail fuel prices and the market price is much wider. More calibrated and staggered price hikes may be on the cards.

"The Rs 3 hike, alongside a marginal softening in crude prices, brings estimated residual under-recoveries down to Rs 10 and Rs 13 per litre, offering OMCs a degree of operational breathing room. The overhang is far from gone, though..." The latest price increase is, therefore, aimed at containing incremental balance sheet stress rather than restoring marketing margins, and is better read as a policy acknowledgement that absorbed costs must eventually reflect in prices," Sehul Bhatt, Director, Crisis Intelligence said Friday.

Global crude oil prices rose by over 50% due to the crisis, but

• STAGGERED HIKES?

OMCs HIKED petrol and diesel prices by Rs 3 per litre on Friday, the first increase in over 4 years

THE QUANTUM of this hike will only partially ease the pressure, as the gap between the retail fuel prices and the market price is much wider

THE GOVERNMENT chose a staggered approach because a one-shot steep price hike would not have been politically palatable, according to experts



CALIBRATED PRICE hikes allow the Centre to pass on the higher prices to consumers gradually, while keeping a tab on public reaction

to protect consumers, the government-owned OMCs didn't pass on the higher rates for retail petrol and diesel. In fact, their prices hadn't been hiked for four years, apart from a cut once before the 2024 Lok Sabha polls.

Discussions on a hike in their prices gathered pace within the government, with a consensus that an increase was necessary. The key considerations were the timing and the quantum: whether to do it im-

minently or hold prices for longer, and whether to announce a steep hike in one go or adopt a staggered approach, as per a top government official.

A staggered approach was evidently chosen. A one-shot steep price hike wouldn't have been politically palatable, and would have had a shock factor, industry sources said.

Calibrated hikes allow the Centre to pass on the higher prices to consumers gradually, while

monitoring public reaction and the inflationary impact on an ongoing basis, instead of the inflationary shock and backlash that a steep hike might lead to.

Apart from a direct bearing on Consumer Price Index (CPI), fuel prices have an indirect impact on inflation as they affect freight and logistics costs, as well as energy and input costs for sectors.

"Given the weightage of petrol and diesel in the CPI basket, a 3-5% increase (in fuel prices) likely adds about 15-25 bps (basis points) to the headline inflation, besides second round impact," Radhika Rao, Senior Economist and Executive Director, DBS Bank said on Friday.

Rao added that the price hike was a "long-anticipated move", and could lead to a bit of moderation in fuel demand. She also recounted that back in 2022, amid the global oil and fuel price surge in the wake of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, retail fuel prices were hiked by about 9-10% in two steps.

The crisis has put the OMCs under severe financial stress.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

CRUDE OIL PRICES, BOND YIELDS SURGE

Rupee hits new low of 96.4, falls for 7th straight day

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, May 18

THE INDIAN rupee weakened for the seventh day in a row on Monday on its way to hitting another all-time low as concerns over the West Asia war continued. Government bond yields, meanwhile, surged to the highest levels in around one-and-a-half months tracking rising interest rates across the world as investors dumped debt instruments.

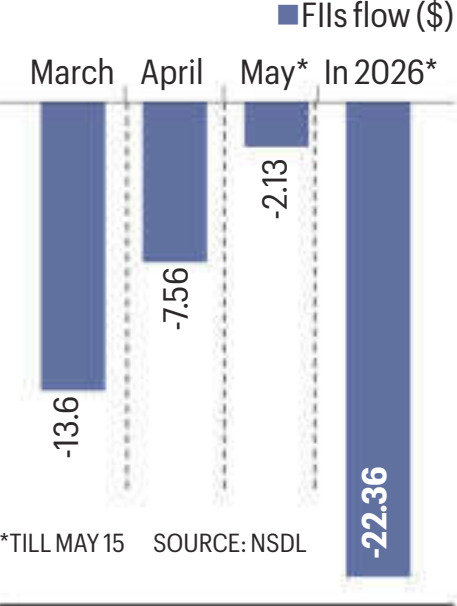
Indian stock indices, however, ended little changed on Monday, although they had slumped 1.4% intraday.

The Sensex ended 0.1% higher at 75,315.04, while the Nifty closed at 23,649.95, up 0.03% from Friday. The market recovery was largely driven by gains in IT services stocks.

"Among the sectoral indices, Nifty IT emerged as the top outperformer, rallying 2.43% amid strong buying interest in technology stocks. Pharma and Private Banking stocks also provided mild positive support to the benchmark indices," Bajaj Broking Research said in a note. "On the other hand, broader selling pressure persisted across several sectors, with Nifty Media, Auto, PSU Banks, and Consumer Durables ending as the major laggards of the session. The broader market remained under pressure, as the Nifty Midcap 100 declined marginally by 0.15%, while the Nifty Smallcap 100 slipped 1.26%."

Although stocks were little changed on the whole, the rupee continued to trend lower,

• Foreign investors pull out funds



*TILL MAY 15 SOURCE: NSDL

falling as low as 96.4-per-dollar before closing the day at 96.36. The rupee is now down 5.6% since the war in West Asia began on February 27 and 6.7% in 2026. It is the worst-performing Asian currency this year.

Monday's weakness in the currency market came as worries continued over the West Asia crisis, with a drone attack setting fire to a nuclear power plant in the United Arab Emirates on Sunday, sending crude oil prices above the \$110-per-barrel mark. Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have sold \$22.4 billion of Indian shares and bonds so far in 2026 on a net basis, per latest data, as fears mount over the size of India's Balance of Payments deficit in 2026-27, which would be the third year in a row that the metric has been in negative territory. And with the deterioration of the BoP — which was \$64 billion in surplus as recently as 2023-24 — predating the on-

going war, economists warn that addressing this situation is an important challenge.

"So, in a sense, we are addressing: (1) a short-term problem of elevated energy prices, which threaten to widen the current account deficit, and (2) a medium-term problem of capital inflows slowing, which pushed the BoP into deficit even before the energy shock struck" HSBC economists said in a note on Monday. They expect the BoP to clock a deficit of \$65 billion this fiscal.

With fears of a sustained increase in inflation rising due to the prolonged nature of the war, bond yields surged globally, including in the US and Japan. Higher bond yields are considered a negative for the equity and currency markets.

In India, the benchmark 10-year government bond ended at 7.13% on Monday, up from 7.06% on Friday. This is the highest level since early April.

Bond yields move in the opposite direction to prices. Earlier this month on May 8, the RBI issued the new 10-year government bond at a coupon of 6.94%. On Monday, it closed at 7.08% and is already trading at a discount of almost one rupee. A higher yield is indicative of a higher cost of borrowing for the government.

The RBI has held the policy repo rate unchanged at 5.25% so far in 2026, with headline retail inflation having stayed below its 4% target. However, wholesale inflation in April skyrocketed to 8.3% — the highest in 42 months. FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

'Russian oil bought regardless of waiver, will keep importing'

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, May 18

INDIA HAS been regularly buying Russian oil irrespective of any sanctions waiver from the US, and will continue to do so with commercial viability of the imports and the country's energy security being the primary considerations, a senior Petroleum Ministry official said on Monday.

Over the weekend, the US allowed its sanctions waiver on importing Russian oil already at sea to expire. The US is yet to confirm if it will be extended. When it expired in April, the US had refused to extend it, only to do so within a few days.

"Regarding the American waiver on Russia, I'd like to emphasise that we have been purchasing from Russia earlier, before waiver also, during waiver also, and now also. So, it is basically the commercial sense, which should be there for the OMCs (oil marketing companies) to purchase (Russian oil)," said Petroleum Ministry Joint Secretary Sujata Sharma.

According to a General License issued by the Office of Foreign Assets Control of the US Department of the Treasury last on April 17, Russian oil and petroleum products loaded on tankers, including sanctioned vessels, on or before 12:01 eastern daylight time (9:31 am IST) on April 17 could be purchased and received by most countries till May 16.

The previous waiver issued in March expired on April 11.

Its renewal came two days after US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said that it won't be extended. As per industry experts, the decision to extend it till mid-May likely came after pressure from countries buying

The waiver helped Indian refiners take deliveries even on tankers under sanction, and deal directly with the sanctioned firms

Russian crude to partly offset the loss of Gulf barrels due to the Strait of Hormuz closure.

With global oil supplies hit due to the effective halt in vessel movements, such waivers were aimed at allowing more barrels to reach the global market and exerting downward pressure on spiralling oil prices.

Experts saw the moves as part of the Trump administration's effort to prevent a sustained spike in global oil prices, aiming to keep domestic fuel costs down ahead of this year's midterm elections. However, Russian oil waiver drew criticism from various US sections.

Critics argued that it led to a windfall for Moscow, which will fund its war in Ukraine. These arguments were also made against the waiver for purchase of Iranian oil, with whom the US was locked in battle in West Asia.

While Washington took a U-turn and extended the Russian waiver, it didn't renew the Iranian waiver.

While government officials maintained India didn't require a US waiver to buy Russian oil, experts said it helped. The waiver enabled refiners to take deliveries even on tankers under sanction, and deal directly with sanctioned firms. It temporarily eased India's friction with the US over hefty purchases of Moscow's crude. FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• FY27 BoP DEFICIT SEEN AT \$65 BILLION: HSBC

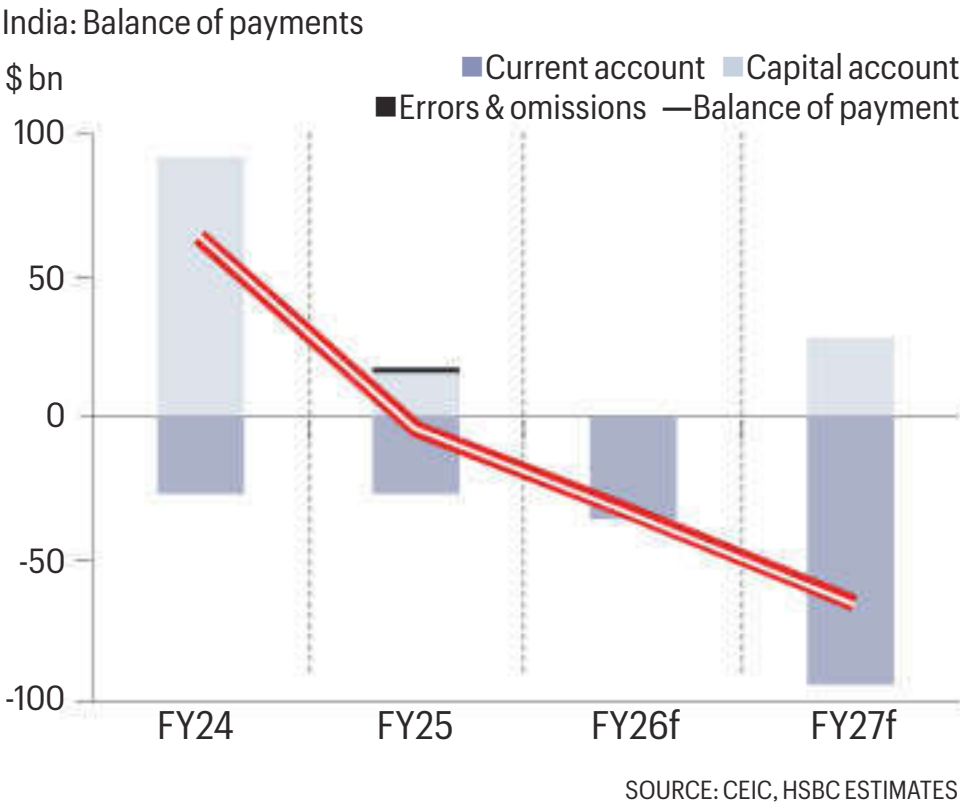
In the first 20 years of the 21st century, India posted a Balance of Payments (BoP) deficit on only 3 occasions: FY09, FY12, and FY19. Since then, these deficits have occurred more regularly, in FY23, FY25, and the first 3 quarters of FY26, as per data. Altogether, the BoP deficit in these years is estimated to be around \$81 billion. However, as per HSBC economists, FY27 by itself may see a BoP deficit of about \$65 billion.

"We assume that the sharp outflow from equity markets is arrested as FY27 progresses. We also assume that gross FDI inflows remain similar to FY26 levels. Estimates could change if policymakers announce new measures to attract inflows," HSBC said in a note on Monday.

1 The worsening of India's Balance of Payments predates the current energy crisis.

2 A BoP deficit of \$65 billion in FY27 would be almost twice the \$35 billion HSBC estimates for FY26.

A higher c/a deficit is likely to be the key driver of a wider BoP deficit in FY27



SOURCE: CEIC, HSBC ESTIMATES

US-based insurer Liberty Mutual raises stake in Indian arm to 74%

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, May 18

US-BASED Liberty Mutual Insurance has hiked its stake in Liberty General Insurance Ltd (LGI) to 74% from 55.40%, highlighting the growing footprint of foreign insurers in India.

This marks the American insurer's second expansion, following a previous stake increase from 49% to 55.40% in September 2025.

On Sunday, Prudential plc of the UK said it will acquire a 75% stake in Bharti Life Insurance Company Ltd for an initial cash consideration of Rs 3,500 crore (\$389 million).

The company did not disclose the financial details of the increase in stake.

LGI commenced operations

in 2013 to provide comprehensive retail, commercial and industrial insurance solutions.

The company has an employee strength of over 1,300 and its presence spans across 95 locations in 28 states and Union Territories. Its partner network includes over 6,500 hospitals and more than 6,100 auto service centres.

The firm provides a wide range of insurance products in India, including health and personal accident cover, motor insurance for cars and two-wheelers, employee compensation and commercial insurance, along with specialised solutions such as surety, engineering, marine, liability and property insurance.

Parag Ved, Chief Executive Officer and Whole-Time Direc-

tor, Liberty General Insurance, said, "With stronger backing from Liberty Mutual, we are now better positioned to expand our distribution footprint and deepen our presence across retail and commercial line segments. Our focus remains on building a business that is consistent, resilient, and built on sound fundamentals, while remaining adaptable in a market defined by constant change."

Liberty Mutual Insurance Group is ranked 91st among Fortune 500 companies and is the 9th largest property and casualty insurer globally, with \$178.2 billion in assets and \$50.5 billion in revenues in 2025.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Govt eases quality control norms for import of certain compressors

New Delhi: The Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) has allowed manufacturers of air-conditioning and refrigeration equipment to import specified quantities of certain compressors without complying with the mandatory Quality Control Order (QCO) till March 31, 2027. The department has issued the Air-Conditioner and its related Parts, Hermetic Compressor and Temperature Sensing Controls (Quality Control) Amendment Order, 2026, in this regard on May 8.

"This order shall not apply to goods or articles specified... imported by a manufacturer of air conditioning and refrigeration equipment and related parts for the purposes of its own manufacturing, up to 31st March, 2027, to the volume specified," the order said. PTI

hicles, according to an order reviewed by Reuters.

The order, part of a broader austerity push, will cover institutions like the State Bank of India, Bank of Baroda and Life Insurance Corp of India and their employees.

Under the new measures, all meetings, reviews and con-

sultations must be conducted via video conferencing unless physical presence is deemed essential, the order issued by the Department of Financial Services said.

Separately, the government has asked the organisations to accelerate adoption of electric vehicles.

• BRIEFLY

TVS Motor to buy 4.9% stake in Jana Small Finance Bank

New Delhi: TVS Motor Company Ltd on Monday said it will acquire 4.9% stake in Jana Small Finance Bank Ltd for Rs 193.32 crore. The acquisition is part of a deal by TVS VENU to acquire a minority stake in Jana Small Finance Bank Ltd through a combination of primary issuance of warrants and a secondary purchase for an equity ownership of up to 9.9% on a fully diluted basis, which includes 4.9% to be owned by TVS Motor Company, it said in a regulatory filing. "This investment in Jana is aligned with TVS VENU's long-term approach to support high-quality institutions that serve India's growing financial needs and its expanding digital financial ecosystem. Jana Small Finance Bank has built a credible banking franchise with a strong presence across customer segments central to India's credit, savings, and investment growth," TVS Motor Company Chairman Sudarshan Venu said. PTI

Keeping close watch on supply shock: RBI Guv

Mumbai: The RBI is keeping a close vigil on whether and when supply shocks get embedded in the general price level, warranting monetary policy action, Governor Sanjay Malhotra has said amid persisting global uncertainties. During a panel discussion titled 'Monetary Policy in a Time of Heightened Uncertainty' jointly organised by the Swiss National Bank and the IMF in Switzerland last week, he said India is used to frequent supply shocks. PTI

'Commercial oil inventories depleting rapidly'

Paris: Fatih Birol, head of the IEA, said Monday that commercial oil inventories were depleting rapidly with only a few weeks worth left due to the Iran war and the closure of Strait of Hormuz. Birol, who is participating in the Group of Seven finance leaders meeting, said the release of strategic oil reserves had added 2.5 million barrels of oil per day to the market, but said these reserves "are not endless". REUTERS

• MARKETS

Sensex 75,315.04 77.05 0.10%	NIFTY 23,649.95 6.45 0.03%	Gold ₹1,62,800	US Dollar ₹96.35
		Silver ₹2,76,000	Oil \$110.73
NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER ALL INDIA SARAFI ASSOCIATION DATA GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF MAY 15, 2026			

• WHITE HOUSE STATEMENT DROPS REFERENCE TO ELIMINATION OF CHINA'S EXPORT CONTROL REGIME; FLAGS INDIUM SHORTAGES FOR THE FIRST TIME

US gets small rare earth win, but China's export curbs will stay

Reuters
Beijing, May 18

CHINA WILL address US concerns about rare earth shortages, the White House said on Sunday in a recap of agreements struck at last week's leaders summit that fell short of calling for the removal of restrictions that have disrupted US aerospace and semiconductor manufacturing.

Introduced in April 2025 in retaliation for US President Donald Trump's so-called Liberation Day tariffs, Beijing's controls continue to tightly restrict exports of certain rare earths despite a deal at last October's Busan summit where the White

House said China committed to "effectively eliminate" all current and proposed critical mineral export controls.

Six months on, the White House's latest statement now acknowledges that China's export control regime will stay. It also did not mention whether a one-year truce on a wider set of Chinese rare earth restrictions, due to expire in November, will be extended. The Sunday fact sheet summarising key takeaways from the summit said China will address US concerns about shortages of critical minerals and rare earths including yttrium, scandium and indium.

It also said China would address US concerns over export



China's indium exports dropped dramatically, plummeting by about two-thirds globally in 14 months since February 2025. REUTERS

curbs on rare earth processing technology, which Beijing tightly guards to protect domestic producers responsible

for almost all of the world's production. Unlike the White House, China's Ministry of Commerce made no mention

of rare earths in its own summary published on Saturday.

While rare earth export licences are flowing to sectors like autos and consumer electronics, firms in sensitive sectors where rare earths have potential military applications continue to face delays.

Indium and chips

One critical mineral mentioned for the first time by the White House is indium, which plays a key role in the upstream and downstream semiconductor supply chain and has been on a Chinese export control list since February 2025. Its compound indium phosphide is crucial for making next-gener-

ation photonic chips that use light instead of electricity to process data, as well as high-speed optical lasers used in optical fibre and 6G networks. Another compound, indium tin oxide, is used to make LED screens.

Manufacturers like Coherent are stepping up production of photonic chips that are rapidly being integrated into the development of AI data centres around the world.

Chinese exports of indium have fallen dramatically in the 14 months since February 2025 versus the same period the year before, customs data showed. Shipments are down by about two-thirds globally and by 77% to the US.

In Iraqi desert, 2 Israeli outposts were ‘kept secret’ for months

Israeli forces began preparing base in late 2024

Erika Solomon & Fahih Hassan
May 18

THE TRUCK rattling by at 2 pm March 3 was a familiar sight to residents of the Bedouin encampment in Iraq's rugged western desert — a local shepherd's pickup, en route to the nearest town of al-Nukhaib.

Its return a few hours later, flaming and riddled with bullets, was anything but routine.

A helicopter was chasing the truck, three witnesses from the camp said, firing on it repeatedly until it jerked to a halt in the sand.

The deadly attack, which has not been previously reported, took place after Awad al-Shammari, 29, set off on a grocery trip, his cousin, Amir al-Shammari, told *The New York Times*. Instead of making it home, the shepherd stumbled upon a closely guarded Israeli military secret, hidden in the Iraqi desert. His family believes it cost him his life.

Awad al-Shammari's discovery would ultimately reveal how Iraq had played host to two covert bases operated intermit-

tently by Israel, a hostile state, for well over a year.

Sometime between starting his ill-fated trip and its gruesome end, al-Shammari had contacted Iraq's regional military command to report what he had seen: soldiers, helicopters and tents clustered around a landing strip. Israel was operating a base there to support its military operations against Baghdad's regional partner, Iran, according to senior Iraqi and regional officials.

The presence of an Israeli outpost in Iraq was previously reported by *The Wall Street Journal*. Iraqi officials told the *Times* there was another undisclosed second base, also in Iraq's

western desert.

The base al-Shammari came across predated the current war between the United States, Israel and Iran, the regional security officials said, and was used during the 12-day war against Tehran in June 2025.

Israeli forces began preparing to build the makeshift base as far back as late 2024, one of the regional officials said — identifying remote sites from which to operate in future conflicts.

Israel's military declined repeated requests for comment on the camps or on al-Shammari's killing. The witnesses to al-Shammari's death spoke on the condition of anonymity, citing concerns for their safety. Most of

the officials who discussed the Israeli bases insisted on anonymity to discuss a highly sensitive security matter.

The information they shared indicates that at least one of the bases — the one al-Shammari stumbled upon — had been known to Washington since June 2025 or possibly earlier. That would most likely mean Baghdad's other key ally, the United States, had withheld from Iraq the fact that hostile forces were on its soil.

"It shows a blatant disregard for Iraqi sovereignty, its government and its forces, as well as for the dignity of the Iraqi people," said Waad al-Kadu, an Iraqi lawmaker who attended a confiden-

tial parliamentary briefing about that base. The US role in Iraqi security was part of Israel's calculations in deciding it could safely operate clandestinely in Iraq, the regional officials said.

In both the brief war last year and the current conflict, two Iraqi security officials said, Washington compelled Iraq to shut down its radars to protect U.S. aircraft, making Baghdad more reliant on U.S. forces to detect hostile activity.

The disclosure of the bases raises uncomfortable questions for Iraq, too. Among them: Were its forces really unaware of a foreign presence until a shepherd exposed it? Or did they know, but chose to ignore it?

NYT

Elon Musk loses lawsuit against Altman's OpenAI

In a unanimous verdict, court says Musk brought his case too late



OpenAI CEO Sam Altman (left), CEO of SpaceX & Tesla Elon Musk

Reuters
Oakland, May 18

A US jury on Monday ruled against Elon Musk in his lawsuit against OpenAI, finding the artificial intelligence company not liable to the world's richest person for having allegedly strayed from its original mission to benefit humanity.

In a unanimous verdict, the jury in Oakland, California federal court said Musk had brought his case too late. The trial began on April 28. It has widely been seen as a critical moment for the future of OpenAI and artificial intelligence, both in how it should be used and who should benefit from it, including financially.

The verdict followed 11 days of testimony and arguments where Musk's and Altman's credibility came under repeated attack. Each side accused the other of being more interested in money than serving the public.

In his closing argument, Musk's lawyer Steven Molo reminded jurors that several witnesses questioned Altman's candor or branded him a liar, and that Musk did not give an unqualified yes when asked during the trial if he was com-

pletely trustworthy. "Sam Altman's credibility is directly at issue," Molo said. "If you don't believe him, they cannot win."

Musk accused OpenAI of wrongfully trying to enrich investors and insiders at the non-profit's expense, and failing to prioritize AI's safety. He also contended Microsoft knew all along that OpenAI cared more about money than being altruistic.

OpenAI countered that it was Musk who saw dollar signs, and that he waited too long to claim OpenAI breached its founding agreement to build safe artificial intelligence to benefit humanity.

"Mr. Musk may have the Midas touch in some areas, but not in AI," William Savitt, a lawyer for OpenAI, said in his closing argument. OpenAI competes with AI companies such as Anthropic and xAI, and is preparing for a possible initial public offering that could value the business at \$1 trillion.

Microsoft has spent more than \$100 billion on its partnership with OpenAI. Musk's xAI is now part of his space and rocket company SpaceX, which is preparing a IPO that could exceed OpenAI's in size.

‘Cypher’ cable: Imran Russia visit irked US, led to ouster as Pak PM

Press Trust of India
Washington, Islamabad, May 18

A LEAKED diplomatic cable suggests that the United States' ire at then-Pakistan Prime Minister Imran Khan for his trip to Russia on February 24, 2022, the day of the attack on Ukraine, played a role in his removal from the office, according to an American media outlet.

The *Drop Site News* released a copy of the classified cable called "cypher", sent by Pakistan's envoy to the US Asad Majeed Khan to the Foreign Secretary in Islamabad, documenting his meeting with US Assistant Secretary of State for South and Central Asia Donald Lu on March 7, 2022.

According to the cable, the US official told the Pakistani envoy that Khan's visit to Russia had "created a dent" in the bilateral relationship and suggested that "all will be forgiven" if the no-confidence motion against the Prime Minister succeeded.

"I would argue that it has already created a dent in the relationship from our perspective. Let us just wait for a few days to see whether the political situation changes, which would mean that we would not have a big disagreement about this issue, and the dent would go away quickly," Lu told the Pakistani envoy during meeting.

U.S. PRESIDENT TRUMP SAYS HE HAS INSTRUCTED MILITARY TO BE READY FOR ‘FULL SCALE ASSAULT’

‘Called off Iran strike planned for today at Gulf allies’ request’

Reuters & AP
Washington, Dubai, Karachi, May 18

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said he is holding off on a "full, large scale" military strike on Iran planned for Tuesday because "serious negotiations" are underway.

The President did not offer details about the planned attack but said he instructed the US military "to be prepared to go forward with a full, large scale assault of Iran, on a moment's notice, in the event that an acceptable deal is not reached."

Trump said in his social media post that he was calling off the planned strike at the request of allies in West Asia, including the leaders of Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates.

Earlier on Monday, Iran sent a new peace proposal to the US with terms that appeared similar to offers Washington has previously rejected, although a senior Iranian official told Reuters on Monday that the US had softened positions on some issues.

A Pakistani source confirmed that Islamabad, which has conveyed messages between the sides in the war in West Asia since hosting the only round of peace talks last month,



Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian (right) with Pakistan Interior Minister Naqvi in Tehran on Sunday. REUTERS

had shared the latest proposal with Washington. But the source suggested progress had been difficult. The sides "keep changing their goalposts," the Pakistani source said, adding: "We don't have much time."

Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei confirmed that Tehran's views had been "conveyed to the American side through Pakistan" but gave no details. Washington did not comment.

The Iranian proposal, as described by the senior Iranian source, appeared similar in

many respects to Iran's previous offer, which US President Donald Trump rejected last week as "garbage".

It would focus first on securing an end to the war, reopening the Strait of Hormuz - a major oil supply route that Iran has effectively blockaded - and lifting maritime sanctions. More contentious issues around Iran's nuclear programme and uranium enrichment would be deferred to later rounds, the source said.

However, in an apparent softening of Washington's stance, the senior Iranian source said

the United States had agreed to release a quarter of Iran's frozen funds - totaling tens of billions of dollars - held in foreign banks. Iran wants all the assets released.

The Iranian source also said Washington had showed more flexibility in allowing Iran to continue some peaceful nuclear activity under supervision of the International Atomic Energy Agency. Iran's *Tasnim* news agency separately quoted an unidentified source as saying the US had accepted waiving oil sanctions on Iran while negotiations were under way.

Israel, Hezbollah war continues as Lebanon death toll tops 3,000

Beirut: Israel carried out airstrikes in southern Lebanon on Monday, Lebanese security sources and the state news agency said, while Hezbollah announced new attacks on Israeli forces, continuing the war in Lebanon despite the extension of a US-backed truce.

Since the war began on March 2, more than 3,000 people have been killed in Lebanon, the country's health ministry reported in its latest casualty toll on Monday. Reignited by the US-Israeli conflict with Iran, hostilities between Iran-backed Hezbollah and Israel persisted since US President Donald Trump first announced a ceasefire on April 16.

A 45-day ceasefire extension, announced after a third round of US-hosted talks between Lebanon and Israel on Friday, began at midnight, a Lebanese official said. The US-led mediation has emerged in parallel to diplomacy aimed at ending the US-Iran conflict.

REUTERS

Maldives probes if Italian divers went too deep in fatal cave dive

Reuters
Male, May 18

MALDIVIAN AUTHORITIES are investigating multiple possible factors behind the deaths of five Italian divers in a deepwater cave last week, including whether they descended far deeper than expected, a government spokesperson told *Reuters*.

The group that entered the cave on Thursday was led by Monica Montefalcone, 51, a University of Genoa professor and marine ecologist who was a regular diver in Maldivian waters in the Indian Ocean.

Her daughter was among the four researchers who died, along with an instructor. The instructor's body is the only one that has been recovered so far, from a depth of 60 metres.

Mohamed Hussain Shareef, chief spokesperson at the Maldives president's office, said the government had given the the group the necessary permit to research soft corals in the Devana Kandu site. "What we didn't know was that it was cave diving," Shareef said. "Because, as divers will tell you and appreciate, it's a very different discipline with its own sets of challenges and risks involved, and particularly at that depth, there are any number of things that could have gone wrong."

Expert divers from Finland spotted the four remaining bodies on Monday inside the cave's third and last chamber, "pretty much together," Shareef said. The plan is to recover two of the bodies on Tuesday and the other two on Wednesday.

Hantavirus-hit cruise ship docks in Netherlands for disinfection

Rotterdam: The cruise ship hit by a deadly hantavirus outbreak has docked at the Dutch port of Rotterdam for disinfection, wrapping up a troubled journey that put international health authorities on alert.

The *MV Hndius* was still carrying 25 crew members and two medical personnel as it reached Europe's largest port on Monday morning, after its passengers disembarked on the island of Tenerife last week.

The crew will now go into quarantine, with those who cannot be immediately repatriated spending their time in quarantine in these containers.

"Luckily so far the crew has suffered no symptoms," Yvonne van Duijnhoven, the director of public health in Rotterdam told *The Associated Press*. AP



Android Monks

Participants including Buddhist monks holding Lotus Lanterns, and Android robot monks take part in a Lotus Lantern parade ahead of Lord Buddha's birthday in Seoul, South Korea, on Monday. REUTERS

● HIROKAZU KOREEDA'S FILM FAILS TO DIG DEEPER AND COME UP WITH THE KIND OF TRUTH BOMBS HE TEASES OUT OF HIS STORIES

Evolving nature of grief in AI age: Exploring the future with *Sheep In The Box*



SHUBHRA GUPTA

THERE CANNOT be anything more timely than the premise of Hirokazu Koreeda's Cannes Competition entry *Sheep In The Box*, which deals with the evolving nature of grief in the age of AI: A couple who've lost their young son bring home a humanoid android, who looks and sounds exactly like their boy.

It is when Kakeru (Rimu

Kuwaki) begins to show signs of thinking like their son that Otone (Ayase Haruka) and Kensuke (Daigo Yamamoto) start wondering about the larger implications of their actions.

The question — does a machine have a soul — has been at the heart of such discussions for a long time.

Those with long memories may remember famous science fiction writer Isaac Asimov toying with the revolutionary idea (at the time of his writing from the 1930s to the 1950s) of sentient robots from his earliest work. Phillip K Dick, who many thought carried Asimov's legacy forward,

wrote his legendary book in 1968, which was called *Do Androids Dream Of Electric Sheep*. I wouldn't be surprised if Koreeda's title is a variation.

Back in those days, it must have felt that this kind of thing was safely in the future, but the rapid developments in AI have made everything possible.

The film is set "sometime in the near future", where drones are used domestically, and microwave dinners appear to have replaced the labour of endless cooking.

But being able to replace an actual human with a robot, without it creating challenges, is easier said than done.

You may be able to replicate



A still from *Sheep In The Box*. FESTIVAL DE CANNES

human DNA, but can you allay grief? What happens to memories vested in the one who's

gone? Is grief now a commodity? Dad Kinsuke is a little more sceptical and resistant around

the new entrant. But Mom Otone has suspended disbelief much faster: you can see her melt when Kakeru 2.0 says, "I'm home." When this version of Kakeru needs "charging", he sits on a chair; he also cannot go off too far because the tracker in his system stops sending signals.

It's all quite sweet, with both parents trying to adjust to their new reality. It's when Otone's meddling mom, and sister (with her kids) show up without warning, that the s#*t hits the fan.

On the one hand is the shock and horror of the humans. On the other is Kakeru's discovery that a silent rebel-

lion has been brewing amongst his kind, and a bunch of android kids are gathering together in a shed, to plot and plan.

At this point, the film could have swerved off the family territory, and gone to a more complicated place — complex human relations have been at the beating heart of Koreeda's best work, which has argued that it isn't always blood that binds. The connection could be as strong, if not stronger, amongst those who think alike.

But this is one of those rare Koreeda's films which fail to dig deeper and come up with the kind of truth bombs he teases out of his stories.

A faint promise emerges when the concept of wooden blocks carrying memories of their source (trees being the source of life) starts to get a bit of play, but even that turns into bland exchanges between mother and son.

In some ways, there's an ET-go-home vibe in the way the androids band together, and it could truly have become an exploration of how humans and ultra-smart machines will have to learn to coexist in coming times.

But there's little depth on display, and we are left with a film which belies its potential to be extraordinary, by staying disappointingly mundane.

OFFICE OF THE RESIDENT COMMISSIONER
GOVT. OF MADHYA PRADESH

MADHYA PRADESH BHAWAN PLOT NO. 29 C-D, JESUS & MARY MARG,
CHANAKYAPURI, NEW DELHI-110021 Phone No. 011-26772001, 2002

Dated: 15/05/2026

TENDER NOTICE

Online tenders for Annual Supply of Stationery items at Madhya Pradesh Bhawan Plot No. 29 C-D Jesus and Mary Marg Chanakya Puri New Delhi-110021 are invited in single stage two envelope systems (Technical bid & Financial bid) through e-Tendering website www.mptenders.gov.in or www.mpbhawan.gov.in. in the prescribed proforma from interested parties/ Registered Firms/ Registered Companies/Reputed Organizations/ Agencies for one year.

Pre-bid meeting	28.05.2026 at 03:00 pm
Last date and time of submission	02.06.2026 upto 03:00p.m.
Date and Time of Opening of Technical Bid	03.06.2026 at 03:00 p.m.
Date and Time of Opening of Financial Bid of qualified bidder	11.06.2026 at 03:00 p.m.
Probable cost of work	₹ 6,00,000/-
EMD	₹18000/- (to be paid online)
Cost of Tender Document	₹ 500/- (to be paid online)

Addl. Resident Commissioner
M.P. Bhawan, New Delhi

NO-G13032-26



OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER
KANPUR MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

Ref no- D/ 28/C.E./C.M.G./26-27

Date- 18-05-2026

E-Procurement Tender Notice

Nagar Nigam Kanpur invites percentage rate bids on <http://etender.up.nic.in> from eligible bidders for the following package under the CM-GRID Scheme Phase-3.

Sl. No.	Package No.	Nagar Nigam	Road ID	Included Roads	Length of Road (km)	Estimated Cost Excluding GST (Rs. Lakh)	Total Estimated Cost of Work (Rs. In Lakh)	Earnest Money Deposit (Rs. In Lakh)	Duration of Construction Work (in Months)	Tender Fee Including GST
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
1	Package 01	Kanpur Municipal Corporation	KMC/CMG/25-26/PK-G-01	Improvement of road from Gurudev Road To ICAI Bhawan Road & Awadhputi Road Under Zone -06.	1.942	3756.69	67.41	3824.10	76.49	15
TOTAL					1.942	3756.69	67.41	3824.10	76.49	15

Sr No	Event	Date & Time
1	Availability of tender document on E-Tender portal of NIC.	19.05.2026,03:00 After noon
2	Date & Place of Pre-bid meeting	29.05.2026 3:00 PM URIDA Head Quarter, Directorate urban local Bodies Lucknow/Online Email:-chiefengineernagarnigam@gmail.com
3	Last date and Online for submission of bid on E-Tender Portal	09.06.2026, up to 3:00PM
4	Opening of tender (technical bid)	09.06.2026, 4:00 PM
5	Tender ID	"CMGRIDS"

Any Corrigendum/addendum or any other additional information related to the tender shall be available at Kanpur Nagar Nigam Website- kmc.up.nic.in and tender can be seen at e-tender portal from 19.05.2026 i.e. <http://etender.up.nic.in>
Under IBT Clause-10, Kanpur Nagar Nigam has right to issue corrigendum/addendum which will not publish in any newspaper. All bidders are advised to keep watch on E-tender portal on daily basis. Any corrigendum/addendum or any other additional information related to the tender will be available at Kanpur Nagar Nigam Website kmc.up.nic.in and tender can be seen at e-tender portal from 19.05.2026 i.e. <http://etender.up.nic.in>
It will be mandatory to pay the Earnest Money and Tender Fee price of the said tender online through e-tender portal during online bid submission.
Any queries/complain related to tender can be sent before 24 Hrs. of Pre-bid meeting date and time i.e. 28.05.2026 at e-mail-id of chiefengineernagarnigam@gmail.com and urda.goup@gmail.com, so that queries can be resolved at Pre-Bid meeting.
No queries/complain will entertain after 29.05.2026, 3:00 PM.

Sd/- Chief Engineer, Kanpur Municipal Corporation

SURAT MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
Light & Energy Efficiency Cell
FIT INDIA

Online Tender Notice No: - ACE (Ele/Mech)/ Light & EEC/02/ 2026-2027

Bid(s) are invited for the following work through online process on <https://smctender.nprocure.com> from experienced Suppliers/ contractors/ Agencies.

(1) Name of Department :-	Light and Energy Efficiency Cell
(2) Nos. of Work :-	04

The detailed notice will be made available on website www.suratmunicipal.gov.in

No. P.R.O./32/2026-27 Additional City Engineer (Ele/Mech),
Date: 18/05/2026 Surat Municipal Corporation

NORTHERN RAILWAY
PROCLAMATION REQUIRED THE APPEARANCE OF
ACCUSED PERSON (SEE SECTION 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that that accused **Nitin Saini S/o Jaibhagwan, R/O House No. 148, Vidya Peeth School Ke Pas, Bhorgarh, Narela, Delhi-110040** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) an offence Case Crime No. 11/2022 of Railway Protection Force Post, Adarsh Nagar which is punishable under section 3 (a) Railway Property (Unlawful Possession) Act and a warrant of arrest thereupon issued which has been returned un-executed stating that the said accused **Nitin Saini S/o Jaibhagwan** cannot be found on his permanent and local addresses and his other whereabouts are unknown and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Nitin Saini S/o Jaibhagwan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Nitin Saini S/o Jaibhagwan** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.07.2026**.

By order
Shri Vaibhav Garg,
Judicial Magistrate,
First Class-11, Central Court No. 138,
First floor, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi
1649/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

KARNATAKA STATE ROAD TRANSPORT CORPORATION
Central Offices, Mechanical Engg., Dept., K.H. Road, Shanthinagar, Bengaluru-560027, Tel No: 080-22221321 EXT: 291

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
SHORT TERM TENDER NO: KSRTC/2026-27/ IND0298 (T-150) Dated:18/05/2026
(Through KPP Portal Mode only)

(1) Short term Tender is invited through KPP Portal for supply of 400 Nos. BS-VI diesel fully built Mofussil buses for KSRTC.
(2) Tender Value Approximate: **Rs. 160.00 Crores.**
(3) Last Date for Bid Submission in KPP portal: **03/06/2026@17:00 Hours.**

Further, any addendum/corrigendum in respect of change in calendar of events, specification, scope, other tender terms & conditions etc., will be uploaded/Published through KPP Portal only.

NOTE: Interested Bidders need to register in the KPP portal.

Interested Bidders may log into <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> for details. In case of further assistance, the bidders may contact e-procurement Help Desk for support Ph:080-22230960 & 080-22234115 or email at eprocurementhelpdesk@gmail.com. Interested suppliers may also contact e-procurement cell for training on bid submission. E-mail to eprocurementhelpdesk@gmail.com for further information if required.

Sd/-
Chief Mechanical Engineer
(Tender Inviting Authority)

DIPR/CP/JA/724/2026-27

Distt. Programme Officer (CDS)
Women & Child Development Department,
Phone No. 0124-2331148

जिला कार्यक्रम अधिकारी, महिला एवं बाल विकास, गुरुग्राम।
ई-निविदा सूचना

महिला एवं बाल विकास विभाग के अर्न्तगत वर्ष 2026-27 के लिए जिला गुरुग्राम के आंगनवाडी केन्द्रों के लिए खाद्य सामग्री / अन्य सामान को सप्लाय हेतु टेंडरिंग प्रोसेस को ई-निविदाई आमन्त्रित की जाती है जिसका ई-टेंडर नं० 2026_HRY_522003_1 है।

ऑन-लाईन ई-निविदाई भरने की अन्तिम तिथि 26.05.2026 को सायं 5:00 बजे तक है, उपरोक्त निविदा अतिरिक्त उपायुक्त, गुरुग्राम की अध्यक्षता में विभाग द्वारा गठित जिला स्तरीय कमेटी द्वारा दिनांक 28.05.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे खोली जाएगी। इच्छुक उम्मीदवार जो सभी नियम व शर्तें पूरी करते हों, इन्हें भर सकते हैं।

अधिक जानकारी के लिए दस्तावेज जिसमें सभी नियम व शर्तें शामिल हैं, उन्हें वेबसाइट <https://etenders.hry.nic.in> में देखे / डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं।

हस्ता/-
जिला कार्यक्रम अधिकारी.
महिला एवं बाल विकास, गुरुग्राम।
No. 45269/HRY

NORTHERN RAILWAY
NOTICE INVITING APPLICATIONS

Notice Inviting Applications for appointment of Halt Contractor at 37 Halt Stations over Delhi Division.

1 Notice Inviting Application No. : 631-CP-Halt Tender-2023
2 Name of the work and its locations : Appointment of "37" Halt Contractors at 37 Halt Stations for sale of unserved tickets on commission basis for a period of Five Years (05) over Delhi Division.
3 Tender Type : Open Application
4 Date & time for submission of application and opening of the application: Applications in sealed envelope will be accepted from 19.05.2026 to 08.06.2026 (From 10:00 to 17:00 hrs.) and on 09.06.2026 up to 14:00 hrs. and same will be opened on 09.06.2026 at 15:00 hrs. at Commercial Branch DRM Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055.
5 Where complete details of application can be seen : Application Notice and Application Documents is available at Northern Railway website i.e. www.nr.indianrailways.gov.in PDF format.
6 Halt application submit mode : The applications can submit their application in both mode i.e. either Offline or Online modes.
7 Halt application submit by offline mode : The applications who wish to apply through Offline may submit their applications along with all the prescribed relevant documents in a sealed cover in the Office of the Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/PS, Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110055 w.e.f. 19.05.2026 to 08.06.2026 (From 10:00 to 17:00 hrs.) and on 09.06.2026 up to 14:00 hrs. and same will be opened on 09.06.2026 at 15:00 hrs.
8 Halt application submit by online mode : The applications who wish to apply through Online may submit their applications at the following e-mail address: srdcm.ndls@gmail.com w.e.f. 19.05.2026 to 09.06.2026 up to 14:00 hrs. and same will be opened on 09.06.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

No.: 631-CP-Halt Tender-2023 Date: 18.05.2026 1648/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
T. Tender No.- 230-Elect/TRD/PRY/JE-Tender Notice/ 2026/635 Date 15.05.2026
E-Tender Notice

Sr. Divl. Electrical Engineer/TRD/N.C. Rly/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following E-Tender, the details of the tenders are as under:-

T. No.: 230-TRD-WC-1024-2026

Description of work: Replacement of overaged/weak Catenary wire in Prayagraj Division.

Advised Value: ₹ 80,84,490.00 Bid Security: ₹ 1,61,700.00
Completion Period: 12 months Bidding System: Single Packet

Tender Closing date & Time: 08.06.2026 & 14.00 Hrs.
Tender Opening date & Time: 08.06.2026 & 15.00 Hrs.

Note- 1. The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders shall be available on Website www.ireps.gov.in 21 days prior to the of opening of the tender. 3. Bids other than in the form of E-Bid shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate. 4. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 11/26 FA

North central railways @ CPONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

उत्तराखण्ड पॉवर कारपोरेशन लिमिटेड
(उत्तराखण्ड सरकार का उपक्रम) कॉर्पोरेट आईडेंटिटी नं० U40109UR2001SGC025867
विक्टोरिया कोस विजेता मर सिंह कर्जा भवन, कांशी रोड, देहरादून 248001
ईमेल आईडी:- ndg@upcl.org वेबसाइट:- www.upcl.org दूरभाष:-135-2763672-75 Ext:-170,250

पत्रांक : 363/EE(CM)/UPCL/A-2 दिनांक : 18.05.2026

निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना
(निविदा सं० 01 /आईटीओ/यूपीसीएल/2026-27 दिनांक 18.05.2026)
उत्तराखण्ड पावर कारपोरेशन लिमिटेड, देहरादून के "डेस्कटॉप कंप्यूटर और सहयोगी उपकरणों की दशा में अंतिम तिथि अगले कार्यदिवस पर उसी समय लागू होगी। उपरोक्त निविदा में मतिथि में कोई भी संशोधन/सुद्धिपत्र केवल <https://ukntenders.gov.in> एवं <https://upcl.uk.gov.in> पर ही अपलोड किया जायेगा।

अधिशारी अगिन्यात (आईटीओ)

विस्तृत दस्तावेज, पात्रता मानदण्ड और निविदा जमा करने का निर्धारित प्रारूप दिनांक 20 मई 2026 से वेबसाइट <https://ukntenders.gov.in> एवं <https://upcl.uk.gov.in> पर उपलब्ध रहेगा। उपरोक्त तिथियों में से किसी भी दिन अवकाश होने की दशा में अंतिम तिथि अगले कार्यदिवस पर उसी समय लागू होगी। उपरोक्त निविदा में मतिथि में कोई भी संशोधन/सुद्धिपत्र केवल <https://ukntenders.gov.in> एवं <https://upcl.uk.gov.in> पर ही अपलोड किया जायेगा।

अधिशारी अगिन्यात (आईटीओ)

"सद्वृत्ति में बिजली बचारे, बिजली बचाने हेतु एलईडी बल्ब का प्रयोग करें।"
(टोल फ्री नं० 1812) विद्युत बिजली के 24x7 ऑनलाईन मुताबत हेतु www.upcl.org पर जाएं
(विद्युत चोरी की सूचना टोल फ्री नं० 18001804185 /फैक्स नं० 0135-2760911 पर दें)

WESTERN RAILWAY VADODARA DIVISION
OHE MODIFICATION WORK
OPEN 'E' Tender Notice Tender No. EL/TRD/Tender/26-27-09 Tenders for and on behalf of The President of India are invited by Divisional Railway Manager (Electrical Tr.D) Western Railway, Pratap Nagar, Vadodara - 390 004 for the following works. Sr. No: (1) Tender No.: EL/TRD/Tender/26-27/09 Name of work: OHE modification work in connection with Re-spanning and Re-dropping of OHE for the conversion of 1x25 kV OHE to 2x25kV OHE in Surat - Geraipur and Vadodara Godhra section of Vadodara Division. Approximate cost of the work: ₹ 8,97,81,006.00/- Bid Security: ₹ 17,95,600.00/- Cost of Tender documents and completion period: 18 months Tender scheduled on: Tender closing date 18/06/2026 and time of closing at 15-00 hrs. on the same date Web page particulars and notice for location where complete details can be seen & address of the office and clarification: Website www.ireps.gov.in In Divisional Railway Manager (Electrical Tr.D) Western Railway, Pratap Nagar, Vadodara 390004. Like us on: [facebook.com/WesternRly](https://www.facebook.com/WesternRly)

"IMPORTANT"

Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary inquiries before sending any monies or entering into any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

Aligarh Municipal Corporation
E-Procurement Tender Notice

NIT No: 837/NV/NNA/2026-27 Date: 29-08-2025

Aligarh Nagar Nigam Re-invite percentage-rate bids on <http://etender.up.nic.in> from eligible bidders for the following package under the CMGRID Scheme.

Sl. No.	Package No.	Included Roads	Road Length (Km)	Estimated Cost Excluding GST (Rs. Lakh)	Total Estimated Cost of Work Excluding GST (Rs. In Lakh)	Earnest Money Deposit (Rs. In Lakh)	Duration of Construction Work (in Months)	Tender Fee Including GST
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1	ALGC/ MG 24-25/ Pkg. 1	Integrated development and upgrade of the road from Kalidh crematorium to the railway gate via Avtar Nagar.	3.233	4482.40	90.40	4572.80	91.46	12 Month
2	ALGC/ MG 24-25/ Pkg. 2	Integrated development and upgrade of the road from Medical Road Doodpur Road to the Medical College railway gate.	1.150	1804.07	30.29	1834.36	36.69	9 Month
3	ALGC/ MG 24-25/ Pkg. 3	Integrated development and upgrade of the road from Jail Road Bridge to Naya Basti Pokhar, Masoodabad GT Road via Raghuvir Puri Road to Gular Road.	1.070	1570.28	25.51	1595.79	31.92	9 Month
4	ALGC/ MG 24-25/ Pkg. 4	Integrated development and upgrade of the road from Sarai Hamrayan-Sasni Gate intersection to Panchnagari Pokhar	0.880	1091.24	22.23	1113.47	22.27	9 Month

Sr No	Event	Date & Time
5	Availability of tender document on E-Tender portal	From 18/05/2026, 12:00PM
6	Pre-Bid meeting Date & Venue	20/05/2026, 15:00 PM at 3rd floor URIDA, Sector-7, Gomti Nagar Extension, Lucknow -226010
7	Last date of Submission of e-Bids on E- tender Portal	25/05/2026, 17:00 PM
8	Date of Opening of tender	26/05/2026, 11:00 AM

- The Employer has the right to issue addendum /corrigendum as per ITB clause-10 on-line which will not be published in any newspaper. All prospective bidders are advised to keep regular watch and visit e-tender portal regularly.
- For further details please log on to <https://etender.up.nic.in> and download the bid document.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer
Municipal Corporation Aligarh

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

GORKHA RIFLES
No 9431063L Rfn Palden Sherpa of 1/11 Gorkha Rifles (BATALIK) left for heavenly abode in an unfortunate road accident at Barney village, Distt-Jhapa East Nepal on 12 May 2026. The soldier will always be remembered for his valuable service to the nation . To this braveheart we pledge that we shall always be guided by his immortal spirit and will make his name proud.

BORDER SECURITY FORCE
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans on their Balidan Diwas.

HEAD CONSTABLE JAGMOHAN SINGH 15.02.1966 – 19.05.2003	LANCE NAIK E M MANUSWAMY 11.11.1968 – 19.05.1997	CONSTABLE/ TRADESMAN BALKAR SINGH 08.08.1975 – 19.05.1999	CONSTABLE JAVIR SINGH, PPMG 13.06.1976 – 19.05.2004
CONSTABLE OM PRAKASH 08.06.1966 – 19.05.2002	CONSTABLE PRATAP SINGH 11.05.1970 – 19.05.1995	Constable HUKIM SINGH 19.12.1962 – 19.05.1992	CONSTABLE JATINDER KUMAR 09.02.1967 – 19.05.1992

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

Veer Balidani Shri Vijay Pal Singh Dy. Comdt. 66 Bn 16-09-1971 To 19-05-2010	Veer Balidani Head Constable B. L. Santra 66 Bn 22-01-1967 To 19-05-2010	Veer Balidani Constable/Driver Rakesh Kumar 66 Bn 26-08-1978 To 19-05-2010	Veer Balidani Constable D. Ramesh 66 Bn 10-04-1985 To 19-05-2010

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to five bravehearts of 66 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Maoists near Tututala Bridge, PS Lalgarh, West Medinipur, West Bengal on 19 May 2010. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Head Constable Satender Prasad Singh 41 Bn 08-10-1949 To 19-05-2002	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Satender Prasad Singh of 41 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating militants during a track sanitization operation in PS Lolu area, district Doda, Jammu & Kashmir on 19 May 2002. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Suraj Bali Rai 79 Bn 19-07-1952 To 19-05-2002	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Suraj Bali Rai of 79 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating a militant attempting to infiltrate the battalion camp at village Chasan, district Udhampur, Jammu & Kashmir on 19 May 2002. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE No.- T-06-N-2026-27 Date: 15.05.2026
E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (General) N. C. Railway, Agra on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on line only (E-Tendering) for the following works:

Tender No.: T-06-N-2026-27 Approx. Cost of the work: Rs. 1920676.23

Name of work with its location & Completion Period: Electrification work in connection with "Provision of monitoring facility for digital & electronic equipments in LHB & VB coaches and upgradation of staff rooms & existing rooms of DCWTC building at coaching depot, AGC". Completion period: 08 months.

For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. Tenders can only be submitted through web portal www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs. on 12.06.2026. 1118/26 (ADM)

North central railways @ www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPONCR

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E-Tender Notice
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- E-tender No.- 18/EDCC(K)2026-27
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Out-of-sync
Gaikwad's lean
run hurting CSK



CSK skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad laboured to 15 from 21 balls against SRH on Monday. PTI

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, May 18

OFF THE 21st delivery he faced, Ruturaj Gaikwad finally took the aerial route off Pat Cummins. As Eshan Malinga pounced it deep square-leg, and Gaikwad dragged himself off, it felt as if the Chepauk crowd was more relieved than stunned into silence. 15 off 21. No boundary and no six. A strike-rate of 71.42. Opening the batting and returning to the pavilion after 11.3 overs, the numbers said it all.

In a tournament where openers and the top three have set the early pace with quickfire knocks, Gaikwad has been the opposite. His strike-rate of 120.67 is way below what the modern T20 template demands. Chennai Super Kings' opponent on the night, Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH), have at their disposal two openers who strike at 209.13 and 171.09. As the broadcaster put out a graphic, Gaikwad's strike-rate of 125 is the lowest among all openers who have faced a minimum of 200 deliveries this season.

Batsmen enduring a dip in form through the course of the IPL isn't new. CSK have had the habit of carrying them, waiting patiently to turn the corner and have succeeded in it. But in those seasons, they have had other batsmen put their hands up and deliver.

Right through the season, CSK have had the lowest run-rate (8.84). And this despite Samson being at his best and giving them quick starts. While he has continued to embrace a high-risk approach, Gaikwad has been rather timid. Right through IPL 2026, even in conditions that have suited batsmen, Gaikwad has seldom tried to bat in the top gear. If anything, his approach has been measured. Maybe the pressure of leading a franchise that is fighting hard is reflected in the batting. Maybe he doesn't have form by his side. And maybe, all of it is having a collective effect on his batting.

His innings against SRH was one that Gaikwad would want to forget by the time he wakes up on Tuesday. CSK were 17/0 after the first over and 43/1 after three overs. Other batsmen found scoring far easier on the same surface.

Gaikwad grinding at one end meant that batsmen at the other end had to make up. Against an SRH team that bats deep, it was an innings that did no favours to CSK. Wherever they go from here, Chennai have some soul searching to do, and it would have to start with Gaikwad.

INDIAN PREMIER LEAGUE

Kishan & Klaassen take Sunrisers to playoffs, push CSK to brink

After SRH pace attack keeps them to a manageable target, third-wicket stand lays foundation for key victory

SYNOPSIS: Sunrisers Hyderabad beat Chennai Super Kings in Chepauk to make the play-offs, take Gujarat Titans along to the last four.

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, May 18

A CENTRE pitch, already used twice this season. It was a dry and slow surface that promised to bring the spinners into the game. So in a fixture of utmost importance to both Chennai Super Kings and Sunrisers Hyderabad, the conditions weren't going to dictate terms. Ruturaj Gaikwad won the toss and chose to put a total on the board and challenge Hyderabad's gung-ho batting unit to overhaul it.

And Hyderabad responded, showing they are capable of adjusting to different conditions. The 75-run partnership between Ishan Kishan (70 off 47 balls) and Heinrich Klaassen (47 off 26) swung the game Hyderabad's way. Chennai's qualification isn't in their own hands now.

Collective effort

Chennai, for a change, read the conditions well. They didn't try to aim for a 200-plus total and fall for a long way short. Once Sanju Samson provided a rapid start, they paced their innings perfectly with skipper Gaikwad being the lone batter to struggle in the conditions. As has been the case through the season, he had a timid approach in the Powerplay and by the time his innings ended in the 12th over, had only 15 to show off 21 deliveries. It was an innings that forced others to play high-risk

• IPL table						
Teams	M	W	L	P	NRR	
RCB (Q)	13	9	4	18	1.065	
GT (Q)	13	8	5	16	0.400	
SRH (Q)	13	8	5	16	0.350	
PBKS	13	6	6	13	0.227	
RR	12	6	6	12	0.027	
CSK	13	6	7	12	-0.016	
DC	13	6	7	12	-0.871	
KKR	12	5	6	11	-0.038	
MI (E)	12	4	8	8	-0.504	
LSG (E)	12	4	8	8	-0.701	

game on a pitch that seldom encouraged it.

As Chennai paced their innings, due credit had to be given to the Hyderabad attack for not allowing them to run away with the game. Pat Cummins, a master when it comes to reading conditions, showed the way for his young pace pack. Realising the slowness of the pitch and the big boundaries either side, the plan from the SRH bowlers was simple: just keep one side of the wicket in the game.

It wasn't an easy plan to pull off, but the inexperienced pace attack pulled it off admirably well. They bowled short deliveries with pace taken off, as the Chennai batters managed only two boundaries through the mid-wicket region. One that went to fine leg was off a top edge.

Gaikwad's grinding knock aside, it was a collective effort from the Chennai batters that took them to 180/7. None of them had fifties to show, but Samson (27), Kartik Sharma (32), Dewald Brevis (44) and Shivam Dube (26) scored vital runs.

With boundaries and sixes hard to come by, it needed one of them to bring out a high-risk



Ishan Kishan's 47-ball 70 took Sunrisers Hyderabad over the line and into the playoffs. CREIMAS FOR BCCI

Though Klaassen's departure provided Chennai an opening, Kishan ensured there weren't any twists. At one point, he was 32 off 26, but once he settled, he didn't hold back.

approach and providing it were Kartik and Brevis. Walking in at No.4 when Hyderabad had the upper hand, Kartik's cameo provided momentum. And once he was dismissed, Brevis took over that role. He looked set for a big one until Eshan Malinga's reverse-swinging delivery rattled his stumps.

Plan B for Hyderabad

During the innings break with giant ropes staying off sight, it was evident the conditions were only going to get slower. Under the circum-

stances, Abhishek Sharma and Travis Head could have given Hyderabad an early advantage. But the Aussie departed in the third over for 6 and Abhishek, despite finding three boundaries and a six in his stay of 21 deliveries, struggled for tempo before falling to Akeal Hosein.

That dismissal brought together Kishan and Klaassen. When the South African walked into the middle in the eighth over, the run rate was hovering around 7.5 and at the half-way mark, Hyderabad had 75/2. For them to cross the line, they needed one of the two to play an innings that defied the conditions. And with Kishan finding the perfect tempo in the middle, it was Klaassen who played the knock that proved to be the difference. Dropped on 18 by Spencer Johnson, he scored at a strike rate of 180.76 and gave Hyderabad the required impetus.

Unlike the Hyderabad attack, which read the conditions

and bowled cutters, Chennai's attack didn't show any of that creativity. Despite the slowness of the surface, they seemed content to stick to their strengths and paid the price. Klaassen, amongst the most consistent performers in this season, came to the party again.

Though his departure provided Chennai an opening, Kishan ensured there weren't any twists. At one point, he was 32 off 26, struggling to get used to the pace of the pitch. But once he settled, he didn't hold back. If Chennai tried to deny him anything in his swinging arc, he was happy to play them safely. And when Hyderabad needed him to show the way, he was in absolute command. He couldn't stay till the end, but had done his job.

BRIEF SCORES: Chennai Super Kings 180/7 in 20 overs (Brevis 44; Cummins 3/28, Sakib 2/34) lost to **Sunrisers Hyderabad** 181/5 in 19 overs (Ishan 70, Klaassen 47; Mukesh 2/36) by five wickets.

Big Bash comes to India: Chennai set to host opener in Dec

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, May 18

BIG BASH is heading to India. Chennai's MA Chidambaram Stadium is set to host the opening game of the new BBL season starting in the second week of December 2026, with Cricket Australia having received encouraging signals from the Board of Control for Cricket in India after months of talks.

Over the past three months, CA has been exploring the possibility of hosting the BBL opener in India. The BCCI was initially not receptive, but after further discussions CA is understood to have received positive news from their Indian counterparts. A five-member CA delegation has since flown to



The MA Chidambaram Stadium is set to host the opener of Australia's Big Bash League later this year. CREIMAS FOR BCCI

Chennai for CSK's final IPL home game to recce the stadium.

A CA representative declined to confirm the development but acknowledged the

conversations.

"We are not able to confirm anything. We are exploring the potential of Chennai in partnership with the Australian Government to deepen the

Over the past three months, CA has been exploring the possibility of hosting the BBL opener in India. A five-member delegation has since flown to Chennai to recce the stadium.

India-Australia relationship. Nothing confirmed as yet and we are working closely with our friends in BCCI," the representative said.

BCCI president Mithun Manhas was also in Chennai to meet the CA delegation, as were representatives from the Australian trade community. Ever since CA decided to take

the BBL opener overseas, Chennai had been their first-choice venue, with talks running in parallel with the local Tamil Nadu Cricket Association.

While early discussions had floated the possibility of hosting more than one match, scheduling constraints mean it is likely to be just the opener - which could feature defending champions Perth Scorchers.

The December timing carries complications. Chennai's peak monsoon season runs through that month, a factor both boards will need to navigate.

Last year, R Ashwin had signed with Sydney Thunder and was set to become the first Indian to feature in the BBL before injury ruled him out.

Job's not over: De Zerbi on Spurs' survival

Reuters
London, May 18

TOTTENHAM HOTSPUR'S Premier League survival path suddenly looks a lot less treacherous as they head to Stamford Bridge to face Chelsea on Tuesday but manager Roberto De Zerbi says his rescue mission is far from complete. The Italian has overseen an upswing in results since being appointed in March with Tottenham taking eight points from a possible 15 to climb out of the bottom three.

West Ham United's 3-1 defeat at Newcastle United on Sunday means Tottenham will be mathematically safe from a first relegation since 1977 if they take two points from their final two games, away to Chelsea and at home to Everton.

Even a draw at Chelsea would all but guarantee Tottenham's survival as that would put them three points clear of West Ham with one

game left and with a far superior goal difference.

"Now we have to reach the target and to make another result. We have to play another two games," De Zerbi told reporters at Tottenham's training ground on Monday. "It is not finished yet. We have to make a point in the Premier League and especially in the Premier League, to make one point you have to fight and play very well. We have to keep focused on the game and then we can answer and make a big press conference (about what went wrong this season). Now is not the right time."

De Zerbi will have first-choice goalkeeper Guglielmo Vicario available again for the last two games although hinted that he will remain faithful to Antonio Kinsky. Playmaker James Maddison could also play some part after returning off the bench against Leeds United last week but striker Dominic Solanke will miss out.

• CHESS IN BED

Alireza forced to play from hotel room after rolling ankle

Amit Kamath
Mumbai, May 18

IT FELT like a return to the work-from-home era during the coronavirus pandemic. When French grandmaster Alireza Firouzja rolled over his ankle after his third round game at the Super Chess Classic 2026 tournament in Bucharest, organisers of the Grand Chess Tour knew they would have to get creative if they wanted to ensure his continued participation in the remaining rounds of the classical tournament in the Romanian capital.

So, they came up with a never-before-seen solution: Alireza was asked to play from a bed in a hotel room with his opponent sitting across a physical board and an arbiter designated in the room to keep a mindful eye on them. The organisers were unable to set up cameras in the room on time, which meant that only the board's live transmission was

available. Visuals of Alireza facing Javokhir Sindarov in the room were not seen.

Despite being in crippling pain, Alireza managed to hold the Uzbekistan grandmaster to a draw on a day when all five contests ended in stalemates.

"After the third round, Alireza suffered an ankle injury. Fortunately, the ankle was not broken or fractured. After consulting with his team and the tournament organisers, he has decided to continue the tournament in a special room with the agreement of his opponents and the presence of an arbiter," veteran grandmaster Yasser Seirawan announced on the live broadcast before the start of round 5 of the tournament. "We are thrilled that Alireza remains in the tournament and is willing to continue to play."

The ankle injury meant that Alireza had to skip his fourth round game against American grandmaster Fabiano Caruana. But the organisers, considerate



Alireza Firouzja (L) faces Javokhir Sindarov in his hotel room bed after injuring his ankle at the Super Chess Classic 2026 tournament in Bucharest on Monday. GRAND CHESS TOUR/ LENNART OOTES

of the physical injury that prevented the youngster from playing, have also allowed Alireza to face Caruana in a game on Tuesday, when the rest of the players will have a rest day.

Alireza's draw with Sindarov meant that he ended the fifth round with a single point to his name and marooned at

last spot in the 10-player standings, with one game left to play. Sindarov, who was in red-hot form at the Candidates tournament, sweeping to the title with an unbeaten run in 14 games, has had a wretched run in Romania, going winless in five rounds.

India's R Praggnanandhaa continued his own streak of

• BRIEFLY



Mushfiquur Rahim hit his 14th Test century on Monday. AP/FILE

Mushfiquur inspires Bangladesh to set 437-run target in 2nd Test

MUSHFIQUR RAHIM hit a record-breaking century as Bangladesh set Pakistan a daunting 437 runs for victory in the second cricket test on Monday. Rahim struck a superb 137 off 233, smashing 12 fours and one six to help Bangladesh post 390 in the second innings. Litton Das, followed his first-innings 126 with an elegant 69. **AP BRIEF SCORES: Pakistan** 232 and 0 for 0 in 2 overs trail **Bangladesh** 278 and 390 (Mushfiquur 137, Litton 69, Shahzad 4-86, Sajid 3-126) by 436 runs.

CIC rules BCCI outside RTI ambit

THE CENTRAL Information Commission has ruled that the Board of Control for Cricket in India does not qualify as a "public authority" under the Right to Information Act, effectively keeping the world's richest cricket board beyond the reach of transparency laws that apply to government bodies. The order reverses a 2018 ruling that held that the BCCI was a public authority and directed it to set up mechanisms for receiving RTI applications. ENS

India U-18 beat Australia 6-3, level series

A CLINICAL Indian U-18 men's hockey team bounced back to register a commanding 6-3 victory over their Australian counterparts in the third match of the series at the Udhav Das Mehta (Bhai Ji) Central SAI Centre. With this win, the hosts have levelled the four-match series 1-1. India held the Aussies to a 2-2 draw in the series opener before losing the second match 1-3 on Sunday. India took early control of the match with a blistering first-half performance. PTI

Indian shuttlers seek revenge against French

A FRESH India-versus-France battle awaits in the men's singles competition and the Indian shuttlers will look to avenge their recent Thomas Cup semifinal defeat when the Malaysia Masters Super 500 tournament begins on Tuesday. India had won a bronze medal after suffering a 0-3 loss to France in the Thomas Cup semifinals in Horsens, Denmark earlier this month, losing all three singles matches. PTI

Jennifer Paes, Leander's mom, dies at 72

FORMER INDIA basketball captain and Olympian Jennifer Paes, mother of tennis legend Leander Paes, passed away on Sunday after a prolonged battle with cancer. She was 72. "She was terminally ill cancer patient and passed away on Sunday. The funeral service was held today at St Thomas Church in Kolkata," a family source said. Jennifer represented India in basketball at the 1972 Munich Olympics and later captained the national team. PTI

Pak ready to take on India in Pro League: Butt

PAKISTAN MEN'S hockey team captain Ammad Sha-keel Butt is ready to take on arch-rivals India in the upcoming FIH Pro League and the 2026 Hockey World Cup in Belgium and The Netherlands. "We have not been able to produce good results against India in a while now so this time we are preparing hard because if we can beat them it will give us a lot of confidence," he said. India and Pakistan will play twice in the fourth phase of the FIH Pro League. PTI

Kerala Blasters sign off with win over FC Goa

KERALA BLASTERS FC ended their Indian Super League (ISL) campaign on a high with a 2-1 victory against FC Goa on Monday. Goals from Kevin Yoke (48th) and Fallou Ndiaye (81st) secured all three points for the hosts, while Mohammed Nemil (62nd) scored for FC Goa in an evenly contested match. The victory extended Kerala Blasters' unbeaten run to six matches and saw them finish eighth with 17 points from 13 matches. PTI

FIFA media rights officials visit India amid no WC broadcast deal



FIFA is yet to close a broadcasting deal in India with less than a month to go for the World Cup 2026. REUTERS

Reuters
New Delhi, May 18

FIFA MEDIA rights officials are visiting India this week, three sources said, ahead of next month's World Cup for which soccer's ruling body has not struck a broadcast deal with India due to differences over pricing.

Millions of soccer fans in India risk not being able to watch the tournament due to a deadlock over broadcast rights. China Media Group, the parent of China's state broadcaster, agreed a World Cup broadcasting deal last week to end a standoff over TV rights there.

The three sources familiar with FIFA's plans said the media rights executives are in India, though details of who they are meeting and the exact agenda were not clear.

Ongoing talks

In a statement to Reuters, FIFA said it concluded agreements with broadcasters in over 180 territories and discussions in India regarding the sale of media rights were ongoing and "must remain confidential at this stage".

Discussions between the Reliance-Disney joint venture, India's biggest media company and FIFA have not materialised, and Sony, another big player, has refrained from bidding, Reuters has previously reported. Reliance-Disney joint venture offered \$20 million for the FIFA rights. That led to a disagreement because FIFA had initially sought \$100 million but was last looking for around \$60 million at least, Reuters has reported.

It is not clear if FIFA is meeting with Reliance-Disney joint venture. The venture, led by billionaire Mukesh Ambani's Reliance, declined to comment.

The World Cup kicks off on June 11, leaving only three weeks for a deal to be finalised, broadcast infrastructure to be set up and advertising inventory to be sold.

With about 85 million fans, soccer is popular in India but lags behind cricket which has 492 million fans, according to a 2024 report from Deloitte and Google.

India accounted for 2.9% of the global linear TV reach at the 2022 World Cup.

INDIAN-ORIGIN GOLFER WINS A MAJOR

Born with golden swing, Rai ends English drought at PGA

Born to parents of Indian roots from England, Kenya, Aaron becomes first British to win PGA title after 1919

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, May 18

ON LATE Sunday night, 31-year-old Indian-origin golfer Aaron Rai became the first Englishman to win the PGA Championship in the stroke play era and became only the second-ever Indian-origin golfer after two-time Major winner Vijay Singh to achieve the feat. His overall score of 9-under-271 and the fateful lifting of the Wanamaker Trophy came under the watchful eyes of his father Amrik Singh and wife, Indian professional golfer Gaurika Bishnoi.

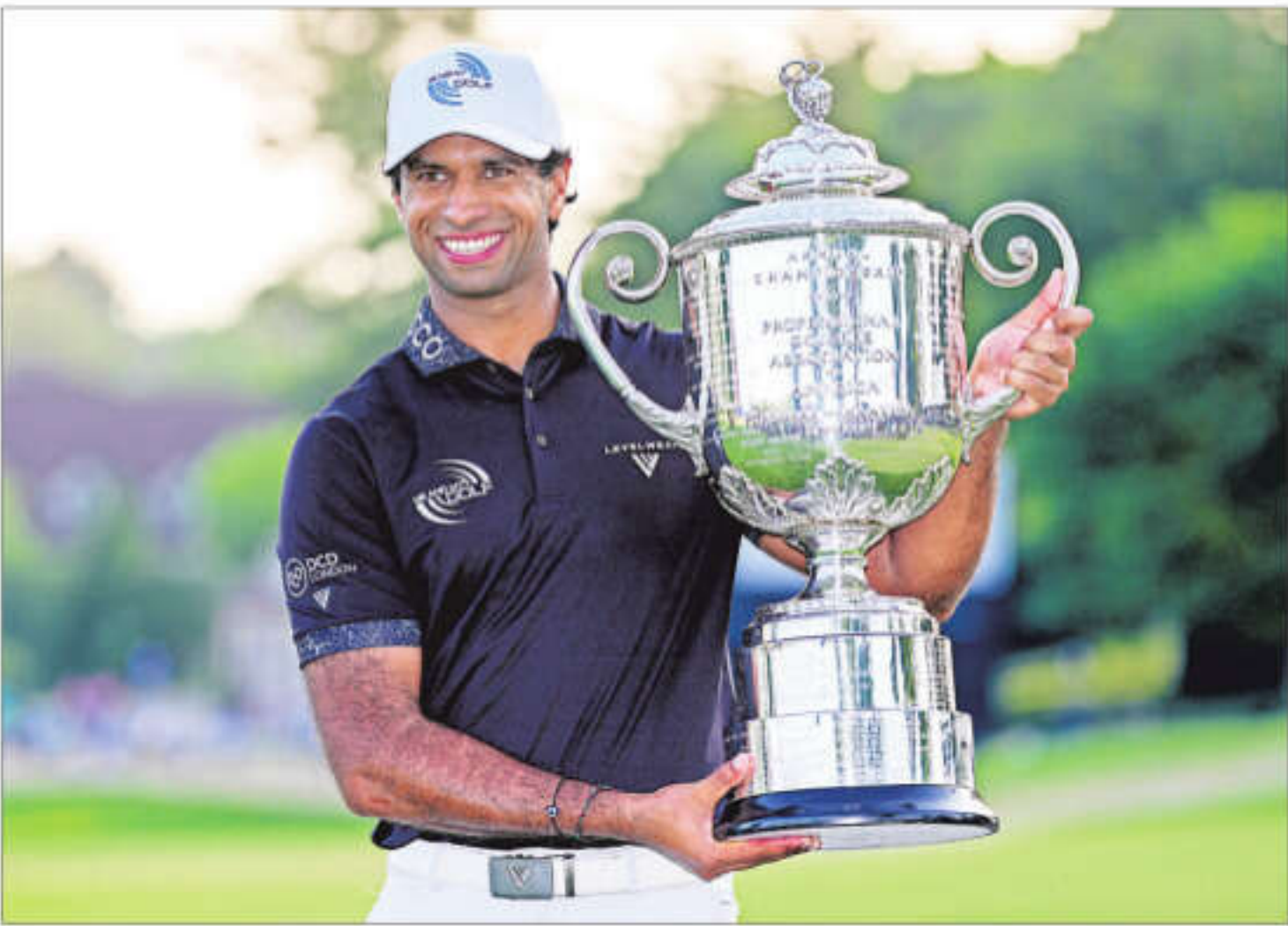
"*Asi sare jane Aaron layi cheer kar rahe si* (We all were awake and cheering for Aaron). While his mother is in Kenya with Aaron's sister, his father Amrik was cheering for him from the stands. My other nephew and niece were here in Wolverhampton and it was a surreal feeling to watch Aaron lift the trophy with his name inscribed on the trophy, which has names like Tiger Woods and other greats on it," shared Kuldip Chana, elder maternal aunt of Aaron while speaking to *The Indian Express* from Wolverhampton.

Aaron's father worked as a professor in Perton, Wolverhampton and mother Dalvir Shukla as a medical nurse. Evenings were spent watching his brother and cousins play cricket before his parents introduced plastic clubs to the then four-year-old. With two golf clubs near their residence,

Aaron's father worked as a professor in Perton, Wolverhampton and mother Dalvir Shukla as a medical nurse.

Amrik would take Aaron to the clubs as well as East Park before getting him enrolled at the 3 Hammer Golf Club. Chana recalled the time when her brother-in-law would talk about his son's golf swing and would tell her that he would support the youngster in his dreams. "Our homes are near and I remember Aaron was four years old when Amrik paji and my sister got him his first pair of plastic clubs. I guess he still used to wear nappies when we used to take him to East Park (laughs). But when Aaron started playing golf at the golf clubs, Amrik paji would tell me, "*Behenji* (sister), you look at Aaron's golf swing!". Later when one of the parents left the job to support Aaron's game, we all understood. Yes, it was tough but then it was all for their son's dream," adds Chana.

Aaron, who first played in a major at the 2017 US Open, spoke about the challenges faced by his family and how it taught him to be humble. "My dad was with me, as I said, every day, practice wise, and he really instilled the importance of work and dedication and trying to consistently build just good,



Aaron Rai with the Wanamaker Trophy after winning PGA Championship. ASSOCIATED PRESS

strong habits around the game. My mom worked extremely hard away from golf. She worked a couple of jobs at one time and she did a lot of work around the house. My sister took a massive role as well at a young age. She had a job from the age of 14, 15, so there was a lot of consistent messaging of hard work. I guess as I've got older, it's something that I've really valued," Aaron said on Sunday.

In Wolverhampton, coach Darren Prosser, a former pro and one of Aaron's first coaches, too was watching him win the PGA Championships. While Aaron now trains under Andy Proudman and Piers Ward, Prosser has seen him up close. "He was seven years old when he came to the 3 Hammer course. And we used to do some lessons and then play on the

par-three course. His father Amrik had been his support since day one. Aaron had a textbook swing and he had a great way of getting the club on the ball. He had great hand-eye coordination and he could really work the ball. He hasn't got many weaknesses in his golf game and he's suited for a technical course like it was the last night at Aronimink," said Prosser to *The Indian Express*.

Aaron also spoke about what the win means for England as well India and Kenya. "I am very proud to be from England. That's where I grew up. That's where a lot of my family still lives. I'm very proud of India and Kenya as well. My mom grew up there (Kenya), and my mom's side of the family lived there for a number of years before they moved to

England. And again, going back a couple of generations, both of my sets of grandparents from my mom and dad's side, were from India. So again, I'm just very proud of representing all three," Aaron said.

As for in Wolverhampton, coach Prosser is waiting for his ward to return and give a coaching clinic to the kids. "Post one of his title wins, he had attended a golf clinic and signed for the kids. Hopefully, we will soon have him at our club," said Prosser. At the Guru ka Niwas Gurudwara in Wolverhampton, which the family attends, secretary Sukhjinder Singh is preparing a path for Aaron. "*Sada sareya da puttara hai. Asi vi path karange.* (Aaron is a son of us all too. We will recite hymns for him and his success)," said Singh.

Delhi HC asks for reply; Vinesh's Asian Games hopes dashed



Vinesh Phogat's decision to come back to competitive wrestling has faced multiple hurdles including WFI's show cause notice. FILE

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, May 18

WITH NO immediate relief from the Delhi High Court on Monday, two-time World Championships bronze medalist and Olympian wrestler Vinesh Phogat's chances to appear at the Asian Games this year stands dashed. The selection trials for the 2026 Asian Games are scheduled to be held on May 30 and 31, with the tournament scheduled for September-October this year.

Fresh petition

Phogat, in a fresh petition before the Delhi HC, has emphasised that the WFI's selection criteria "are arbitrary in design and discriminatory in effect including being contrary to past practice", and has highlighted that the qualification window chosen by WFI "substantially overlapped" with Phogat's notified "sabbatical, return-to-training period, pregnancy-related break, and post-partum recovery."

Senior advocate Rajshekh Rao, representing Phogat, told Justice Purushendra Kaurav on Monday, "The larger question is this: this is not a case where I disappeared. I was on maternity leave. I got a show cause notice which effectively said I do not satisfy criteria. Internationally today, if a female athlete takes a maternity break, she comes back, she has to go through a waiting process, but her ranking or her status is protected. Now the policy introduced in 2026 (by WFI) suggests that if you don't play in the last one year, I'll not even consider you. I'm allowed by the international federation to participate, but today the local criteria is to exclude me."

Justice Kaurav however orally remarked, "If that is the policy, it will have to be looked into...let them (WFI) file reply." While Rao requested that she be allowed to participate in the upcoming selection trials, so as to balance equities and subject to the final outcome of the petition, the court orally opined that it needs to hear both sides and that the court will have to examine the policy first before grant of any such reliefs in favour of Phogat.

The court issued notice to WFI, Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, and the Indian Olympic Association, and has directed the parties to file their response with respect to the contentions being raised by Phogat, as well as a rejoinder by Phogat thereafter.

The court will hear the matter on July 6.

pating. The May 6 circular, issued specifically for selection trials for the 2026 Asian Games, also mandated medal wins in 2025 or 2026, additionally clarifying that "past performance will not be considered."

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Meet Kumkum: Girl with second-hand bow but big dreams

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, May 18

ANIL MANOHAR Mohod makes cardboard boxes for sweet shops in Amravati. It is how the family gets by. More than a week after his 17-year-old daughter Kumkum won the women's team gold at the Archery World Cup Stage 2 in Shanghai - India's first women's team gold since 2021 - Mohod had another reason to celebrate.

Kumkum had finished in the top three women recurve archers at the final Asian Games trials in Sonapat on Monday, alongside Kirti Sharma and Ankita Bhakat. Four-time Olympian Deepika Kumari finished fourth and missed the cut. Mohod picked up the phone and called Raghuvir Mithaiyan, one of his clients, to order sweet boxes. Not to deliver them. To receive them.

"Sweet boxes *banane se hi ghar chalta hai aur Kumkum*

ki archery bhi (It is the sweet boxes that run our home, and so does Kumkum's archery)," he told *The Indian Express*. "She was shooting in Shanghai with a second-hand bow, which she has been using for the last five years. And when she won the team gold, I called Raghuvir Mithaiyan - for whom I once made boxes - to order sweets to celebrate. Today also, while I am on my way back to Amravati, I will call him for sweets."

The bow is five years old - the second second-hand bow Kumkum has used since she started the sport in 2018. The first was wooden, bought with Rs 3,000 given by her grandmother. Six months after picking it up, she won a silver at the sub-junior nationals. When Kumkum came under the Khelo India scheme, her father drove her to training on his motorcycle - the shared auto had cost Rs 5,000 a month, and when the other children



Kumkum Anil Mohod in action during Archery WC. WORLD ARCHERY

dropped out, the family could no longer split the fare.

"Yes, it's tough," Anil says. "But if we cannot make sacrifices for her, who else will."

It was her mother Rupali who had started it all. In 2018, a relative's daughter had taken up archery at coach Prafull Dange's Radhey Archery Academy in Amravati. Rupali insisted - their

only child would try it too. Dange saw something.

"When she came to train under me, I was impressed with her stubbornness to learn. Her upper body strength, her shoulder position - Kumkum learnt very quickly. During Covid, we worked on short-distance shooting, something most archers avoid. It helped her use her back muscles to draw the bow automatically,"

The rise has been steady. Last year's nationals brought a bronze with the Maharashtra team. Against Korea in the semi-final, Kumkum shot an average of 9.5 as India won 5-1 - only the fourth time the Indian team has defeated them. In the final against China, her average was 9.22, matching Deepika Kumari. When it came to the deciding shoot-off, she shot a ten.

At the trials in Sonapat, she topped qualification, won six matches in the second stage and finished second behind

Kirti Sharma. Deepika Kumari finished fourth and missed the Asian Games berth.

"This medal is a new start for me. A bow is a bow only and we have to shoot arrows. Apne par confidence aur ability par hi sab kuch matter karta hai (It all depends on one's confidence and ability)," Kumkum told this paper last week.

Taking a train to Amravati from Delhi on Monday, Anil Mohod is already thinking about the next call. "With every medal or selection, I have to call my old clients to order sweets," he says, and laughs.

INDIAN ARCHERY TEAM FOR ASIAN GAMES - Recurve: Men: Dhiraj Bommadevara, Neeraj Chauhan, Yashdeep Bhogee; Women: Kirti Sharma, Kumkum Mohod, Ankita Bhakat; **Compound:** Men: Sahil Jadhav, Kushal Dalal, Thirumuru Ganesh; Women: Jyothi Surekha Vennam, Taniparthi Chikitha, Prithika Pardeep.

Iran arrives in Turkey amid WC uncertainty

Reuters
Antalya, May 18

IRAN'S NATIONAL soccer squad landed in Turkey for a training camp on Monday ahead of their planned trip to the U.S. for the World Cup, with uncertainty still hanging over the team's participation after the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran in late February.

FIFA Secretary-General Matthias Graßmorn told Reuters on Saturday that he held a constructive and positive meeting with Iran's FA (FFIRI) President Mehdi Taj, expressing confidence about the country's participation in the World Cup.

The players and officials filed out of Antalya Airport in black team outfits, many pulling black suitscases, before heading to waiting buses to travel to their hotel at the training base in the nearby resort of Belek, where several national teams have held camps in recent years.

Iran are scheduled to play all three group matches in the United States but the team's participation in the June 11 to July 19 tournament has been in question since the attacks by the U.S. and Israel.

Iranian officials and FIFA have said U.S. visa applications for the team would be handled in Turkey. Uncertainty over the visas was fuelled after FFIRI's Taj was refused entry to Canada for the FIFA Congress in Vancouver this month because of his links to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC).

The U.S. and Canada, who are co-hosting the World Cup with Mexico, classify the IRGC as a "terrorist entity" and have made clear they will not admit people with links to the elite military force.

Switching venues

Iran had asked for their World Cup matches to be switched to Mexico but FIFA President Gianni Infantino insists that all games must be played at the grounds originally scheduled.

Iran's squad is scheduled to move to their U.S. base at the Kino Sports Complex in Tucson, Arizona in early June.

Iran are scheduled to get their World Cup campaign under way against New Zealand in Los Angeles on June 15. They are also due to play Belgium and Egypt in Group G.

INDIA V FOREIGN COACH DEBATE

Sreejesh's right role is in grooming young goalkeepers

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, May 18

PR SREEJESH'S desire to become a coach came from the right place. A modern-day great, the former goalkeeper had learnt the sport a certain way, only to realise midway through his career that much of what he had been taught was completely out of sync with global trends.

For instance, he was told to keep his palms open, chest high and constantly move inside the goal. Modern goalkeeping, he discovered during tours of Europe, was almost the opposite: Stay still, ration movement, react late. "We never had former goalkeepers who learnt modern techniques and imparted them to us," he had once said.

After the 2012 London Olympics, Sreejesh did two things — first, he re-learned goalkeeping from scratch; then, he resolved that the next generation of Indian goalkeepers would not face the same hurdles he did.

In his head, there was never any doubt that coaching would be his Plan A after retirement.

Last week, that plan re-

ceived a jolt.

Sreejesh alleged that on the insistence of current men's senior team head coach Craig Fulton, Hockey India replaced him as the junior team coach with a foreigner. Hockey India swiftly denied the claims, and in the following days, named Frenchman Frederic Soye as his successor.

The instinctive reaction would be to point fingers at Hockey India for treating a legend unfairly. But there are many layers to this saga.

The first, where Hockey India can be rightly questioned, is Sreejesh's appointment itself. At the Paris Olympics, the Indian players hadn't even received their medals when Hockey India informally announced that Sreejesh would take charge as the junior coach. The decision seemed to be based on emotion rather than long-term strategy.

If other candidates were shortlisted or interviewed, if Sreejesh himself was interviewed, or whether Fulton had any say given the junior team acts as a feeder to the senior squad, isn't known.

The appointment, though,



PR Sreejesh during a training session with Junior team. HOCKEY INDIA

was puzzling because Sreejesh was parachuted as the under-21 coach without any solid prior experience, or him attaining any formal coaching credentials like so many other Indians aspiring to manage the national side. This was also unlike other Indian stalwarts like Sardar Singh or Rani Rampal, who started with under-18 players, the lowest age-group. Sardar even went to the Netherlands, where he observed and picked finer nuances of coaching youth sides.

That's the global norm. Even football legend Zinedine

Zidane had to work his way up the Real Madrid system and coach the age-group sides before taking over as manager of the club. A former player of stature can succeed as a coach in cricket, but in sports like hockey and football, it's essential to learn the ropes before diving in.

Sreejesh's stature was his biggest qualification. In his lengthy tirade, he mentioned how he was sidelined despite leading the junior India team to five podium finishes, including a bronze medal at the 2025 Junior World Cup.

But the correct parameter for age-group teams isn't the number of medals they win, but how the players develop technically, tactically and mentally. The job of the junior team coach is to provide a seamless pathway that allows young players to transition smoothly to the senior squad. But only three players from the 2025 Junior World Cup have made the current core group of 36.

It is hard to fault Hockey India for turning to a foreign coach once again. And if Fulton indeed pushed for a foreigner — an unsubstantiated claim — it's to align the junior set-up with the senior team's tactical philosophy.

India desperately needs to broad-base its player pool in the next two years, given that a bunch of players who led the revival from the Tokyo Olympics are expected to hang their boots. That's where Sreejesh's successor, Soye, comes in. He has a reputation of integrating systems that link grassroots hockey, under-18 and under-23 teams, to senior sides. His astute penalty corner strategies and defensive systems made teams like Spain and France punch

well above their weight.

There is no doubt that at some point, India will have to reduce its dependency on foreign coaches and create a robust pipeline for homegrown tacticians. Importing expertise every Olympic cycle isn't sustainable. But an Indian passport cannot be a qualification in itself.

Equally, Sreejesh must recognise that not renewing his contract, and offering him other options such as goalkeeping coach, is not necessarily a slight on his credentials, or a 'demotion', as he sees it. Coaching careers, especially at the elite level, are usually built in stages.

Sreejesh is right to reject Hockey India's offer to take over the development team; it has been a non-serious project with very little thought or planning. But Sreejesh, evidently hurt, should not see a goalkeeping coach role as a 'demotion'.

Two years after his retirement, India still hasn't found a goalkeeper of his class. Perhaps, the best way to honour his legacy is to let him shape the next generation of goalkeepers — the very support system he never had growing up.